works—Barāha Purāṇa, Padya Purāṇa, Ādi Purāṇa, Vrahmānda Purāṇa, Skanda Purāṇa, Saura Purāṇa, Çrimat Bhāgavata, Laghu Tosinī, Govinda Virudāvalī, Gourganoddeça Dīpikā, Sādhanā Dīpikā, Nava Padma, Gopāl Champu, Laghu Bhāgavata, Chaitanya Chandrodaya Nātaka, Vrajavilāsa, Bhatti Kāvya, Bhaktiratnāmṛita Sindhu, Kṛṣiṅa Charita by Murāri Gupta, Ujjval Nilamani, Govarddhanāçraya, Haribhaktivilāsa, Stavamālā, Sangita Mādhava, Vaiṣṅavatosinī, Çyāmānanda Çataka, Mathurā Khanda.

Premavilāsa.

Premavilāsa by Nityānanda Dās. This is also a voluminous work divided into 20 cantos. It was written during the early part of the 17th century. Nityānanda's father Ātmā Rāma Dās belonged to a Vaidya family of Çrikhanda. The work under notice mainly treats of the lives of Çrīnivāsa and Çyāmānanda.

Karṅāmṛita.

Karṅāmṛitā by Jadunandana Dās. The author was a disciple of Çrīmati Hemalatā Devi, a daughter of Çrīnivāsa. Karṇāmṛita gives a full account of Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya's life together with a short account of the lives of his disciples. The work was written in 1607 A.D.

Vaṁcīçikṣā.

Vaṁçī Çikṣā by Purusottama Siddhānta Vāgīça. This book, while giving an account of Chaitanya's renunciation, mainly deals with the life of Vaṁçi Dās Thākura, one of Chaitanyās companions. It was written in 1716 A. D.

Rasika-Maṅgala.

Rasika Maṅgala or the Life of Rasikānanda by Gopivallabha Dās. Rasikānanda was the son of Rājā Achyutānanda and was born in 1590 A. D. He was one of the greatest disciples of Çyāmā-

nanda and took a zealous interest in the propagation of the Vaiṣṅāva-cult in Orissa. The author was a contemporary of the subject of his memoir. This work is important, as it throws light on the history of Orissa of that period. It describes how Rājā Vaidyānāth Bhanja (of Mayur Bhanja) was converted to the Vaiṣṅava faith and also gives an account of the great Vaiṣṅava festivals that took place in the villages of Verākuli and Alamaganja in the district of Midnapur.

Mano-santoṣinī.

Mana Santoṣinī by Jagajivana Miçra. The author was a descendent, by another line, of Upendra Miçra, an ancestor of Chaitanya Deva. The work gives a description of Chaitanya's travels in Sylhet and other parts of Eastern Bengal.

And other works.

Besides these works we have come across a Chaitanya Charita by Chuḍāmani Dās, Nimāi Sanyāsa by Çankara Bhatta, Sitā Charita by Lokānatha Dās, Mahāprasāda Vaibhava, Chaitanya ganoddeça, Vaiṣṅavāchārā Darpaṅa and other works which describe incidents in the lives of Vaiṣṅava worthies.

Theological works of the Vaiṣṅavas.

We shall here briefly notice some of the works which are of a more or less theological character, in which the principles of Vaiṣṇavism are explained as it found favour in Bengal. On page 46 we mentioned a number of books written by the Sahajiyā Vaiṣṅavas. I give below a list of other works on Vaiṣṅava theology. Most of the important theological works of the Vaiṣṅavas are written in Sanskrit. So they do not fall within the scope of my subject. The books mentioned below, written in Bengali, are generally small treatises and

their composition covers a period of 300 years from after the time Chaitanya Deva till the middle of the 18th Century.

1. Bhaktirasātmikā by Akinchana Dās
2. Gopibhaktirasa gītā by Achyuta Das

The book contains 2,100 couplets.

3. Rasa Çudharnava by Ānanda Dās
4. Ātmatattva Jigmāsā
5. Pāsanda Dalana
6. Chamatkāra Chandrikā
7. Gurutattva
8. Prema Bhaktisāra by Gaur Dās Vasu
9. Golokvarṇana by Gopāla Bhatta.
10. Harinmāma Kavacha by Gopi Kriṣṅa. It contains 158 couplets.
11. Siddhisāra by Gopināth Dās (18 couplets).
12. Nigama Grantha by Govinda Dās
13. Premabhakti Chandrikā by Narottama Dās. The writer is one of the great Vaiṣṅava masters about whom we have already written in some detail. The work under notice, though small in size, enjoys a great popularity with the Vaiṣṅavas and is permeated by a devotional spirit.
14. Rāgamayī Kaṇa by Nityananda Dās.
15. Upasanā Patala by Prema Dās.
16. Manaçiksā by Premānanda.
17. Astottara Çatanāma by Dvija Hari Dās,

18. Vaiṣṇavābhidhāna by Valarāma Dās.
19. Hāṭa Vandanā by Valarāma Dās.
20. Premavilāsa by Jugala Kiçora Dās.
21. Rasakalpa tattvasāra by Radhā Mohana Dās.
22. Chaitanya Tattvasāra by Rama Gopala Dās.
23. Siddhanta Chandrikā by Rama Chandra Dās.
24. Smaraṇa Darpaṇa by Rama Chandra Dās.
25. Kriyāyogasāra by Anantarama Datta. The author was born at Sāhapur on the Meghna. His father's name was Raghunātha Datta. The book contains 4000 couplets.
26. Kriāyogasāra by Rameçvara Dās.
27. Chaitanya Premavilāsa (100 couplets).
28. Durlabhasāra (950 couplets).
29. Dehanirupaṅa (100 couplets).
30. Anandalatikā (100 couplets).

By Lochana Dās born in 1523 A.D.

31. Bhaktichintamaṇi
32. Bhaktimahatma
33. Bhaktilaksmana
34. Bhaktisādhana

By Vṛindavana Dās.

35. Vṛindavana Lilāmrita
36. Rasapuspa Kalikā

By Nanda Kiçora Dās

37. Prema Dāvānala by Narasimha Dās.
38. Gokula Maṅgala by Bhaktirama Dās.
39. Rādhā Vilāsa by Bhavāni Dāsa.
40. Ekādaçi Mahātma by Mahidhara Dās.
41. Krisṅa Lilamṛita by Valarama Dās.

V. The Padas or Songs of the Vaiṣṅavas.

The lyrics of the Vaiṣṅava poets, known as Padas, form by far the most important and most interesting page in the history of Vaiṣṅava literature.

The subject of the Padas.

These Padas are divided into several groups. They all relate events and incidents in the life of Kriṣṅa in Vṛindāvana. The pastoral scenes, and gatherings of shepherd-boys, the playful ways of Kriṣṅa in his home,—the manner in which he baffled king Kaṁsa's attempts to kill him, by destroying his great demons, who were one by one deputed to kill him,—his love for Rādhā, the princess, and his final departure from Vṛindāvana and arrival at Mathurā, where he overthrows and kills Kaṁsa—have all been fully described in the Bhāgabata, to which we have already referred on page 220. A short account of Kriṣṅa's life at Vṛindāvana and Mathurā will enable our readers to enter into the spirit of the songs of the Vaiṣṅava poets.

Kaṁsa, King of Mathurā.

Kaṁsa, King of Mathurā, had achieved notoriety by oppressing his people. It was then vouchsafed by Viṣṅu to the goddess of Earth, who groaned under the king's oppressions, that He would Himself be incarnated in the flesh as a son of Daivakī, sister of Kaṁsa, with the object of destroying the ruthless monarch, who with his emissaries was devastating the earth. The message of the coming divine incarnation spread throughout heaven and caused great joy amongst the gods, so that Kaṁsa also heard of it. For Nārada, the heavenly sage, came to him and said that the eighth child of Daivakī, his sister, would be that incarnation of

Viṣṅu, whose first mission would to be to kill him and then destroy other oppressors of the world.

The prophecy alarmed Kaṁsa who immediately put Daivakī and her husband Vāsudeva in prison and ordered that all children born to her should be killed; for his ministers advised him that the prophecy of Nārada was ambiguous in its meaning as it was not clear what was meant by the eighth child;—supposing that Daivakī should have twelve children, then counting from the last, the fourth according to ordinary calculation would be the eighth. As the question of the King's life or death hung on the correct solution, nothing ought to be left dubious and all the children of Daivakī should unsparingly be killed, thus completely removing all chance of danger. One by one seven children were born to poor Daivakī in prison and they were all killed by Kaṁsa. Ultimately Viṣṅu came as the eighth child. He was born in the middle of the eighth night of the waning moon and as Vāsudeva looked upon him, he saw the baby surrounded by a halo of light and possessed of other signs from which he knew him to be no other than Viṣṅu himself; he was naturally eager to save the divine child from the hands of the oppressor, and marched with him to the gates of the prison. The gate-keepers, at his approach, fell into a deep sleep, and the gates which were under strong lock and key, softly opened of themselves making a passage for the child. The anxious father came to the Jumnā whose dark waters rolled before him, with their foaming waves, and the night was so dark that he despaired of crossing it. But at this moment a

Viṣṅu as the eighth child.

jackal passed through the waters, showing that here there was a ford across the river and Vāsudeva followed the steps of the jackal, and found land again under his feet. He crossed the Jumnā and meanwhile the thousand-headed snake, Vāsuki, raised his hoods aloft and protected the father and the child. Vāsudeva went to Vṛindāvana where, according to the prophecy he had heard that night, a child was born to Nanda Ghoṣa, the prince of the gopas, or milkmen, who inhabited the district. In obedience to the prophecy he passed into the birth-room the doors having yielded to his touch, placed his baby by the side of the sleeping Yaçodā, queen of Nanda Ghoṣa, and taking her baby with him, returned to the prison. In the morning Kaṁsa heard of the birth of Daivakī's eighth child and found to his surprise that it was a girl. He however, took the little thing into his hands and tried to dash its brains out against the stones. But this baby was an incarnation of the goddess Bhagabatī. Just as he was throwing her against the stones she slipped from his hand and assuming her own appearance as a goddess rose to the sky, saying: 'One who will kill you is growing up in Vṛindāvana.' The goddess disappeared and Kaṁsa had no sleep by day or night. He constantly thought who this child might be, till he saw appartions of his destroyer even in trees and walls, and sent emissaries throughout the land to kill every little child that was born. The groan of mothers rose to the sky; the earth trembled to her centre and black winds began to blow all over the country.

Kaṁsa kills every new-born child

Then some one said to him that little Kriṣṅa, his future destroyer, was growing up in the house

of Nanda Ghoṣa, prince of Vṛindāvana and he sent Putanā, the demon-nurse, to kill the child. Putanā was killed, and then, as I have said in a previous chapter, in my remarks on the Bhāgabata, one by one Kaṁsa's emissaries, Tṛiṇābarṭa, Baka, Keçi and others were killed in the course of similar missions and the King's anxiety grew in an alarming degree. Last of all he sent Akrūra, a devout Vāiṣṇava, who would know whether it was indeed Viṣṇu who was incarnated as Kriṣṇa, ordering him to bring Kriṣṇa to attend the Dhanuryajña or bow-sacrifice that he was holding at Mathurā. Nanda Ghoṣa, a feudatory chieftain under Kaṁsa, could not disobey his command. And Kriṣṇa and Valarāma, his cousin, were taken to Mathurā, where the former killed Kaṁsa in the open court.

Kriṣṇa kills the King's emissaries.

Akrūra.

Kaṁsa is killed.

This is briefly the story of the Bhāgabata; but the Vāiṣṇava poets do not lay any stress on such manifestations of the glory or ঐশ্বর্য্য, of Kriṣṇa. They scarcely touch on any of the points, here mentioned, in their accounts of Kriṣṇa.

Vaiṣṇava poets not interested in the above.

They describe his games and pastimes at home where his mother Yaçodā, while punishing him for misconduct, weeps for remorse. She would not allow him to go to the fields with other boys to graze the cattle, for fear of Kaṁsa's emissaris; and every morning the shepherds would come to her and beg her to send Kriṣṇa with them for the day. The Goṣṭha or songs of the pastoral sports detail how Yaçodā at first refuses the shepherds but at last yields to their entreaties coupled with Kriṣṇa's own request to be allowed to go to the meadow;—how the shepherd boys blow their horns and the cows follow

The Goṣṭha

them with frolicsome leaps ;—how Kriṣṇa plucks flowers and fruits and distributes them amongst the boys and how they play together, sometimes mimicking the cries of birds,—dancing with peacocks,—trying to skip over their own shadows and sometimes pursuing monkeys through the boughs of trees ; at such a moment appears Triṇāvarṭa or some other demon while Kriṣṇa leaves his comrades, and though only a boy, manifests himself in all his glory, and then destroying the demon re-joins his companions in triumph. So the boys, forsaken by Kriṣṇa, feel that they are helpless. They know him to be their friend and playmate but he is also a mystery to them. They cannot realise his greatness but his personality is dearer to them than life. In many dangers it is he who protects them in a way unintelligible to them. The lake Kāliya was poisoned by the great snake Kāli ; some of the shepherds go there, drink the water and die by poison ; Kriṣṇa is informed of it ; he comes swiftly to the lake, restores the children to life and enters the lake himself, disappearing in its waters ; he wrestles with the great snake for a long time and in the meantime the shepherd-boys having lost Kriṣṇa, the friend of their souls, stand statue-like on the bank of the lake with tearful eyes. Who will now kill Kaṁsa's emissaries for them ? Who will now protect them from Indra, the God of clouds, who has already tried to destroy the Vṛindā groves by sending floods ? Who will protect the cattle when a demon like Baka comes down to devour them ? The apple of their eyes, their protector, playfellow and constant companion, their friend and philosopher, their ever-beloved Kriṣṇa has now

The lake Kāliya.

disappeared in the waters of the poisonous lake Kāliya, and they cry out, in song :

* "O, let us all go, let us go to mother Yaçodā, and tell her—O mother, the jewel of your heart is lost by us in the waters of Kāliya. The moon of the Vṛindā groves has set on yonder lake ! The Vṛindā groves are now void and all the world is void to us and what is now left that we should care to live for !"

At this juncture comes Rādhā like a mad woman stricken with fear,—with her hair dishevelled ; she goes to throw herself into the waters of Kāliya,—when lo ! the great serpent Kāliya raises its hood aloft,—two mermaids on two sides singing the praises of Kriṣṅa and on the hood of the serpent, from which a rich diamond sparkles like the sun, stands Kriṣṅa playing on his flute. The picture of this scene which is called *kaliya damana*, is to be found in all the artists' shops in Bengal. The boys are as if restored to life by the sight. All these incidents are the subjects of song in the 'goṣṭha' ; and the Vaiṣṅava *padas* describing these pastoral scenes tenderly appeal to the heart and claim a tribute of tears from their readers.

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* "চল চল সবে চল, আমরা বলিগে মায়েরে গিয়ে ।
তোর অঞ্চলের মণি, শুনগো জননী,
এলেম ভাসায়ে দিয়ে ॥
ব্রজকুলশশী অস্ত হ'ল এত দিনে, ভুবন শূন্য হ'ল ।
মোদের ফুরাইল আশা, নাহিক ভরসা
আমরা থাকব কি ধন লয়ে ॥"

The Deva Goṣṭha.

Then comes the Deva goṣṭha. Here the boys describe a superb scene that they have witnessed in the Vṛindā groves,—while they come as usual in the morning to solicit Yaçoda's permission to take her dear son to the woods. They say "O mother, believe not your Kriṣṇa to be a common child. We cannot conceive of his greatness. He is our comrade and friend, but he is no ordinary mortal. Resplendent beings, with halo of light round their heads, appear in the forest; O mother, we never knew that such beings lived in Vṛindāvanā. A woman of superhuman beauty comes riding on a lion to the forest every day and taking our Kriṣṇa in her arms gives him sweet cream and butter to eat. But Kriṣṇa distributes those amongst us! They are so sweet, so sweet! O mother, though you are a queen, you have nothing so delicious!" Thus the boys unconsciously indicate that the Goddess Bhagavati comes amongst them to meet Viṣṇu who is incarnated as Kriṣṇa. They continue "Then comes, O mother, a host of other beings. We know them not. Never in Vṛindā groves, have we seen such men! One of them rides on a buffalo (Yama, king of death), another a peacock (the warrior god Kārtikeya) and athird, resplendent with a crown from which diamonds shoot forth their light like suns, comes riding on a huge white elephant (Indra riding on the elephant Airāvata) and then comes another being with four faces, radiant as fire, counting the beads of his rosary (Brahma, the creator). They all come to our Kriṣṇa and if he looks at them with kindliness, they feel as if they are blessed, their eyes become tearful with joy; they dare not approach him too closely, they hold him in so great

A superb sight.

The gods and goddesses come down to pay honour to Kriṣṇa.

a reverence. But last comes a beggar riding on a bull. He puts on a tattered tiger's skin and from his matted locks flows a stream. He is covered with dust and serpents hiss from his head. As he sees Kriṣṅa he dances for joy and Kriṣṅa becomes all impatience to meet him. He clasps the beggar in his arms and locks him in a close embrace saying 'O Lord, you are immaculate, unapproachably pure and a true Yogi. I gave you the golden palace of Kailāsa and appointed Kuvera, the god of wealth as your store-keeper; but you live in funeral grounds on scanty food, and have not been moved from the stern ascetic life. You are above all the gods, O Lord. O Lord, I worship you.' Saying this our Kriṣṅa falls at his feet. But the beggar washes his feet with the water that flows from his matted locks and says again and again 'I am blessed, I am blessed.' This refers to an interview of Kriṣṅa with Çiva. The waters from his locks are the holy streams of the Ganges.

The spiritual significance of the padas.

These songs all possess a deep spiritual significance. Through the legends of gods and goddesses they touch the finer chords of our emotions, and teach that wealth, fame and worldly ties are as nothing when God calls us to Him. The devotion of the shepherds of the Vṛindā groves to Kriṣṅa has no grain of earthliness in it. Beyond the pale of palaces, of the world's splendour and luxury, the Vṛindā groves are situated, under a clear sky and the simple-minded shepherds, by dint of their sincere devotion alone acquire the spirit of resignation to him which theologists and monastic pedants, with all their learning, cannot realise.

The Uttara Goṣṭha or "return home."

Then comes the Uttara-goṣṭha or return home of the shepherds. The mother is anxious. The shades of evening cover the Vṛindā groves ;—the last ray of light disappears from the western horizon and the poor Yaçodā is restless. She goes into her appartments to learn the time and comes out looking wistfully towards the woods. Afraid of Kaṁsa's emissaries or of other accidents befalling her beloved Kriṣṅa, she describes to her companion and relative Rohini her anxious fears. She knows that her voice will not be heard, yet calls aloud 'Kriṣṅa, Kriṣṅa, Kriṣṅa ;' and when her anguish is at its deepest, lo ! the horn sounds, or the lowing of the cows is heard, and she runs out to meet her son. Kriṣṅa, with sportive steps amongst his gay companions with the crown of peacock feathers bent a little to the left and the garland of forest flowers hanging round his neck,—his face marked with beautiful *alaka* and *tilaka*,—comes running to the embrace of his doting mother. This is the Uttara goṣṭha.

Padas on Kriṣṅa's amours with Rādhā.

But these incidents also, comparatively speaking, form a very minor portion of the literature of the *padas*, the greater part of them being devoted to Kriṣṅa's amours with Rādhā.

Rādhā is the daughter of the king Vṛiṣa Bhānu. When she was born she did not open her eyes, and people thought she was blind. Amongst others Kriṣṅa as a boy went to see the new-born child. But when he stood beside her, she opened her eyes, so that before seeing anything of the world she might see him—the lord of the universe, unto whom she was pledged in love from birth. In due time she was married to Āyāna Ghoṣa.

Viçakhā, one of her maids, now showed her a picture of Kriṣṇa. The moment she saw it, she felt a strange emotion, she yearned to see him in the flesh. There under the shade of a *Kadamva* tree with the crown made of peacock feathers bent a little to the left, and adorned with the flowers of the forest, stood the young shepherd-god flute in hand: the flute sang 'Rādhā, Rādhā,' and on the moment she fell in love. Her maids did not know what had wakened in her heart. She would go and come out of her room a hundred times in an hour without cause, look wistfully towards the *kadamva* tree, and sigh deeply. Sometimes she would quietly sit like a statue and rise suddenly with a start. Her garments hung loosely on her, her necklace fell to the ground she cared not for it. The maids thought she was possessed by ghosts. One evening she softly related to them her story. It was as if the dark blue sky had taken a human shape,—the rainbow on the top had assumed the beauty of the crown of peacock's feathers and the woods and forests had given their floral tribute to adorn his person. His flute called constantly 'Rādhā, Rādhā' and she could not control herself. She took little food or fasted altogether and looked like a Yogini with her yellow cloth, and fixed her gaze on the clouds, with which she held communion with uplifted hands.

First love.

The emotions of Kriṣṇa were no less fervent. The spikes of the *champaka* flowers, drenched with the rain, blossomed and he was reminded of Rādhā at the sight. He could not look towards Vriṣa Bhānu's palace for his tears: day

and night he took his flute in his hand and sang 'Rādhā, Rādhā.'

The meeting.

Then comes the meeting. She stealthily walks along the forest-path to meet him. A dark coloured sāḍī hides her in the dark night; like a creeper with fine foliage and gay flowers or like a streak of lightning formed in human shape she goes—caring not for caste—fearing not the slanderous tongues of the wicked or the reprimands of her elderly relations,—offering herself body and soul to his service. She comes to him as a martyr for love, and joins him in the bowers of the Vṛindā groves; and from that time forward every night the maids prepare a bower of flowers and there Kriṣṅa and Radhā meet. There are many manœuvres and devices adopted by the lovers for these meetings and the scandal has by this time spread. Rādhā said she would mind no consequence. If the world will not look at her face, well and good. She will repeat the name of Kriṣṅa day and night and the joy derived from that would make up for all her sufferings. 'Take my bracelets away, O maids, the service of Kriṣṅa will adorn my hands, and I want no other ornaments for them;—take away my necklace of purest pearls, the thought of Kriṣṅa is the ornament of my breast; I want no other for it; the praise of Kriṣṅa will adorn my ears, no need of earrings for them. The ground trodden by Kriṣṅa's feet is dear to me, cover my body, O, maidens, with the sacred dust of that ground! Oh I shall turn a Yogini for love. My infamy is known,—you fear it,-but I glory in it; I glory in all that the love of Kriṣna may bring to me!'

We have already spoken of how Kriṣṇa goes in the disguise of a physician knowing Rādhā to be ill and on the pretext of feeling her pulse touches her hand, and is overjoyed. He sees her in the guise of a holy nun, and blesses her, before all present, while with side-long glances conveys to her secretly his deep love. Many similar devices are described. One day, Subala, one of the friends and companions of Kriṣṇa dressed as a girl, went to Rādhā privately and told her that Kriṣṇa was reminded of her at the sight of a *champaka* flower and it being day time he was not able to see her, and a fit of unconsciousness had came over him. On hearing this she immediately exchanged clothes with Subala and looking like a pretty shepherd-boy, with the shepherd's crook in her hand, went to the pastoral grove leaving Subala in the house, disguised as a girl. There she saw Kriṣṇa lying on the earth unconscious and took him in her arms. At her touch his senses came back to him; but without looking at her he said "O Subala, tell me where is my Rādhā, the soul of my soul?" Rādhā said "Look at me, I am your devoted servant. You do not recognise me!" and Kriṣṇa in raptures held her to his breast.

The story of the pearl-plant

But Rādhā is a princess. Occasionally an idea of her own position in contrast with that of a village-shepherd is not unnatural in her. One day the shepherds thought, if the cows were adorned with necklaces of pearls, how grand they would look! They applied to Kriṣṇa, who, sent Sudāma, a fellow-shepherd, to Rādhā, asking her for a pearl. One pearl would be enough, he said. He would sow it in the ground and by his power create pearl-



Painted in lacquer on wooden board. Meant to be a Book Cover, taken from the District of Birbhum, early 17th century.

plants. The princess sat in the company of her maidens, and told Sudāma in reply—"Foolish shepherd, know that pearls grow in sea-shells and they are precious things. They are not like the forest-flowers that you pluck every day in the Vṛindā-groves. The idea is worthy only of a shepherd. You want to adorn cows with necklaces of pearls; no monarch could be so lavish as to entertain such a wild fancy. Go back to your Kriṣṅa and say that the dew of heaven falls into the sea-shells under the influence of the constellation Svāti, a rare happening, and is formed into pearls, and that fishers risk their lives to bring them from the bottom of the sea. It is not as easy to get a pearl as to possess a *kadamva* or a *champaka* flower." The maids also jeered at Sudāma who stood silent, much mortified at being ridiculed in this manner. The crown of flowers fell from his head, his crook fell from his hand; insulted and disappointed he returned to Kriṣṅa and related the story of the treatment he had received from Rādhā and her maids. Kriṣṅa heard it; a sense of shame suffused his face, and he was pensive for some time; then he said, "Very well, my friends! I shall obtain a pearl by some means or other. Please wait here a moment for me." He ran to his mother and begged for a pearl. Yaçodā said, "Foolish boy, what would you do with a pearl?" But Kriṣṅa would not leave her without one. He was refused and with tears in his eyes was about to return, when Yaçodā's heart melted in affection:—"After all a pearl is of no value compared with my Kriṣṅa. I cannot see him sad." She called him to her and from her earring gave the brightest pearl that she had.

Forthwith he ran to his companions and sowed the pearl. Lo, the plants grew and in a few moments they were rich with their precious burden. The bank of the Jumnā—its groves and bowers—all looked as if they were set on fire,—the pearls reflecting the light of the sun. The shepherds plucked them as fast as they could, made necklaces of them, put them round their own necks in profusion and hung them on the cows. In the meantime a maid of Rādhā had come to the Jumnā to fetch water, when her eyes were dazzled by the wonderful scene. She hid herself behind a tree, and stealthily saw all that the shepherds did with the pearls. She hastened home and reported the matter to Rādhā, who now felt remorse for her conduct. She sent one of her maids to sound Kriṣṇa as to how he would treat her. But the shepherds sent her away with rough words. Rādhā herself hastened in the evening to the spot: but the pearl-groves had disappeared and she saw a strange city looking like a second heaven on the banks of the Jumnā. There were celestial maidens with golden rods in hand guarding the gate of the city, and each maiden was as beautiful as herself and decorated with jewels and ornaments such as no earthly princess wore. She asked one of them if she knew where her Kriṣṇa was. The damsel replied in contempt,—'What! You want Kriṣṇa! You could never reach his palace, it is the highest in heaven. You will pass many a city like this before you reach his palace: but the guards will not allow you to enter." And poor Rādhā in deep anguish of heart passed on from palace to palace,—all displaying wonderful wealth, their spires and domes resplendent with

diamonds, and reaching up to the starry regions,—heavenly damsels of beauty superior to any she could claim, rudely preventing her passage and when she asked about Kriṣṅa, saying "How foolish for a mad woman to think of reaching the highest heaven, the Vaikuṇṭha of Kriṣṅa!" There in the starry night when the dews were falling and the *champaka* was diffusing its fragrance,—the soft murmurs of the Jumnā were heard from a distance,—in that dark night illuminated by the diamonds on the walls of the palaces and the stars of the sky, the unfortunate wanderer moved from gate to gate with pale face crying 'O Kriṣṅa', and as the gate keepers treated her with contempt and even rudeness,—her eyes became full of tears and she suddenly fell on her knees and with clasped palms prayed,—"O Lord of my Soul, O Lord of the Universe, O Kriṣṅa, I am a poor woman, foolish to the extreme and full of frailties and sins. Pardon me, O Lord, pardon me. I cannot live without thee. I die here." And she drooped low even as a flower droops when the rains fall upon it, and in deep resignation she sat closing her eyes dazzled with the glories before her. 'How weak am I! How poor and cursed!' She cried. 'But forsake me not, O Lord of the Universe, I am but a poor and ignorant milk-maid," and when she opened her eyes, the palaces had all gone and she saw her own Kriṣṅa,—the shepherd-boy standing before her, flute in hand, and taking her gently by the arm, saying "Rādhā, my soul, the joy of my life, where have you been so long?" and she clasped his feet with her hands and for her choked voice could not say where she had been. God does

not come to the proud but yields to love. This is the meaning to be found in this story. *

The Māthura or parting.

There are innumerable songs describing similar incidents in this love-story. The last is the Māthur,—the most pathetic of all. Kaṁsa sends Akrūra to Vṛindā-groves to bring Kriṣṇa. A chariot comes to take him. The shepherds stand speechless, statue-like and with choked voices, they cannot even say 'don't go.' Yaçodā lies unconscious in her frantic agony of heart. Nanda hides his eyes and groans in a corner of his palace, and the milk-maids with Rādhā at their head go to throw themselves under the wheels of the chariot to destroy their miserable lives; for unbearable will their life in Vrindāvana be when Kriṣṇa has gone away. The birds Çuka and Sārī sit mute, not singing their accustomed merry tunes. The cows look wistfully towards the far bank of the Jumnā where Mathurā is situated. The bees no longer hum round the blooming flowers. All the groves of Vṛindā look like a picture of desolation where the shepherds and the maids, remain plunged in sorrow after the chariot has moved away. Kriṣṇa kills Kaṁsa and is restored to Vāsudeva and Daivakī, but poor Nanda and Yaçodā are blinded with weeping.

Vrindāvan deserted by Kriṣṇa.

Rādhā forsaken by Kriṣṇa.

Rādhā with her maids seek the Vṛindā groves; it is a mad and fruitless search; she asks the jessamine, the lotus and the *kunda* flower if they can tell her the whereabouts of Kriṣṇa; she stands lost in a trance, and then runs on again,—the thorns pierce her feet, she does not care; the

* This story is related in the Bengali poem **Muktālatāvalī** written about 120 years ago

maids say 'do not run in that way, the thorns will pierce your feet, the snakes may bite; the place abounds with them.' Rādhā says 'when I fell in love with a shepherd, I knew I would have to wander through forests full of thorns. So I brought thorns from the woods and placing them in my courtyard, I learnt to walk on them. I guarded myself against snakes by learning charms with the same object; so I fear them not.' She comes to the pleasant bowers—there her senses leave her completely. Her gaze is transfixed to the clouds overtopped with a rainbow; she mistakes them for Krishna and addresses them,* "O go not away! Wait but for a moment, thou friend of my soul, leave me not thus. One should not forsake her who cannot live without him. If you stay not here, go wherever you will; but wait only one moment. If you are resolved to go away, tears cannot check you, I know, and tears cannot

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* ওহে তিলেক দাঁড়াও দাঁড়াও হে,

অমন করে যাওয়া উচিত নয়॥

যে যার শরণ লয়, নিঠুর বঁধু, তাকে কি বধিতে হয় হে

হেথা থাকতে যদি মন না থাকে, তবে যেও সেথাকে,

যদি মনে মন রত, না হয় মনের মত,

কাঁদলে প্রেম আর কত বেড়ে থাকে!

তাতে যদি মোদের জীবন না থাকে,

না থাকে না থাকে, কপালে যা থাকে, তাই হবে।

যথা যে না থাকে, তারে আর কোথা কে,

ধ'রে বেন্ধে কবে রেখে থাকে!

produce love. If my life goes out for this, let it go. Who can avoid fate! Alas, dear friend, who can detain the unwilling heart by mere importunities!"

"But bear with me for one word more. Our feelings were mutually sincere. But you are indifferent to me now. The result of this will be, that our love which was pure as gold will be misunderstood; others will blame the love that killed the milk-maids. Stand there a moment, if you will not come near, wait only there where you are, and see how I die of love."

All this Rādhā addressed to the clouds mistaking them for Krishna. At this stage she swoons and Vṛindā the maid comes. She uses various methods to bring her mistress to her senses, but she fails. Her maids cry aloud, 'Rādhā is dead.' With thin cotton placed near her nostrils they feel that there is still a little breath left. She is carried to the Çyamakunda, and they plunge her body into the holy waters—a usage followed by Hindus at the moment of death and called the *Antarjali*, and the maidens whisper in her ear 'O Krishna, O Krishna.'—

আর এক দুঃখ শুন কই হে তবে,
অকৈতব ভাবে ঘটা'লে কৈতবে.
এই হবে,—বঁধু জান্বনদ হেম, সম যেই প্রেম.
হেন প্রেমের নাম আর কেউ না লবে।
শুনহে, মাধব, বলবে লোকে সব, প্রেম করে ম'ল গোপিকা সবে
বঁধু তিলেক দাঁড়াও, গোপীগণের বঁধু, গোপীগণের প্রেমের
মরণ দেখে যাও হে॥

Rye Unmādini by Krishna Kamala.

for the dying soul must hear the name of God. On hearing Kriṣṅa's name she slowly revives and looks helplessly around ; weak and feeble she cannot speak. Vṛindā says 'At the first infatuation of love Kriṣṅa gave a bond to Rādhā that he would be her slave all his life. She now wants back this bond assuring the maids that she will go to Mathurā with it and bring him back bound in chains as a runaway slave. Rādhā, though dying for love, cannot hear any one abuse Kriṣṅa. She speaks her foolish fears in gentle whispers to Vrindā* 'Oh, do not bind him, do not speak rude words to him. If you say a rude word, his lovely face will grow pale, my heart breaks at the very thought of it.'

The spiritualisition of the Rādhā-Kriṣṅa legend.

But Rādhā and Kriṣṅa are no historical personalities with enlightened Vaiṣṅavas. Kriṣṅa Kamala the poet says of Kriṣṅa† "When the God-vision becomes clear in the soul the devotee expresses it by the allegory of Kriṣṅa's coming to the Vṛindā-

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* "বেঁধোনা তার কোমল করে,
ভৎ র্সনা করো না তারে,
মনে যেন নাহি পায় দুঃখ।
যখন তারে মন্দ কবে,
চন্দ্র মুখ মলিন হবে,
তাই ভেবে ফাটে মোর বুক"
Rye Unmādini by Kriṣṅa Kamala.

† "স্ফূর্ত্তিরূপে মূর্ত্তি যখন দেখেন নয়নে,
তখন ভাবেন কৃষ্ণ এল বৃন্দাবনে,
অদর্শনে ভাবেন কৃষ্ণ গেছে মধুপুরী।"
Rye Unmādinī by Kriṣṅa Kamala.

groves. When the vision fades away, he considers Krishna to have gone to Mathurā." Dāçarathī, another poet of the old school, says * "If you O Krishna, come to my heart, it will be sacred as the Vrindā groves. My devotion to you will be expressed in the symbol of Rādhā; my desire to reach the final emancipation will be as Vrindā the milkmaid. My body will be the palace of Nanda Ghosa and my love for you will be Jaçodā herself. Bear, O Lord, the load of my sins as once you did the mount Govardhana and destroy my six passions, which are like the six emissaries of Kamsa." The whole matter is thus spiritualised. Chaitanya Deva said † "As a young man yearns for his beloved, even so the soul yearns for God; it is for want of a better object of comparison that the Vaishnavas worship the Lord under this form."

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* "হৃদি বৃন্দাবনে বাস কর যদি কমলাপতি।
ওহে, ভক্তিপ্রিয়, আমার ভক্তি হবে রাধা সতী॥
মুক্তি কামনা আমারি হবে বৃন্দা গোপ-নারী
আমার দেহ হবে নন্দের পুরী স্নেহ হবে মা যশোমতী,
ধর ধর জনার্দ্দন, পাপ ভার গোবর্দ্ধন,
কামাদি ছয় কংস চরে ধ্বংস কর সম্প্রতি।"

A song by Dāçarathi.

† "যুবকের আর্ত্তি যথা যুবতী দেখিয়া
সেইরূপ আর্ত্তি আর না দেখি ভাবিয়া॥
একারণে ভক্তগণ ভজে যদুপতি।
পত্নীভাবে তার প্রতি স্থির করি মতি॥"

Sayings of Chaitanya Deva,
from Govinda Dās's Kadchā.

A person who yearns for God should not care for home, for fame, or for any earthly consideration ; he must renounce all. This idea is best expressed by the allegory of Rādhā and Kriṣṅa ; for a woman, peculiarly situated as she is in Hindu society, cannot contract love with a stranger without risking all that is near and dear to her. The spirit of martyrdom in this love is kindred to that for which the soul of a true devotee is always ready. Persecutions and all manner of earthly evils must come upon him as a matter of course and the world will call such a man, a knave, a maniac and what not ; but he must stick to his faith inspite of all misfortune. Hence this symbol was adopted by the Vaiṣṅavas to express their unflinching devotion and self-sacrifice for religion.

The emotions of Chaitanya Deva attributed to Rādhā.

The personality of Chaitanya Deva gave a new form to this poetic literature. If one reads carefully a number of Vaiṣṅava *padas* from such collections as the Padakalpalatikā, Padakalpataru, and Padasamudra together with some of the biographies of Chaitanya Deva, they will be struck with the fact, that nearly all the emotions ascribed to Rādhā are taken from those of Chaitanya Deva. The rapturous feelings on his seeing the clouds described in his biographies are attributed to Rādhā in the *padas*. His fine frenzy lends charms to the similar mental states ascribed to her, and the sight of a *kadamva* flower, of the river Jumnā, of the Vṛindā groves, lifts both into a state of rapture. One who is not an adept in Chaitanya literature will be charmed while reading the *padas* by the high poetical flights reached in the description of Rādhā's love for Kriṣṅa, and will not easily suspect

that in the accounts of this love they are perusing the story of Chaitanya's realisation. In fact there are innumerable songs in this literature which echo the sentiments of Chaitanya Deva, and there is in this respect a difference between the love songs of Rādhā and Krishṇa of the pre-Chaitanya period and those that followed him. The allegory becomes complete and beautiful in the latter as they bear the stamp of this influence, and the compilers of the collections of these songs have clearly indicated this by giving as a prologue to each chapter a song describing the emotions of Chaitanya Deva by Vāsu Ghoṣa, Narahari or other poets who personally witnessed them. Such a prologue is called the Goura Chandrikā or preliminary verses in praise of Chaitanya; the songs that follow are true to the spirit of the emotions of Chaitanya though the love of Rādhā and Krishṇa is apparently the subject of them. For instance, in the Purvarāga or dawn of love, we have several Goura Chandrikās to indicate the subsequent spirit of the songs. One Gour Chandrikā runs thus *"To-day I saw the moon of Navadwipa (Chaitanya);

The Goura-Chandrikā.

* "আজু হাম কি পেখলু নবদ্বীপ চন্দ।
করতলে করই বয়ান অবলম্ব॥
পুনঃ পুনঃ গতাগতি করু ঘরপন্থ।
ক্ষণে ক্ষণে ফুলবনে চলই একান্ত॥
ছল ছল নয়নে কমল সুবিলাস।
নব নব ভাব করত পরকাশ॥
পুলক মুকুলবর ভরু সব দেহ।
রাধা মোহন কছু না পাওল থেহ॥" Pada No. 68.
From Chapter I, Padakalpataru.

resting his cheek upon his hand he sits brooding quietly—lost in thought; he goes and comes without intention; as he wanders towards the woods where the flowers bloom, his eyes, large as full blown lotuses, seem to float in tears. They betray great emotions. A strange gladness takes possession of him and Rādhāmohana (the poet) can not enter into its meaning." After a prologue of this sort the compiler gives many passages of love between Rādhā and Kriṣṇa. The first runs as follows:*—"She (Rādhā) comes out of her house a hundred times; her mind is agitated; she looks wistfully to the shade of the *kadamva* trees; Oh, why has Rādhā become so? She cares not for infamy, nor for the scoldings of the elderly women of her house. Has some spirit possessed her? Her loose garments she does not care to adjust, she sits quietly and rises with a sudden start; her ornaments fall carelessly from her person."

Songs before and after Chaitanya.

The difference between the songs written before and after Chaitanya Deva is well marked; for instance, in a song on Abhisāra or the stealthy visit of Rādhā to Kriṣṇa by night, we find Jayadeva, the

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* "ঘরের বাহিরে, দণ্ডে শতবার, তিল তিল আসে যায়।
মন উচাটন, নিঃশ্বাস সঘন, কদম্ব কাননে চায়॥
রাই এমন কেন বা হৈল,
গুরু দুরুজন, ভয় নাহি মন, কোথা বা কি দেব পাইল।
সদাই চঞ্চল, বসন অঞ্চল, সম্বরণ নাহি করে।
বসি থাকি থাকি, উঠয়ে চমকি, ভূষণ খসিয়া পড়ে॥"

Chandidās.

Sanskrit poet of the 12th century writing.* "The sounding *nupura* of your feet you must leave behind, for they will jingle; you should come to love's bower putting on a dark-coloured sāḍī." In the night she would have to go stealthily; so the poet recommends a dark sāḍī to conceal her from the view of others and also to leave her *nupura* lest they should draw the attention of others by their jingling sounds. This is a very natural piece of advice to one who wants to meet her lover secretly; but let us read a love song on Abhisāra by a subsequent poet who wrote after Chaitanya Deva "Her *nupura* called *bankaraja* sounds pleasantly and her bracelets make a merry jingling sound. She is surrounded by her maidens;—the high sounding musical instruments, the *Dampha* and the *Ravaba* are heard from a distance and a thin music flows on like waves of love." This seems quite unsuited to a song on Abhisāra where secrecy must be the watchword. But the poet who wrote it had in his mind the processions of the *sankirtan* parties led by Chaitanya Deva where the *Dampha*, the *Ravaba* and other musical instruments sounded their high notes and where the party marched, literally carried on by waves of love.

The Abhisāra.

These associations and references, however anomalous they may appear at times, as marring the natural beauty of a description, do in fact nothing of the sort but lend a charm to it;—they

* "মখরমধীরম্ ত্যজ মঞ্জীরম্ ... ...
চল সখি কুঞ্জম্ সতিমির পুঞ্জম্ শীলয় নীল নিচোলম্"
Jayadeva.

only remind one of the spiritual significance of these songs without affecting the poetry. The song referred to is highly poetical inspite of what might appear as its anomalies. I give below the full text.* "Towards the cool shade of the Vṛindā groves Rādhā goes to meet Kriṣṇa. Her face is as beautiful as a newly risen moon, the sandal-marks adorn her lovely cheeks, a mark of *kasturi* is on her forehead ; behind her hang her beautiful braids adorned by a golden *jhapa* with silken pendants and a lovely pearl brightens her nose. The bracelets and the *nupura* called *Bankaraja* make a merry jingle as she walks; her maids surround her and the high notes of *Dampha* and *Ravaba* are heard. As she goes, cupid flies away terror-struck, and the sweet scents from her person attract the bees, who mistake her foot-prints for lotuses and maddened with the perfumes fall to the ground in the hope of drinking honey, and only kiss the foot prints. The beauty of her person far excels that of a golden creeper or the lightning flash—it shows the utmost skill the creator had in command; gracefully she walks as a

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* শ্যাম অভিসারে, চলল বর সুন্দরী, শীতল বৃন্দাবন মাঝে।
একে সে তরুণ ইন্দু, মলয়জ বিন্দু বিন্দু, কস্তুরী তিলক তাহে সাজে।
পিঠে দোলে হেম ঝাঁপা, রঙ্গিয়া পাটের থোপা, নাসায় মুকুতারাজ সাজে।
কঙ্কণ রণরণি, বঙ্করাজ ধ্বনি, চলইতে সুমধুর বাজে।
চৌদিকে রমনী সাজে, ডম্ফ রবাব বাজে, চলে সবে মদন তরঙ্গে।
ধনি যে দিকে পয়ান করে, মদন পলায় ডরে, সৌরভে ভ্রমর যায় সঙ্গে॥

royal swan; her arms rest on the shoulders of her maids. Poet Ananta Dās says they arrived at the bowers to the delight of Kriṣṇa." The *kasturi* mark, or *tilak,* is a holy sign referred to in the above song, and this is another feature that reminds us of the spiritual significance of the song. The foot-prints bear the light red mark of the *alta* dye and hence they are mistaken for lotuses. So without injuring the poetic beauty of the description or introducing anything to jar on the ear of the unsuspecting lay reader, the songs are fraught with a deep religious significance which true Vaiṣṇavas only are privileged to enjoy. The references are so clear that to those versed in Chaitanya literature, Rādhā the princess portrayed in the songs will pass away and the personality of a handsome Brāhmin youth maddened by God's love, bewailing his separation from Kriṣṇa and holding communion in a trance with the clouds of heaven, the trees of the woods, and the waves of the Jumna as though they were real friends who could tell him of the God he sought for, will appear as the only reality investing the songs with the significance and beauty of a higher plane.

চলইতে চরণের, সঙ্গে চলে মধুকর, মকরন্দ পানকি লোভে।
সৌরভে উনমত, ধরণী চুম্বয়ে কত, যাঁহা যাঁহা পদচিহ্ন শোভে॥
কনক লতা জিনি, জিনি সৌদামিনী, বিধির অবধি রূপ সাজে॥
রাজহংস জিনি, গমন সুলাবণী, অবলম্বন সখী কাঁধে।
অনন্ত দাস ভণে, মিলন নিকুঞ্জ বনে, পুরাইতে শ্যাম মনসাধে॥"

Padas No. 308-9 Chapter X, Padakalpataru.

Classification of emotions.

The love literature of the Vaiṣṇavas is a unique treasure. It displays the nicest classification of emotions and all conceivable forms of tender feelings. The Purvarāga or the dawn of love is divided into subheads such as—বয়ঃসন্ধি, সখ্যুক্তি, চিত্রপটদর্শন, স্বানকালেদর্শন, দৈত্য, etc. Then comes রূপাভিসার, মান, কারণমান, নির্হেতুমান, মিলন, বাসকসজ্জা, বিপ্রলব্ধা, খণ্ডিতা, কলহন্তরিতা, আক্ষেপানুরাগ, রূপোল্লাস, প্রেমবৈচিত্র, মাথুর, সম্ভোগমিলন, বাৎসল্য গোষ্ঠ, নৌকাবিলাস সৌখ্য and many more. In Bhaktiratnākara we have 360 different kinds of the finer emotions of a lover's heart minutely classified. Each of these groups has hundreds of songs attached to it by way of illustration and has, besides, the usual prologues or Goura Chandrikā which the poets have called সর্ব্বকালোচিত or lending permanent interest to the songs, suggesting spiritual associations.

The human interest and the underlying spirituality.

It is a curious literature. It deals with human passions mainly of the most platonic sort and has always a door open heavenwards. While perusing the accounts of love between man and woman in all its varied forms, the reader will every now and then find himself breathing a higher atmosphere; it is as though he comes to the junction of a river with the sea;—looking back, he sees a stream that comes through delightful landscapes, through groves and bowers that resound with human voices,—but looking forward he finds the endless sea that cuts off at the coast all connection with the human world and stretches on beneath the foaming waves till it loses itself in heaven.

There is yet another account of Kriṣṇa's life which the Vaiṣṇava poets have taken pains to des-

The Prabhāsa.

cribe ; it is the scene of Prabhāsa. Kriṣṅa who was a shepherd boy has killed Kaṁsa and is now the king of Mathurā ; no more the crown of peacock feathers on his head, but a diadem sparkling with the richest jewels,—no more the rod Pāchanbāri in his hand to drive the cattle, but the sceptre to rule,—and no more playing the flute to madden poor Rādhā but playing with the fate of millions of his subjects. The Vṛindāvana scenes are forgotten. He has found his parents, Vasudeva and Daivakī; and cares not to hear that Nanda and Yaçodā have grown blind with weeping for him. The shepherd boys no longer tend the cattle on the banks of the Jumnā as in Kriṣṅa's time—they cannot bear the sight of the Vṛindā groves. Rādhā's body is carried into the waters of the Jumnā and her maids know that in a few moments all will be over with her. At this time, the Dhanuryayna or sacrifice of the bow is held in Mathurā in the field of Prabhāsa by Kriṣṅa. All the world is invited to attend it, but he does not invite the people of the Vṛindā groves. Nanda and Yaçodā hear of the sacrifice and so do the shepherds. Uninvited they go, for they cannot bear separation from him any longer. The gate-keepers prevent them from having an interview with the king. Yaçodā importunes them at every gate to be allowed to have a sight of her dear Kriṣṅa, but the gate-keepers take her to be a mad woman and will not allow her to pass into the Royal presence. Struck with grief Yaçodā falls to the ground sighing in a manner which rends the heart to behold. Suddenly in the great hall Kriṣṅa with the Sruka—the golden sacrificial cup—reciting mantras falters in his speech;

suddenly a tear starts to his eyes and he clasps his brother Valarāma to his breast saying "O tell me, Brother, where is my unfortunate mother, where are my comrades of the Vrindā groves and where is my Rādhā? Away with my royal robes and kingdom ;—where are the scenes of our boyhood—the dear Jumnā and its bowers ?'' The whole scene changes—from the grandeur of a royal palace to the groves of Vrindā.

The reason why he did not invite the people of Vrindāvana is that he held them as his own, and it would be dishonouring the sacred relationship to send the formal letter of invitation due only to those who are more or less distant.

Govinda Dās 1537-1612 A.D.

Of the *Pada kartas* (lit. masters of songs) that followed Vidyāpati and Chandidās, the greatest by unanimous consent of all parties is Govinda Dās. We find accounts of this poet's life in Bhaktiratnākara, Narottamavilāsa, Sārāvali, Anurāgavallī, and Bhaktamāla. He was a son of Chiranjiva Sen, an illustrious companion of Chaitanya Deva and was a grandson, on his mother's side, of Dāmodara who was a great Sanskrit poet and scholar of Çrīkhanda at the time. Chiranjiva left his village home at Kumāranagara and settled at Çrīkhanda where he had married. But the Çākta element there was powerful and showed open hostility towards the Vaiṣṇavas. The result was that Govinda Dās had to leave Çrīkhanda in his old age and settle at the village of Teliā Vudhuri on the Pudmā.

Govinda Dās belonged to the Vaidya or the physician caste. His elder brother Rāma Chandra

Kavirāja was a famous scholar and a friend of Narottama Thākura. It is said that Govinda Dās formerly belonged to the Çākta sect, but having recovered from a serious attack of dysentery at the age of forty through the help of a devout Vaiṣṇava, he adopted that faith and became a disciple of the famous Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya.

Brajabuli.

His songs on Rādhā and Kriṣṇa are held in great appreciation by the people. They are written in that sweet mixed dialect which is called the Brajabuli. Bengali by eliminating the Prākṛita elements, and adopting the more rigid forms of Sanskrit has lost some of its natural mellifluousness but in Brajabuli we find a preponderance of Prākṛita words together with a sprinkling of Maithili which contributes greatly to the softness of the mixed tongue. Brajabuli is not the spoken dialect of any province; yet it is not at all an artificial dialect. The choice Prākṛita words to be found in old Bengali together with some of the soft-sounding Maithil words are combined in Brājabuli in an artistic manner. And the curious medley has been made singularly sweet and pleasing to the ear by the Vaiṣṇavas in the *padas*. And Govindadās particularly, who imitates Vidyāpati in his songs, is a perfect master of this mixed language. His songs which are only next to those of Chandidās and Vidyāpati in poetic merit are quite unmatched for their sweetness of language and show a wealth of rhythmical expression which brings him into the first rank of early Bengali poets.

His padas.

In the last years of his life we find the poet occupied in making a collection of his songs at Vudhuri.

*"In close retirement he was occupied in making a compilation of his precious songs with a gladsome heart."

Govinda Dās's *padas* were sung during his life-time by Gokuladās and Çrīdās, two brothers —inhabitants of Kānchā Gaḍiyā, who enjoyed a great reputation in the Vaiṣṇava community as singers; and it is related in Narottama-vilāsa that Vira Bhadra Gosvāmi and Jiva Gosvāmi, two great apostles of the Vaiṣṇava faith, delighted in his songs and being full of admiration for the poet embraced him as a mark of their satisfaction when his *padas* were sung before them by the two gifted brothers.

Besides his Bengali *padas*, Govindaās wrote two Sanskrit works of great poetic beauty *viz.*, Sangita Mādhava and Karṇāmṛita.

Govinda Dās was born at Çrikhanda in 1537 A.D. and died at Telia Vudhuri in 1612 A.D.

I give below two *padas* by Govinda Dās. Rādhā feels that she cannot bear life forsaken by Kriṣṇa. She says :—

†"Let my body after death be reduced to the earth of those paths which will be touched by the

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* "নির্জ্জনে বসিয়া নিজ পদরত্নগণে।
করেন একত্র অতি উল্লাসিত মনে॥"
Bhaktiratnākara, Chap. XIV.

† "যাঁহা যাঁহা অরুণ চরণে চলি যাত।
তাঁহা তাঁহা ধরণী হইএ মঝু গাত॥
যো সরোবরে পঁহু নিতি নিতি নাহ।
হাম ভরি সলিল হোই তথি মাহ॥

beautiful feet of Kriṣṇa. Let it be melted into the water of the tank where Kriṣṇa bathes. When I shall have expired, let my spirit live as the lustre of the mirror in which Kriṣṇa sees his face. O, let it be turned into a gentle breeze for the fan with which he cools himself. Wherever Kriṣṇa moves like a new-born cloud, may I become the sky behind, to form the back-ground of his beautiful form."

* "He for whose sake the reproofs of the elders and the slanderous tongues of the wicked were nothing to me;—he for whom I loved all the ills of life as if they were good fortune,—and for whom I broke my sacred maidenhood, foregoing the law observed by wedded wives,—strange, passing strange it is, that he wants to forsake me! How hard is this to believe! He who would leave his palace of pearls in expectation of meeting me and pass the whole night on thorny briers looking wistfully towards my path and he for whom timid damsel that I am, I would walk on dark nights so

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যো দরপণে পঁহু নিজ মুখ চাহ।
মঝু অঙ্গ জ্যোতি হোই তথি মাহ॥
যো বীজনে পঁহু বীজই গাত।
মঝু অঙ্গ তাহি হোই মৃদু বাত॥
যাঁহা পঁহু ভরমই জলধর শ্যাম।
মঝু অঙ্গ গগন হোই তছু ঠাম॥"

*"যাহক লাগি, গুরুগঞ্জনে মন রঞ্জনু, দুরজন কিয়ে নাহি কেল।
যাহক লাগি, কুলবতী বরত সমাপল, লাজে তিলাঞ্জলি দেল॥
সজনি জানলু কঠিনু কঠিন পরাণ।
ব্রজপুর পরিহরি যাওব সো হরি শুনইতে নাহি বাহিরান॥

lost in love that if a venomous snake had coiled round my feet, I should have considered it as *nupura* to adorn them,—says Govinda Dās, it is not possible for him to forget this great love."

Jñana Dās and Valarāma Dās.

Next to Govinda Dās we may name Jñana Dās and Valarāma Dās. Jñana Dās was born at Kaṇḍrā, in the district of Birbhum and Valarāma Dās belonged to the Vaidya caste and was an inhabitant of Çrīkhanda. His father was one Ātmarāma Dās. Both Jñana Dās and Valarāma Dās imitated the style of Chandidās in their songs as Govindadās did that of Vidyāpati and the two poets were contemporary with Govinda Dās. One of the most important festivals of the Vaiṣṇavas that was ever held in Bengal was the Mahotsava ceremony of Çrīkheturi. Narottama Dās who had renounced the world and embraced the vow of Sanyāsin was the heir to the *gadi* of Kheturi, the deceased Raja, Kriṣṇa Chandra Datta being his father. As however he did not accept the Raj, but made a gift of it to his cousin Santoṣa Datta, the latter out of gratitude and admiration for the Vaiṣṇava worthy called in all members of the Vaiṣṇava community to Çrīkheturi at a Mahotsava ceremony held by him with great *eclat* in 1504 A.D. The ceremony was a grand success and was in fact an historic

The Mahatsava at Çrīkheturi 1504 A.D.

যো মঝু সরস সমাগম লাগস মণিময় মন্দির ছোড়ি।
কণ্টক কুঞ্জে জাগি নিশি বাসব পন্থ নেহারত মোরি॥
যাহক লাগি চলইতে চরণে পড়ল ফণী মণি-মঞ্জীর করি মানি।
গোবিন্দ দাস ভণ কৈছন সো দিন বিছুরবা ইহ অনুমানি॥"

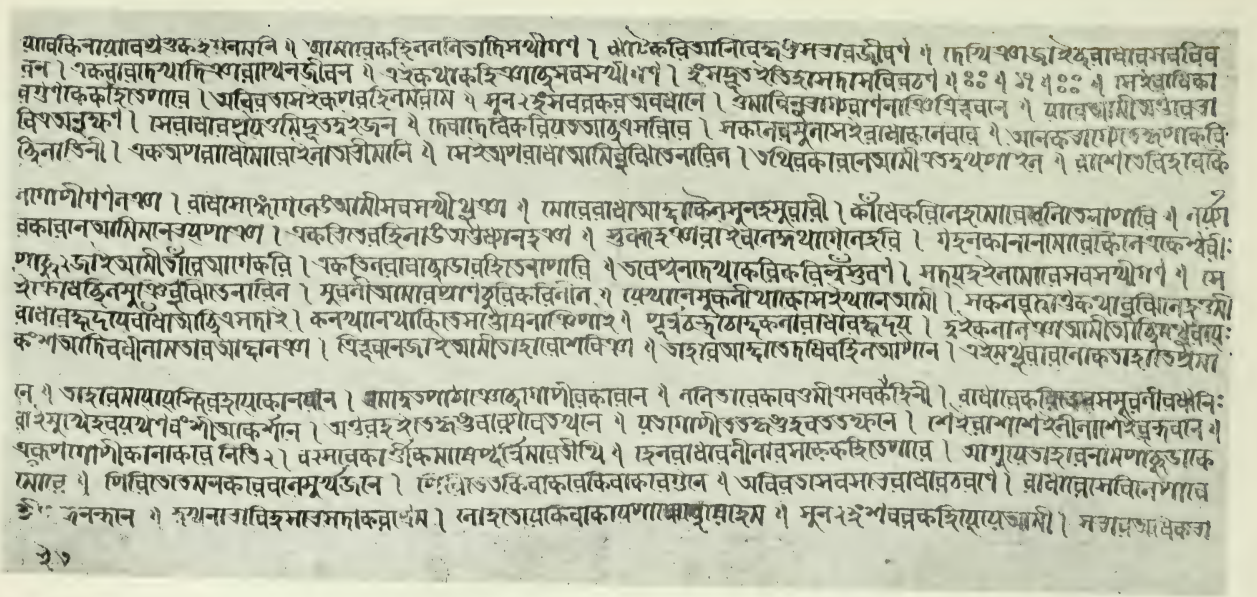
Padakalpataru, second chap. 1624th Pada.

event in Vaiṣṇava society having been graphically described by many writers, chiefly by Narahari Chakravarti who in his Narottama Vilāsa gives an elaborate list of the important members of the Vaiṣṇava community who attended it. Govindadās, Jñana Dās, Valarāma Dās were all there and Vṛindāvana Dās, the famous author of Chaitanya Bhagavata, was at the time a hoary-headed old man, described as 'venerable and learned' who took a prominent part in the affairs of the ceremony. We also find Vasanta Roy there—the clever poet who revised Vidyāpati's poems and changed his Maithili to elegant Brajabuli in which we find his poems in the Bengali collections of the present day. The Mahotsava ceremony at Çrīkheturi is indeed a landmark in the history of the Vaiṣṇavas and a sort of light-house discovering to our view a whole panorama of scenes in which the illustrious Vaiṣṇavas of the early 16th century, whose names are so familiar to us by their writings, played an important part. Besides, the history of social manners and customs and ways of life of the Vaiṣṇavas of that period have been faithfully recorded in the accounts of this festival.

About the other Padakartās we jot down the following notes :—

Jadunandana Dās born 1537.

Jadunandana Dās, born in 1537 A.D. He wrote an historical work called Karṇānanda in 1607 at the command of Çrīmati Hemalatā, daughter of Çrīnivās Āchāryya. He was 70 years old when he wrote the above work. Jadunandana, besides, tarnslated Govindalilamṛita by Kriṣṇa Dās Kavirāj and Vidagdha Mādhaba, a drama by Rupa Gosvāmi from Sanskrit into Bengali metrical verse.



Page of Bengali M.S. of Govinda Lilamrita from the district of Behar, Date 1701. Note close affinity of characters to Deva Nagri.

Jadunandana Chakravarti.

Jadunandana Chakravarti wrote, Rādhā Kriṣṅa Lilākadamva, a Bengali poem containing 6000 couplets. He was a disciple of Gadādhara Dās.

Prema Dās

Prema Dās, (the Vaiṣṅava name adopted by Purusottama Siddhanta Vāgiça) was born in Kuliā in Navadwipa. He wrote the Vamçi Çikṣā, already noticed on page 513, in 1712 A.D. and translated Chaitanya Chandrodaya, a Sanskrit drama by Kavikarṇapura into Bengali verse.

Gourī Dās.

Gourī Dās, a highly respected personage of the Vaiṣṅava community and a contemporary of Chaitanya Deva. It is said that the latter presented Gourī Dās with a Gitā copied by himself and also an oar with which he rowed his small pleasure-boat on the Ganges. Gourī made an image of Chaitanya Deva in Nimba wood when the latter was on the eve of taking Sanyasin's vows. This historic image is still worshipped at Ambikānagara in Kālnā.

Narahari Sarkāra 1487-1540 A.D.

Narahari Sarkāra (1487-1540) of Çrīkhanda—a friend and follower of Chaitanya Deva. Chaitanya Deva is said to have exclaimed when in a trance in a village of southern India "O Narahari, dear as my life, where art thou now? Recite Kriṣṅa's name once more and I will embrace thee."* Narahari belonged to the Vaidya caste. His father's name was Nārāyana. He wrote many padas in praise of Chaitanya.

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* "কখন বলেন কোথা প্রাণ নরহরি।
হরি নাম শুনি তোমা আলিঙ্গন করি॥"
Govinda Dās's Kaḍchā.

Vasu Ramānanda.

Vasu Rāmānanda—a grandson of Mālādhara Vasu who translated the Bhāgavata into Bengali. Rāmānanda was a contemporary of Chaitanya Deva.

Raya Rāmānanda.

Raya Rāmānanda—the illustrious Prime Minister of King Prataprudra of Orissa and author of the Sanskrit drama, Jagannātha Vallabha which Chaitanya delighted to read. Rāmānanda Rāy was a great friend and follower of Chaitanya. He has left some Bengali *padas* of singular beauty; the following one finds a place in Chaitanya Charitāmṛita and has a deep spiritual meaning which must be explained in the light of Vaiṣṇava philosophy.

* 1. "At first love dawned (on my heart) by a glance of his eye.

2. It went on growing and knew no stop.

3. When Cupid entered our souls, forgetful we became that he was a man and I a woman.

4. O maidens, ask him, how could he have forgot all this story now!

5. Nor had we, in this love, waited for a secret agent or any third party. In this union Cupid was our guide." The idea contained in the 3rd stanza is mystic.

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* "পহিলহি রাগ নয়ন ভঙ্গে ভেল।
অনুদিন বাড়ল অবধি না গেল॥
না সো রমন না হাম রমণী।
দুহু মনে মনোভব পশিল জানি॥
এ সখি সে সব প্রেম কাহিনী।
কানু ঠামে কহব বিছুরব জানি॥
না খোঁজল দূতি না খোঁজল আন।
দুহুঁকো মিলনে মধ্যস্থ পাঁচ বাণ॥"

Rāma Rāy died in 1584 A.D.

Narahari Chakravarti.

Narahari Chakravarti—author of Narottamavilāsa and Bhaktiratnākara—the celebrated biographical and historical works already mentioned, wrote a large number of *padas* under the name of Ghana Çyāma Dās. There is also another Ghana Çyāma—a *padakarta*, son of Divya Sinha and grandson of Govindadās, the illustrious poet.

Rama Gopala Dās

Pitāmvara Dās.

Rāma Gopāla Dās—the author of Rasakalpavalli (written in 1643 A.D.) wrote many *padas* of exquisite beauty and his son Pitāmvara Dās author of Rasamunjari contributed a good number of *padas* to Vaiṣṅava collections.

Jagadānanda.

Jagadānanda, a Vaidya by caste. He was a descendant of Mukunda, one of the contemporaries of Chaitanya. They were originally residents of Çrikhanda, but afterwards settled at the village of Yophalai in the district of Burdwan. Jagadānanda cared only for sweet words in his *padas*. We have come across some of the drafts of his composition in his own handwriting which show that he was far from being a born poet; he acquired the power of writing poetry by mastering the vocabulary of sweet sounding words, as a school-boy acquires a knowledge of Geography by noting the places in his memory. One of the draft shows that he made himself busy to find out the synonyms of words to be used in his songs. On the other page of the said draft he scribbled doggerels with the words on his list; he cared for nothing else than to create a pleasant jingle with them. He writes a line and then cuts it through and repeats the process several times, all the while evidently

turning over the other page with the object of drawing upon the vocabulary which seems to be the only source of his inspiration; thus correcting words continually with the help derived from it, he lights upon highly ornate expressions and composes a couplet in which rhythm is done to a fault; such couplets we find in the Padakalpataru and we cannot help enjoying the humour of the herculian efforts put forth to give them the shape in which they are finally presented to us. They hardly convey any sense through the jingle of words which it was the primary object of the poet to create. Jagadānanda died in 1704 at Yophalai where a *mela* is held every year to commemorate his death. A collection of his *padas* with a learned preface was published not long ago by the late Babu Kali Dās Nāth of Calcutta.

Vaṁçi Vadana. Vaṁçī Vadana, son of Chhakaḍi Chattopadhyaya. Vaṁçī Vadan was born in the village of Pātuli in 1498 A.D.

Rāma Chandra. Rāma Chandra—a grandson of Vaṁçī Vadana. He settled at the village of Rādhānagara. He migrated from Pātuli to Rādhānagara on the Pudma. Born in 1534 A.D. died in 1584 A.D.

Çachī Nandana. Çachī Nandana—brother of Rāma Chandra. Besides *padas* he wrote a poem called the Gourānga Vijaya.

Parameçvari Dās. Parameçvari Dās. We find a mention of this Padakartā in connection with the Mahotsava ceremony at Kheturi which he attended in 1504 A.D.

Jadunātha Āchāryya. Jadunātha Āchāryya—son of Ratnāgarva Ācāryya a friend and follower of Chaitanya Deva. The

family which originally resided at Sylhet migrated to Navadvipa during Chaitanya Deva's life-time.

Prasāda Dās.

Prasāda Dās—a native of Visṅupur in the district of Bankurā. He had the title of Kavipati.

Uddhava Dās.

Uddhava Dās—a friend of Vaiṣṅava Dās who compiled the celebrated Padakalpataru—an inhabitant of Teñā Vaidyāpura.

Rādhā Vallabha Dās.

Rādhā Vallabha Dās,—son of Sudhākar Mandal of Kāṅchāgaḍia and the compiler of a Bengali translation of Vilāpa Kusumānjali by Raghu Nāth Goswāmi.

Rāy Çekhara.

Ray Çekhara or Çaçi Çekhara—an inhabitant of the village of Parāṇa in the district of Burdwan. He lived early in the 18th century.

Paramānanda Sen.

Paramānanda Sen—a great Sanskrit poet who also wrote *padas* in Bengali. He was born in 1524. He is more commonly known by his title Kavikarṇapura. He wrote his celebrated Chaitanya Chandrodaya Nātaka in 1572 A.D

Vāsudeva Ghoṣa.

Vāsudeva Ghosa, Mādhava Ghose and Govindānanda Ghose, three brothers and contemporaries of Chaitanya Deva. All of them composed *padas* in Bengali. They were originally inhabitants of Kumārhatta, but finally settled at Navadvipa. They belonged to the Kāyastha caste. Vāsu Ghosa's *padas* in praise of Chaitanya are the best of their kind and they generally form the Gour Chandrikā or prelude to the songs of Rādhā and Kriṣṅa in all collection of Vaiṣṅava *padas*. The present Maharajā of Dinajpur is descended from Vāsu Ghoṣa through one of his daughters.

Champati Rāy. Champati Rāy—a famous Padakartā. We find the following line about him in the Sanskrit notes affixed to the Padāmrita Samudra by Rādhā mohan Thākura.

*"There lived in Southern India a great follower of Chaitanya by the name of Champati. He is this famous Padakartā."

Daivakinandana. Daivakinandana, a contemporary of Chaitanya Deva and author of Vaiṣṅava Vandanā.

Narasinha Deva. Narasinha Deva—Rāja of Pakva Palli whose efforts to vanquish Narottama Thākur in a controversial discussion culminated in complete failure and his own acceptance of the creed of the Vaiṣṅavas. The Rājā wrote several padas of great beauty.

Vira Hāmvira. Rājā Vir Hāmvira of Viṣṅupur to whom a reference has already been made, composed many *padas* some of which we find in the Bhaktiratnākara by Narahari Chakravarti.

Madhavī. Mādhavi—a sister of Çikhi Māhiti and a contemporary of Chaitanya wrote *padas* under the name of Mādhavi Dās. She was renowned for her piety and purity of life.

This is, briefly, an account of only a few of the great masters of songs who followed Chaitanya Deva. A brief notice of some more Padakartās is to be found in my Bengali work 'Vangabhāṣā O Sāhitya,' in the Bengali Encyclopædia—the Viçva Koṣa and in the collection of songs in praise of Chaitanya

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* "চম্পতি নাম দাক্ষিণাত্য-শ্রীকৃষ্ণ-চৈতন্য-ভক্তরাজঃ
কশ্চিৎ আসীৎ স এব গীতকর্ত্তা।"

Padāmrita Samudra.

Deva edited by the late Babu Jagatbandhu Bhadra and published by the Vangiya Sāhitya Pariṣat, Calcutta. I give below a list of the Padakartās whose *padas* I have been able to collect up to the present with the number of *padas* they composed.

A list of the Pada-kartās.

NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.	NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.
Ananta Dās	47	Ananta Ācharyya	2
Ākvar āli	1	Atmārāma Dās	9
Ānanda Dās	3	Bhupati Nāth	7
Bhuvana Dās	2	Chandi Dās	960
Chandra Çekhara	3	Champati Thākur	13
Chuḍamani Dās	1	Chaitanya Dās	15
Çankara Dās	4	Çachinandana Das	3
Çaçī Çekhara	3	Çyamā Chanda Dās	1
Çyamā Dās	3	Çyamānanda	7
Çiva Rāy	1	Çivarām Dās	25
Çivānanda	4	Çiva Sahachari	1
Çivāi Dās	7	Çrīnivāsa	3
Çrinivāsācharyya	2	Çekhera Rāy	176
Dalapati	1	Dīna Ghoṣe	1
Dīnahīna Dās	3	Dukhi Kriṣṇa Dās	4
Dukhīni	2	Daivakinandana Dās	4
Dharamā Dās	3	Gatigovinda	1
Gadādhara	3	Giridhara	1
Gupta Dās	1	Gokulānanda	1
Gokula Dās	1	Gopāla Dās	6
Gopāla Bhatta	2	Gopīkanta	1
Gopīramana	1	Govardhana Dās	17
Govinda Dās	458	Govinda Ghoṣa	12
Gourmohona	2	Goura Dās	2
Gour Sundara	3	Gouri Dās	2
Ghanarāma Dās	14	Ghana Çyama Dās	35
Hari Dās	7	Hari Vallabha	4

NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.	NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.
Harekrishṇa Dās	2	Harerāma Dās	2
Jagadānanda Dās	5	Jagannātha Dās	9
Jagamohona Dās	2	Jaykrishṇa Dās	1
Jñāna Dās	194	Jñanahari Dās	2
Kavira	1	Kaviranjana	9
Kamarali	1	Kanāi Dās	4
Kanu Dās	14	Kāmadeva	1
Kalikiçore	179	Krishṇa Kanta Dās	29
Krishṇa Das	22	Krishṇa Pramoda	2
Krishṇa Prasad	5	Laksmī Kanta Dās	1
Lochana Dās	30	Mathurā Dās	1
Madhu Sudana	5	Maheça Vasu	1
Manohara Dās	6	Madhava Ghoṣa	9
Mādhava Dās	65	Madhavāchāryya	5
Mādhavi Dās	17	Madhu	3
Murāri Gupta	5	Murāri Dās	1
Mohona Dās	27	Mohani Dās	4
Natavara	1	Nandana Dās	1
Nanda (Dvija)	1	Nayanānanda Dās	22
Narasinha Dās	1	Narahari Dās	22
Narottama Dās	61	Nava Kanta Dās	1
Nava Chandra Dās	2	Naranārāyan Bhupati	1
Nasir Mamud	1	Nṛipati Sinha	1
Nṛisinha Deva	4	Parameçwara Dās	1
Paramānanda Dās	12	Pitamvara Dās	0
Phakir Havir	1	Phātana	1
Raghu Nātha	3	Rasamaya Dās	2
Rasamayi Dāsi	1	Rasika Dās	3
Rama Kanta	1	Rāma Chandra Dās	6
Rama Dās	2	Rāmi	2
Rama Ray	1	Rādhā Mohona	175
Raja Sinha Bhupati	4		

NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.	NAME.	NUMBER OF PADAS.
Rādhā Vallabha	29	Rādhā Mādhava	1
Rāmānanda	15	Ramānanda Dās	1
Rāmānanda Vasu	9	Rupanārāyan	3
Sadānanda	1	Salavega	1
Sinha Bhupati	7	Sundara Dās	2
Suvala	1	Sekha Jālāl	1
Sekh Bhik	1	Sekh Lāl	1
Saiyad Martuja	1	Tulasī Dās	1
Uddhava Dās	110	Vala Deva	1
Valarama Dās	131	Valāi Dās	3
Vallabhā Dās	26	Vaṁçī Vadana	38
Vasanta Ray	33	Vāsudeva Ghoṣa	134
Vijayānanda Dās	1	Vidyāpati	800
Vindu Dās	4	Vipra Dās	6
Vipra Dāsa Ghoṣa	161	Viçvambhara Dās	2
Vira Chandra Kar	1	Vira Nārāyana	2
Vira Vallabha Dās	1	Vira Hāmvira	2
Vaiṣṇava Dās	27	Vṛindāvana Dās	30
Vrajānanda	1	Yadunandana	95
Yadu Nātha Dās	17	Yadupati	1
Yaçorāja Khān	1	Yādavendra	3

Next to Vidyāpati and Chandī Dās, the following *pada-kartas* enjoy precedence for their poetical excellence and delineation of tender emotions.

1. Govinda Dās.
2. Jñāna Dās.
3. Valarama Dās.
4. Ray Çekhara.
5. Ghana Çyama.
6. Rāi Vasanta.
7. Ananta Dās.
8. Yadu Nandana Dās.
9. Vaṁçī Vadana.
10. Vāsu Ghoṣa.
11. Narahari.

This *pada* literature is a mine of poetry. It breathes freedom from the rigid style of the old

The padas breathe a spirit of freedom.

writers who were always aiming at classical figures of speech. Here we find classical figures only occasionally, but more often the poets hit upon common-place objects and translate them into apt and happy similes. The style of the best amongst the *pada kartas* is free from all slavish imitation of Sanskrit models and is full of appropriate homely words and happy turns of expression taken from common life which discovers the innate strength of our language. By adopting the Braja Buli, the *pada kartas* not only made their language a fitter vehicle of tender thought, but gave scope for contributions to this literature by poets out-side Bengal. Hence it is that we find the songs of Champatipati, a poet of southern India and of Mādhavi and Rāma Rāi, who belonged to Orissa, collected in Bengali compilation of songs. These poets found it easier to adopt Brajabuli than Bengali, as the former had in it a profuse admixture of Hindi which people of all parts of India spoke and understood.

The advantages of adopting Brajabuli.

In an earlier chapter of our history we have noticed that rustic songs such as Mānik Chandra Rājār *gan* were full of common place words taken from life. The writers of these songs could not use Sanskritic expressions simply because they were illiterate; but the *pada* literature of the Vaiṣṇavas abounds, as I have already said, in loose Prakrita forms—not as a result of ignorance of Sanskrit, for these poets were almost all Sanskrit scholars, but because they had a finer power of perception as compared with the poets of the Sanskritic school and knew better than they, that the poetic vision must be supplied from life and not from

The pada-kartas prefer Prakrita forms.

classical studies alone. They drew richly, moreover, from the living fountain of love that was before them—in the ecstasies of Chaitanya's divine love.

The fastidious Hindu Socity and Rādhā.

As in style of composition, so in their descriptions of social life, the same spirit of freedom dominates. In the poetic literature of the Hindus, the fidelity of woman has always formed the loftiest theme and has naturally supplied the highest poetic inspiration. But Vaiṣṇava literature glories in Rādhā who breaks the sacred ties of domestic life and walks in the unrestrained path of freedom from all social bondage. How could a society so rigidly fastidious in point of woman's honour admire Rādhā and allow her such an elevated place in their literature? The answer is a very simple one. Rādhā, as has been already said, is a religious symbol—a typification of the free worship offered by the human soul to God. In Bengali songs the spiritual significance of this symbol has been made apparent by associations with Chaitanya Deva—Rādhā having been represented in them as the very spirit of God-realisation manifested by the great devotee.

Domestic relationship given a high place.

Besides, viewed in a spiritual light, domestic relationship has been given a greatly elevated place in the literature of the Vaiṣṇavas. In the parent, in the child, in the friend and in all around us, it is the same benign hand that the Vaiṣṇavas mark, offering love and unsolicited service to us. Domestic ties are therefore sacred to them. Their literature is a history of this all-sacrificing disinterested love.

Nothing in return.

Nothing in return is its motto. The flowe that defuses its sweet scent does not want an return, nor do the rays of the sun that warm you nor the air which you breathe—without which yo cannot live for a moment, and all this represent the sort of love which a real lover must hav for the world. Those who want return in love an consider it a marketable commodity are not priv leged to have access into the *pada* literature o the Vaiṣṇavas. When poor Rādhā was dying- being forsaken by Kriṣṇa, she tells Vṛindā " Say n cruel words to him. His face beautiful as th moon will turn pale, if you use rude words. M heart breaks at the thought of it." Yet no on could be more cruel than was Kriṣṇa to Rādhā This may be denominated mere sentimentalism an be unacceptable to the materialistic mind. But th Vaiṣṇavas aspire to practising an absolutely resig ed love in life, which has unnumbered woes t poison it unless we see everything in the spirit o such love.

The collection of padas.

Of the collections of *padas* by the Vaiṣṇav masters the most bulky is reported to be Pad samudra, compiled by Manohara Dās in the midd of the 16th century. It is said to contain 150 *padas*. This vast collection has not yet seen th

Pada-Samudra.

light and the only manuscript-copy of the work which we have heard, was with the late Hārādhan Bhaktinidhi of Vadanganja in the district of Hugh He used to send me songs copied from the work no and then, but since his death I have not been able

Padāmrita Samudra.

trace the Ms. The next collection Padāmrit Samudra was made by Rādhā Mohona Thāku grandson of Çrinivās Āchāryya towards the e

the 16th century. . The learned compiler affixed anskrit annotations to the Bengali *padas* in his ollection thereby showing great scholarship. The notations are named as the Mahābhāvānusāri-kā. There are many smaller collections some which enjoy great popularity, such as Padakalpa-tikā by Goura Mohana Dās, Gita Chintāmaṅi, by Hari Vallabha, Gīta Chandrodaya by Narahari hakravartī, Pada Chintāmaṅimālā by Prasāda Dās, asamanjarī by Pītāmvara Dās, Līlā Samudra, adārnavasārāvali, Gīta Kalpalatikā and other orks by unknown compilers.

Smaller collections.

But we have not yet named the collection which the best of them all, and deservedly enjoyes the reatest popularity. It is Padakalpataru by Vaiṣ-ava Dās. Vaiṣṅava Dās, lit. servant of the aiṣṅavas, is the title which the compiler adopted token of humility. His name was Gakulānanda en and he was a Vaidya by caste. He was an habitant of Teña Vaidyapura in the district of urdwan and he compiled his work early in the 8th century.

Padakalpa-taru.

It would be difficult to recover Padasamudra hich is by far the greatest collection of the Vaiṣ-ava songs. Of the rest Padamṛitasamudra by Rādhā Mohon Thākur is a much smaller collection han Padakalpataru; but the compiler has inserted it more than 400 *padas* composed by himself hice is too large a number to find place in the ollection if we consider their poetic excellence. n the larger collection by Vaiṣṅava Dās we find nly 27 *padas* of his own and these he was bound o insert as preliminary *padas* in honour of the

Its relative merit.

great Vaiṣṇava masters. Pada Chintāmaṇi though a very small collection is a singularly fine one containing 351 padas. The only defect of this work lies in the anxiety of the compiler to select *padas* which please the ear in preference to those which appeal to the heart.

The Padakalpataru is a collection of 3,101 *padas* and is divided into four Çākhās or Chapters. The first chapter contains 11 *pallavas* or sub-chapters. The number of *padas* in them is 265. The second chapter has 24 *pallavas* with 351 *padas*. The third has 31 *pallavas* with 965 *padas* and the fourth chapter 36 *pallavas* and with 1520 *padas*. The classification is made in the order in which emotions grow and develop in the heart. The subtlety and fineness of this classification will interest the student of Psychology. Though the compiler has followed the rules of rhetoric in the classification of the songs, the songs themselves are not directed by rhetoric, but come from the heart of the poets direct and appeal to the heart of the readers.

A classification of the finer emotions.

In the preliminary account given by Vaiṣṇava Dās in his Padakalpataru we find the following lines:

Vaiṣṇava Dās's account of himself.

* "In the line of Çrinivās Ācharyya was born Rādhā Mohana Thākur. Who can describe the noble qualities that he possessed. He was a second

* "আচার্য্য প্রভুর বংশ শ্রীরাধামোহন।
কে কহিতে পারে তাঁর গুণের বর্ণন॥
যাহার বিগ্রহে গৌর প্রেমের নিবাস।
হেন শ্রীআচার্য্য প্রভুর দ্বিতীয় প্রকাশ॥

incarnation of Çīrnivās Āchāryya and his heart was the true home of love for Chaitanya. Rādhā Mohana Thākur compiled a collection of *padas* known as Padamṛitasamudra (a song-ocean of nector). I used to sing the *padas* from that work and was greatly interested in them. I travelled in various countries and collected other *padas* including those found in the Padāmṛitasamudra in my work. He was my model and I compiled my book after his work and named it Padakalpataru."

গ্রন্থ কৈলা পদামৃতসমুদ্র আখ্যান।
জন্মিল আমার লোভ তাহা করি গান॥
নানা পর্য্যটনে পদ সংগ্রহ করিয়া।
তাহার যতেক পদ সব তাহা লইয়া॥
সেই মূল গ্রন্থ অনুসারে ইহা কৈল।
প্রাচীন প্রাচীন পদ যতেক পাইল॥
এই গীত পদকল্প নাম কৈনু সার॥"

Pada No. 3,031. Padakalpataru.

Supplementary Notes

TO

CHAPTER V.

—o—

Chaitanya did not organise the Vaiṣṇava society.

Chaitanya Deva himself was not the organiser of the Vaiṣṇava community that afterwards sprang up in Bengal. In fact it was not his mission to make codes and regulations for the guidance of a small community. He spoke for all men, lived for all men, and lost in the love of God as he was, he was not at all actuated by any desire of a secular kind, to establish a community and claim the glory of being its founder. But a great idea—the idea of equality and freedom—was put into a stereotyped and orthodox society. The Chandals and the Parias felt that they were no heriditary bondsmen;—the Çudras felt that the Brahmins were not the only souls privileged to interpret the truths of religion. Freeing themselves from the iron grip of Brahmanic rule and the trammels of monastic codes, the people of all castes gave quick response to the call from the new order that was being formed. In the Buddhistic age fallen women and men who had lost their caste, flocked to the sanctuary of the *viharas* and shaving their heads as a sign of penitence became monks and nuns. On the revival of Hinduism the portals of society were closed against this class of people and they had no *locus standi* in the land of their birth, after the

The idea of equality and freedom.

The Buddhist masses.

fall of the Buddhistic monasteries. These men and women heard of the great idea of universal love preached by the Vaiṣṅavas who had raised the flag of equality for all men and they quickly responded to the call. Chaitanya Deva lived at Puri for the last 18 years of his life, and all this time he dwelt on man's relation to God and showed the power and beauty of the Divine grace, by his own life and example. In Khardah and Çantipur, however, Nityānanda and Advaitāchāryya initiated a great movement for organising the Vaiṣṅava community on a new basis. The place is still pointed out at Khardah where 1200 Naḍas or shaven men and 1300 Naḍies or shaven women—the Buddhist Bhikṣus and Bhikṣunies came to the great Vaiṣṅava apostle Nityānanda and surrendered themselves to him. He took them into his new order. So glad were these people at being admitted to the new order, that they have since held a *mela* at Khardah every year in commemoration of the event. Nityānanda is justly called *patita pavana* or "a friend of the fallen" owing to his sympathetic attitude towards the out-castes. The fallen women of Hindu society also, against whom it has always closed its gate with iron bars, found a place in the Vaiṣṅava community. Widow marriage is allowed amongst the lay Vaiṣṅavas, who override all considerations of caste; in fact it is forbidden to ask a Vaiṣṅava to what caste he had belonged before he accepted the Vaiṣṅava faith. With what indignation the Hindu society looked upon this movement may be seen from the following *slokas* in Tantraratnākar. Vatuka Bhairava asked Ganadeva if the great demon Tripurāsura killed by

Nityānanda and Advaita.

The Buddhist Bhiksus and Bhiksunies.

The tota upsetting of the old Society

Çiva was altogether annihilated or still lived in the form of a spirit, Ganadeva answered.

Chaitanya and his companions as incarnations of the Demon Tripurāsura.

*"The great demon Tripurāsura being killed by Çiva reduced himself into three parts in great rage, and devised many plans for the overthrow of the Çaiva religion, and for misguiding the people and taking vengence on the followers of Çiva. The first part appeared in the womb of Çachī Devī and came into the world as Chaitanya; the second part was incarnated in Nityānanda who weilded a great power and the third as Advaita. Assuming these three forms this lord of the demons came to earth in the Kali Yuga and deluded the world by teaching effeminacy."—effeminacy because Chaitanya Deva did not recognise such cruel rites in religion as human or animal sacrifices, but taught that one should know his sins and in a truly penitent spirit approach his God with tears! The Vaiṣṇavas abstained from fish and meat altogether and from all intoxicating

* "স এষ ত্রিপুরো দৈত্যঃ নিহতঃ শূলপাণিনা।
কষয়া পরয়াবিষ্ট আত্মানমকরোত্রিধা॥
শিবধর্ম্মবিনাশায় লোকানাং মোহহেতবে।
হিংসার্থং শিবভক্তানামুপায়ান সৃজদ্বহূন্॥
অংশেনাদ্যেন গৌরাখ্যঃ শচীগর্ভে বভূব সঃ।
নিত্যানন্দো দ্বিতীয়েন প্রাদুরাসীন্মহাবলঃ॥
অদ্বৈতাখ্যস্তৃতীয়েন ভাগেন দনুজাধিপঃ।
প্রাপ্তে কলিযুগে ঘোরে বিজহার মহীতলে॥
ততো দুরাত্মা ত্রিপুরঃ শরীরৈস্ত্রিভিরাসুরৈঃ।
উপপ্লবায় লোকানাং নারীভাবমুপাদিশৎ॥"

drugs and liquors ; they were thus effeminate in the eyes of those who drank wine, took gānjā, ate all kinds of meat and were followers of *kapaliks*—those dreadful people who could perpetrate the most heinous crimes without a blush.

An incarnation of God.

The lay Vaiṣṅavas as a retort composed *slokas* to prove that Chaitanya was Viṣṅu incarnated in the flesh and interpolated them in the manuscripts of the Vāmana Purāṅa, the Vāyu Purāṅa, the Nāradiya Purāṅa, the Bhoviṣya Purāṅa, the Matsya Purāṅa, the Viṣṅu Jamala, the Garuḍa Purāṅa, the Viṣṅu Purāṅa, the Kurma Purāṅa, the Devī Purāṅa, the Skanda Purāṅa, the Vālmiki Purāṅa, the Nṛisinha Purāṅa, and in the Mahābhārata. These *slokas* signify in the form of a prophecy that God will be incarnated in Chaitanya Deva in *kali yuga*.

The activity with which the Vaiṣṅavas proceeded with their task of reforming society was remarkable. There is no sphere of Bengali life which does not bear the stamp of their influence. At early dawn in the winter-months every village in Bengal resounds with the *kirtans* of a class of Vaiṣṅavas called the Vairāgies who visit every house, from the hut of the rustic to the palace of the Raja, calling upon all to rise from their bed and offer thanks to God, as another day has dawned. Amongst the Tiprās, a hill-tribe living in the hills of Tippera, who speak broken Bengali, I found in circulation such learned Vaiṣṅava works as the Chaitanya Charitāmṛita and the Chaitanya Bhāgavata. Many of these men wear *tilak* marks like the Vaiṣṅavas, and the Manipurians are all zealous followers of the creed of Chaitanya

Deva. The people of Orissā are more devoted followers of Chaitanya Deva than even the Bengalees. The Vaiṣṅavas were anxious to do away with the pride of caste altogether. The Padakartās and other authors amongst the Vaiṣṅavas have adopted the title of Dās or servant in the place of their family surnames as a mark of humility. This word Dās in the orthodox society of Bengal is exclusively used by castes inferior to the Brahmins. But in the Vaiṣṅava literature all good Brahmins, not to speak of the inferior castes, delight in calling themselves 'Dās' and thereby eliminate the titles indicating their family status; this has often made it exceedingly difficult for us to find out to what caste or family a certain author amongst the Vaṣiṅavas belonged.

The title 'Dās.'

Vaiṣṅava influence in the Rāmāyaṅa.

The whole of the old Bengali literature subsequent to Chaitanya Deva bears the mark of the influence of the Vaiṣṅavas. The original Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivās is lost, but from fragmentary manuscripts of the 16th century that have come to hand, we may surmise that the poet conformed to the original epic of Vālmiki though he considerably abridged it; the interpolating hands of later writers are, however, distinctly traceable in the subsequent manuscripts and in the modernised version of the work which is found in the market. In this book we find the Rākṣasas or demons metamorphosed into saints and Vaiṣṅavas. In the whole range of our literature we can scarcely find a more curious matter than this transformation by Vaiṣṅava poets of the Rākṣasas of the Rāmāyaṅa. In the original epic of Vālmiki they are great warriors,—fighting to the last on the battle-field with unflinching

heroism. But in the modern editions of Krittivāsa's Rāmāyaṅa we frequently meet a great Rākṣasa on the battle field with the spirit of a devout Vaiṣṅava; he sees in Rāma an incarnation of God, and when such a feeling dominates in his mind the battle field is naturally transformed into a pulpit and sermons and hymns become the order of the day. Viravāhu a Rakṣasa, son of Rāvaṅa has come to fight with Rāma in the battle field. Here is the description:—* "From the back of the elephant Viravāhu beholds Rāma. His human form with dark blue complexion—the colour that we find in a fresh tuft of grass—is simply a mask to conceal his divinity. His locks hang in beautiful curls and his forehead is large. His demeanour is quiet and he is kind to all. The marks of ধ্বজ (flag), বজ্র (thunder-bolt), and of অঙ্কুশ (hook)—indicative of divine power—are distinct in his person. The bow in his hand is of

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* "গজপৃষ্ঠ হতে বীর নেহালে শ্রীরাম।
কপটে মনুষ্য দেহ দুর্ব্বাদল শ্যাম॥
চাঁচর চিকুর রামের চৌরস কপাল।
প্রসন্ন শরীর রাম পরম দয়াল॥
ধ্বজ বজ্রাঙ্কুশ চিহ্ন অতি মনোহর।
ভুবন মোহন রূপ শ্যামল সুন্দর॥
রামের হাতের ধনু বিচিত্র গঠন।
সকল শরীরে দেখে বিষ্ণুর লক্ষণ॥
নারায়ণ রূপ দেখি রাবণ কুমার।
নিশ্চয় জানিল রাম বিষ্ণুর অবতার॥
হাতের ধনুক বাণ ভূতলে ফেলিয়ে।
গজ হতে নামি কহে বিনয় করিয়ে॥
ধরণী লোটায় রহে জুড়ি দুই কর।
অকিঞ্চনে কর দয়া রাম রঘুবর॥

wonderful structure, and in all parts of his body are visible the marks of the great God Viṣṇu. On seeing these signs Viravāhu was convinced that Rāma was Viṣṇu himself: he threw away the bow from his hand and coming down from his elephant prostrated himself with closed palms before Rāma and said in great humility, 'I am a poor being, O Lord, have mercy on me. All praise be to thee O Rama—the refuge of the world. Thou that art truthful and master of thy passions,—an incarnation of Viṣṇu, to thee I make my obeisance. Thou art the first principle of the universe and in thee rests the phenomenal world. The Gods of the Trinity form a part of thee. The Vedas Sāma, Rika, Yaju and Atharva have all originated from thee, O Lord. It is not in my power to describe thy infinite attributes."

Virabāhu's humility.

Tarani & Rāvaṇa.

Tarani Sen, another Rākṣasa warrior comes with the *tilak* marks and Rāma's name stamped all over his body like a true Vaiṣṇava; and even the great Rāvaṇa addressed Rāma, his foe, with closed palms,* "I have committed endless sins; pardon me,

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প্রণমহ রামচন্দ্র সংসারের সার।
অগতির গতি তুমি বিষ্ণু অবতার॥
পুরুষ প্রকৃতি তুমি, তুমি চরাচর।
তোমার একাংশ ব্রহ্মা বিষ্ণু মহেশ্বর॥
সাম ঋক্ যজু অথর্ব্ব তোমা হতে।
অসীম মহিমা গুণ নারি সীমা দিতে॥"

Rāmayaṇa by Krittivasa.

* "জন্মিয়া ভারতভূমে আমি দুরাচার।
করেছি পাতক কত সংখ্যা নাহি তার॥
অপরাধ সকল ক্ষম হে দয়াময়॥"

Rāmāyaṇa by Krittivāsa.

O Lord." This may look odd, but one thing ought to be borne in mind in order to understand the situation. Faith in the incarnation of God was the dominant idea of that age in Bengal. If it were possible for us to realise the psychological condition of a soul who fervently believed that the person before him was God himself,—God who created the universe—the all merciful divinity in human flesh before him—what else could he do than sing his praises in devout worship as Viravāhu or Tarani Sen did. In Bengal the peoples' mind at the time was full of the God-man Chaitanya who had passed away like a heavenly vision. Jagāi, Mādhāi, Bhilapantha, and Naroji, great moral wrecks who could not resist the spell of his faith and became converts to the creed of love,—gave shape to the character of the Rakṣasas of the Rāmāyaṅa and the old mythology revived by a new touch of living history. The infidels figured as demons, and the battle-field was transformed into the scene of their reformation. The great personality of Chaitanya with his overflowing faith in God figured as the incarnation of Viṣṅu and modelled the Rāma of old Vālmiki in a new shape. Thus the material of the epic was curiously recast to form a new page of history, and all the incongruities and oddities which may strike us, become clear when we understand why the Rāmāyaṅa in this garb attracted the people of Bengal,—the change being form a battle-field to the *Sankritana* ground, from animosity to love, from fiction to reality.

The infidels as Rākṣasas and Rāma as Chaitanya.

In the songs of Umā which form a part of Çākta literature, we find one poet* describing her as

* Rama Prasada Sen.

Vaiṣṇava influence in Çākta and Çaiva Literature.

going to *gostha* or the meadows to tend the cows. This feature is evidently attributed to her in imitation of Kriṣṇa's *gostha*: the tender sentiments of Yaçodā are not unoften attributed to Menakā, mother of Umā in the literature of the Çāktas.

We find the Çiva of the Vedas transformed into an altogether different God in the Purāṇas. New features were added to his character which belonged to Buddha and thus he was represented in a light which satisfied the requirements of a particular period when Buddhistic ideas predominated. This process of continually remodelling the gods in accordance with the demands of particular epochs of Indian religious history, continues up to the present day, and it is this genius of the people of Bengal for giving a shape to the hoary gods of the Hindu-pantheon suitable to the tastes of the times, that keeps up a perennial flow of inspiration derived from the particular form of religion that may be prevalent at the time. Çivā himself takes on the Vaiṣṇava stamp in some of the songs composed in his honour after the advent of Chaitanya Deva. We quote a song below to illustrate this:—

* "Çiva losing all consciousness by taking drugs, dances in the company of ghosts. His horn

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* "ভাঙ্গে বিভোর ভোলানাথ ভূতগণ সঙ্গে নাচিছে।
হরে রাম হরে রাম মধুর ডুম্বুর বাজিছে॥
কর্ণেতে শোভিছে ধুস্তুর ফুল।
ধুস্তুর সেবনে আঁখি ঢুলু ঢুলু।
পেরানে বাঘছাল খসিয়া খসিয়া পড়িছে॥

An old song of Çiva.

sweetly sounds the name of Kriṣṅa. *Dhusturā flowers adorn his ears; and his eyes have a mad look from taking Dhusturā drug; his robe of tiger-skin is falling off from him."

This dance of Çiva is quite distinct from the destructive dance of the Rudra Deva of the Vedas. The dancing described in this song reminds us rather of the dance of Chaitanya Deva in his spiritual ecstasy. The look of madness, the repeating of Krisṅa's name, the loose robes,—the company of low-caste people who joined in his processions, as represented by the ghosts of Çiva, all significantly point to the Vaiṣṅava influence, without which this dance of Çiva becomes meaningless; it is a dance in spiritual ecstasy and should not be confounded with the dance of the destroyer of the universe that Çiva originally was. Çiva's love for drugs in this song symbolises the excess of emotion verging on madness which characterizes the Vaisṅava dance in a *Sankirtana* party.

Thus we see that Vaiṣṅavism influenced the society of Bengal in all its different sections; neither Çāktas nor Çaivas could resist that influence. The prevailing creeds strengthened themselves by assimilation of the attractive features of their more successful rival, such as has gone on from the beginning in Hindu society.

The apology of the vernacular authors.

During the Paurānic renaissance Bengali literature had not yet reached the stage when scholars could undertake writing in that language without

* Datura fastuosa.

some sort of apology. The activities of those who translated Sanskrit works into Bengali were employed in diverse channels, and works of great literary merit and scholarly patience had been already produced in our tongue; but in the vast literature belonging to the Paurānic Renaissance we scarcely come across one work in which its author does not refer to a command from a god to undertake a work in Bengali—communicated to him in a dream,—as if the stigma of such a humble undertaking would be removed by attributing it to divine inspiration. The authors of Dharma Maṅgala specially are fond of describing such dreams. In one of these the god Dharma is said not only to have directed its author to undertake a Bengali poem in his honour but to have condescended so far as to supply him with the ink, pen and paper for the purpose. The authors seem to have been always in great apprehension of what people might say of their adoption of the popular dialect for writing books; and in their dreams, we feel this throbbing pulse of fear, and an anxiety to prove to their honest, god-fearing and credulous countrymen that they had only acted under heavenly commands, which they were bound to obey.

Vaiṣṇava literature is free from such pretensions. No writer amongst the Vaiṣṇavas refers to dreams. Bengali language was no *patois* to them. The language in which Chaitanya spoke,—in which in yet earlier times Chandidās had written, was sacred in their eyes. Some of the Vaiṣṇava works in Bengali such as the Padamṛitasamudra by Çrinivās Āchāryya and Chaitanya

Bengali,—a sacred dialect to the Vaiṣṇavas.

Charitāmṛita by Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāja have appended to them scholarly Sanskrit annotations, and Narahari Chakravarti in his Bhaktiratnākara quotes Bengali verses from the works of the preceding writers as authority. Bengali was thus raised to the same literary status by the Vaiṣṅavas as the Pāli language was by the Buddhists, and no apology is put forward by renowned Sanskrit scholars such as Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāja, and Narahari Chakravarti, for adopting Bengali as their vehicle in conveying the loftiest thoughts on Vedānta Philosophy and other serious subjects.

The disputes between the Çāktas and the Vaiṣṅavas.

Bengal was during this period the scene of animated disputes between Çāktas and Vaiṣṅavas. The Vaiṣṅavas would not name the *Java* flower because it was the favourite of Kāli, the goddess of the Çāktas. They called it *od*. The word Kāli, which also means ink, they would not use as it was the name of the goddess; they coined the word *sahai* to signify ink. The Çāktas, on the other hand, would vilify the Vaiṣṅavas by all means that lay in their power. Narottama Vilās has a passage describing how the Çāktas went to the Kāli's temple and prayed that she might kill the followers of Chaitanya Deva that very night. When the great Narottama Dās died, a body of Çāktas followed his bier clapping and hissing as a sign of their contempt for the illustrious dead. Here is a satirical poem written by a Çākta poet about the followers of Chaitanya Deva.

A satire against the Vaiṣṅavas.

*"What a set of evil doers has God created in these fools of pretenders who call themselves

* গৌরাঙ্গ ঠাকুরের ভণ্ড চেঙ্গড়া, যত অকাল কুষ্মাণ্ড নেড়া,
কি আপদ করেছেন সৃষ্টি হরি।

the followers of Chaitanya! They say 'O tongue, take the name of Chaitanya' and this is their prayer. When they name Nityānanda they roll in the dust to signify their devotion. In the name of Chaitanya they call upon 36 castes to dine in the same place; and the pariah, the washerman, the oilman and the kotāl, all sit down cheerfully to dinner without observing any distinction of castes. They cannot bear to see a *Vela* leaf or a *Java* flower, the every sight throws them into hysterical fits. If they hear the word Kāli uttered by any one they shut their ears with their hands. They pay one rupee and four annas to a Vaiṣṇava priest and marry a widow with children; and in their community a Mahomedan enjoys precedence in regard to caste being regarded as *kulin*! Their prayer is 'Praise be to Kriṣṇa, Çrīnivās, Vidyāpati and Nitāi Dās' and they all have the conceit of

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বলে গৌর ডাক রসনা, গৌর মন্ত্রে উপাসনা, নিতাই বলে
নৃত্য করে ধূলায় গড়াগড়ি ॥
গৌর বলে আনন্দে মেতে, একত্র ভোজন ছত্রিশ জেতে
বাগ্দী কোটাল ধোপা কলুতে, একত্র সমস্ত।
বিল্বপত্র জবার ফুল, দেখতে নারেন চক্ষের শূল,
কালী নাম শুনলে কাণে হস্ত ॥
কি ভক্তি, কি তপস্বী, জপের মালা সেবাদাসী,
ভজন কুঠরী আইরি কাটের বেড়া।
গোসাঁইকে পাঁচশিকে দিয়ে, ছেলে শুদ্ধ করেন বিয়ে,
জাত্যাংশে কুলীন বড় নেড়া ॥
ভজহরি শ্রীনিবাস, বিদ্যাপতি, নিতাই দাস,
শাস্ত্র ইহাদের অগোচর নাই কিছু।

being profound scholars. Some of them very learnedly agree that the shrine of Vadarikā is good for nothing; it is worth a *kachu* (*Arum Colocasia*)."

The above satire levels itself at three points of Vaiṣṇavism with which the orthodox community was particularly disgusted; the first is the upsetting of the rules of caste, the second is remarriage of widows in the lower ranks of the Vaiṣṇavas; the third is their utter disregard for Çāstric ordinances, and disownment of the sanctity of shrines.

The Manoharsāhi tune.

The Vaiṣṇava singers took the country by surprise by their composition of the Manoharsāhi tune. For pathetic chant of tender sentiments and for cadence and soul-stirring effects, the Manoharsāhi tune is without its rival in the Indian musical system. As in their ways and views of life the Vaiṣṇavas broke down the conventions of ages and displayed originality and freedom, so in thier *kirtana* songs they rejected the time-honoured musical tunes and modes which were so greatly favoured by the leading singers of fashionable society, and introduced a new tune—the Manoharsāhi—full of strange modulations, which sounds like a cry from the depths of the soul and appeals to the heart by its tender wail, bringing tears to the eyes of the hearers often without words. This is the tune adopted in the Vaiṣṇava *kirtanas* where the singers' voice set at naught the hard and fast rules of the stereotyped six Rāgas and thirty six Rāginies of Indian music and flowed

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এক এক জন কিবা বিদ্যাবন্ত, করেন কিবা সিদ্ধান্ত
বদরিকাকে ব্যাখ্যা করেন কচু ॥"
From a poem by Dāçarathī.

The Kirtaniyā and his party.

into new forms. It delights the ear and overflows the heart with soft emotions—like the tender wail of the soul of woman uttered in song and expressed in heavenly pathos. The *kirtaniya* or head-singer stands in the midst of his party and describes, for instance, the Māthur or the story of Kriṣṇa deserting Vrindāvana; his voice trembles as a creeper trembles in the breeze, and he paints in words set to music how the trees of the Vrindā groves looked as if they wept, being wet with dews; how being unable to follow Kriṣṇa, as their roots were fixed to the soil, they moved with their boughs in the direction of Mathurā; how the cows, stood dumb as if they were painted on the air with tears flowing from their eyes, and did not graze;—how the murmurs of the Jumnā sounded like a deep anthem that rent the heart. The shepherd-god left for ever the Vrindā groves, reducing it to a scene of desolation and making his loves and games a tragedy of the deepest woe. When the master-singer sings, the musicians of his party stop playing, and other singers wait for the direction of their leader which is often intimated by a wave of the hand; even the sweet violin stops when the master-singer alone holds the audience spell-bound and captivates their souls by singing the *padas* of the old masters. When a particular stage is arrived at he gives a signal and his party catches the last line of the song and resumes the music. Thus the master-singer with intervals of music in chorus resumes the thread of his tale, stage by stage, and brings to completion the whole episode of a story from the Bhāgavata.

The origin of the kirtana songs—a brief history.

In a work called Chaitanya Chandrodaya Kaumudi written by Prema Dās about the year 1715 A.D., it is related that king Pratāpa Rudra of Orissā was very much moved by the *kirtana* songs sung by the *sankirtana* party of Chaitanya Deva. In reply to a question put by that monarch, Gopi Nāth Āchāryya told him that *kirtana* songs originated with Chaitanya Deva.

We are not, however, prepared to accept this statement as true. Long before Chaitanya Deva, in the Court of King Lakṣmaṅa Sen, some favourite tunes of Bengali *kirtana* were adopted for singing the songs of the poet Jaya Deva, and latterly the songs of Chandī Dās and Vidyāpati began to be sung in some of the best modes of Manohara Sāhi *kirtana*. These poets had preceded Chaitanya Deva by nearly a hundred years.

But the Bengali *kirtana* songs and some of the popular tunes in which they are sung, were, we believe, of an yet earlier origin. They were started by the singers of the glories of king Mahipal in the 10th century and contributed to by the Buddhist Mahāyânists who had already developed the Bhakti-cult. Mahāmahopādhyaya Hara Prasada Çāstri says on this head "The songs of Mahipal have already been spoken of. Buddhist songs in Bengal became the fashion of the day. This was, I believe, the begining of *kirtana* songs. Kriṣṅāchāryya or Kāhna wrote his celebrated Dohās, his songs and commentaries about this period. There were several writers of Dohās and Sāhājiyā sect of Buddhism used to sing Buddhist songs in Bengali throughout the country. Lui, Kukkuri, Birnā, Gaṅḍari, Caiṭela, Bhūsukru, Kahnā, Dombi, Mohinta,

Saraha, Dheguna, Sānti, Bhāde, Taṅḍaka, Rāntū, Kaṅkaṇa, Jayananda, Dhamma and Savara sang *kirtana* songs to the willing ears of Bengali peasants and Bengali artisans."*

Though we would thus admit the priority of the claims of the Buddhists regarding the invention of some of the tunes of *kirtana* songs, yet there is no doubt that these were restricted to a very narrow circle of men. The popularity and development of *kirtana* in all its charming forms, especially in the composition of the Manohara Sāhi tune, belonged undoubtedly to the Vaiṣṇavas. Manohara Sāhi rapidly attained a luxuriant growth under the fostering attention paid to it by the followers of Chaitanya Deva. So we need not wonder that in the popular notion the credit of originating *kirtana* is ascribed to them.

We shall here proceed to give a brief history of *kirtana* in Bengal.

There are four kinds of *kirtana*. 1. Gaḍāna-Hāti 2. Reṅeti. 3. Māndārani, 4. Manohara Sāhi.

The names are taken from those of the places in which particular *kirtanas* originated and flourished. Gaḍāna Hāt is in the district of Māldah, Reṅeti in Midnapur, Māndāran in Katak and Manohara Sāhi is a Perganna in the district of Burdwan.

Manohara Sāhi was created by a clever combination of the different tunes of the three other kinds of *kirtana*; it was therefore a later growth. The composition produced a singular melody and

* Preface to Ram Charita by Sandhyakara Nandi p. 12.

thus Manohara Sāhi quickly surpassed the rest and caught the popular fancy. The four recognised centres of Manohara Sāhi *kirtana* are the villages Kañdrā and Teorā, in Burdwan, Manādālā in Birbhum, and Teña in Mursidābād. It is believed that a musician named Gangā Nārāyaṅ Chakravarti, a Vaiṣṅava of Teora, invented the Manohara Sāhi by a skilful manipulation of the different tunes in which *kirtana* songs were sung at his time and that latterly Maṅgala Thakur, a disciple of Chaitanya Deva's companion Gadādhara contributed to its development and generally improved it.

Here is a list of some of the celebrated singers of Manaharsāhi *kirtana* (from the 15th century down to our own times).

1. Ganga Narayan Chakravarti an inhabitant of Teora (Burdwan)
2. Vadana Chand Thakura
3. Chandra Shekhera Thakura
4. Shamananda Thakura
5. Pulina Chanda Thakura
6. Hari Lala Thakura
7. Vamshi Das Thakura

} of Kandra (Burdwan).

8. Nimai Chakravarti ... of Payer (Birbhum).
9. Hara Dhana Das
10. Dina Doyal Das

} of Mereta (Burdwan).

11. Ramananda Mitra
12. Rasik Lal Mitra

} of Mayna Dal (Birbhum).

13. Vanamali Thakura ... of Kandra (Burdwan).
14. Krishna Kanta Das ... of Panch Thupi (Muridabad).
15. Damudar Kundu ... of Kandi (Mursidabad).
16. Krishna Hari Hazra
17. Krishna Doyal Chandra

} of Panthuli (Mursidabad).

18. Rama Banerjea
19. Mahananda Mazumder

} of Sinhari (Mursidabad).

20. Swarupa Lal Thakura ... of Sati (Mursidabad).
21. Viswarupa Goswami ... of Soanipur (Mursidabad).
22. Gopal Das—This singer introduced the fashion now in vogue of adding easy Bengali verses to explain the deeper meaning of the Vaisnava songs, especially those in Brajabuli which is hard for the people to understand. The additions are called

Akhara (lit. alphabet) in the popular language, and Gopal Das was known as " Akharia Gopal " for this innovation of Batipur (Mursidabad).
23. Gopal Chakravarti ... of Paraj (Mursidabad).
24. Gopi Babaji ... of Kota (Mursidabad).
25. Nitai Das ... ... of Tantipara (Birbhum).
26. Nanda Das ... ... of Maro (Birbhum).
27. Anuragi Das ... ... of Dakhinkhanda Mursidabad.
28. Sujan Mallik ... ... Viranpur (Mursidabad).
29. Krishna Kishore Sarkar ... Kenchotali (Nadia).
30. Rusik Das (living) son of Anuragi Das (No. 27) ... of Dakhinkanda Mursidabad.
31. Sudha Krishna Mitra (living) ... of Maisa Dal (Birbhum).
32. Pandit Adwait Das Babaji (living) ... ... Kasimbazar.
33. Siva Kirtaniya (living) ... of Kushthia (Nadia).

Of the living kīrtaniyās three are admittedly superior to the rest. Their names in order of merit may be thus put. I. Pandit Adwaita Dās Bābāji of Kasimbazar. II. Çivu Kīrtaniyā of Kuṣthiā. III. Rasika Dās of Dakṣinkhanda (Mursidābād).

Çivu Kīrtaniyā.

I heard three years ago the *kirtana* songs of Çivu kirtaniyā, one of the three great singers mentioned above. He sang one of those celestial songs which are inspired by deep love. Çivu himself was overpowered with emotion when he described Māthur; his voice with its tender modulations and inimitable wail touched the heart of the audience, as his own heart was touched. We heard the songs in the house of Mr. G. N. Tagore, Calcutta, but the audience felt themselves to be in the Vrindā groves all the while, whither Çivu had translated them, by calling up a perfect vision of the deserted scenes of the shrine.

The singers

The *kirtana* songs were once a madness in Bengal, and even now they carry great favour with a certain section of our community. The singers are generally acquainted with scholarly Vaiṣṇava

works. They commit to memory most of the *padas* of the Vaiṣṇava-masters and it is the people of this class who have been supplying the noblest ideas of self-sacrificing love to rural Bengal for more than 350 years.

The kathakas.

In a previous chapter I referred to the *kathakas* or professional narrators of stories. It is impossible to exaggerate the great influence which they wield over the masses. They narrate stories in the vernacular, from the Bhāgavata, the Rāmāyaṅa, and the Mahābhārata and intersperse their narration with songs which heighten the effect of their description. The deep religious ideas which underlie the stories are discussed at intervals by the *kathaka* and no one can be successful in this profession unless he is endowed with oratory, a sweet voice, and the power of raising tender emotions in the mind of his audience. We can trace the custom of such narration as early as the times of the Rāmāyaṅa ; it may be even earlier ; we find Vālmiki who lived many thousand years ago refer to a class of people whose avocation it was to narrate stories (See Ayodhyā kānda, Chap. 69.) ; but the manner in which the modern *kathakas* deliver stories with the object of imparting religious instructions and inspiring devotional sentiments in Bengal is derived from the Vaiṣṇavas. There are formulæ which every *kathaka* has to get by heart,—set passages describing not only Çiva, Lakṣmi, Viṣṇu, Kriṣṇa, and other deities, but also describing a town, a battlefield, morning, noon and night and many other subjects which incidentally occur in the course of the narration of a story. These set passages are composed in Sanskritic Bengali with a remarkable

Set passages.

jingle of consonances the effect of which is quite extraordinary. I quote here some of these passages.

Description of a dark night.

* "It is the depth of night;—an impenetrable darkness pervades all objects,—the lily droops, and the fragrance of the *kumuda* flower delights us,—the sound of beetles rise from the earth;—the birds are silent for a time and a network of stars is spread over the firmament. The woman who secretly goes to meet her lover is awe-struck in this thick darkness, and, losing her way, stops at every step and proceeds with difficulty; in the deep shade of the forest move the tiger, the bear and other ferocious animals in search of prey. At such quarter of the night, the cries of the jackals break the slumbers of lovers who wake for a moment to listen, and again fall asleep in each other's arms."

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* "ঘোরা যামিনী, নিবিড় গাঢ় তমস্বিনী, শান্তা নলিনী কুমুদগন্ধামোদিনী, পৃথ্বীঝিল্লিরবোন্মাদিনী, বিহগরব-ক্ষণবিধ্বংসিনী, নক্ষত্রনিকরজালমালবাপ্তা যামিনী সভয়চকিতনয়না কামিনী মনোনায়ক নিকটাভিসারিকা নায়িকাগণ ক্ষণ ক্ষণ দিগ্‌ভ্রান্তাদিজন্য স্থগিত চকিত গতি কষ্টে স্বষ্টে গমন করিতেছেন। ব্যাঘ্র, ভল্লুক ভয়ানক জন্তু সমূহ ভোজনাদ্যর্থে গমন করিতেছে। প্রতি যামে যামে জাগ্রতভট ঘোর কঠোর চীৎকার ধ্বনি প্রবোধিত কান্তাকান্ত প্রবেশিত হৃদয় সঙ্কোচিত ভঙ্গ বিভঙ্গ দ্বারা গাঢ়ালিঙ্গনে মনোহরণ পূর্ব্বক পুনর্নিদ্রাবিষ্ট হইতেছেন।"

The descriptions are often highly poetic, and produce almost a pictorial effect on the mind. Thus in the description of noon* "The buffaloes and bears dipping themselves in a pool doze with half-closed eyes" or in that of a cloudy day;—† "The eastern sky is radiant with the bow of Indra, (the rainbow), it appears as if the god himself comes riding on his elephant—the clouds, and twanging his great bow. A shooting light dazzles the eye as his thunder falls, the storm roars and the terrible sound frightens the traveller,—the birds in great alarm flock around the trees and raise a confused chatter" and in similar descriptions pictures of Indian scenes with which we are all familiar are instantly recalled to the mind.

Noon.

A cloudy day.

But the descriptions of gods by far excel the rest and possess a peculiar charm with the Hindus. The words are so cleverly strung together as to create visions of sublimity and beauty by association.

I have a book of formulæ supplied to me by a *kathaka*, in which I find set passages on the following subjects.

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* "কিবা কিঞ্চিন্মুদ্রিতনয়ন মহিষ বরাহ পল্বল নিমগ্ন"

† পূর্ব্বদিগন্তর দেদীপ্যমান, শক্রধনুশোভিত নভোমণ্ডল,
কাদম্বিনী সৌদামিনী চঞ্চল, তদ্দর্শনোদ্বেজিতান্তঃকরণ
মত্তকরীবরারোহণকৃতদেবেন্দ্র নিজায়ুধবজ্রনিক্ষেপশব্দিত
ইরম্মদস্খলিত পতিতকণা সমুদ্র গর্জ্জিত বজ্রপতন
ভয়ানকধ্বনি প্রতিধ্বনিশ্রবণ সভয় চকিত নয়নোদ্বেজিত
পান্থজন পক্ষিগণগণিতপ্রমাদ সঙ্কটত্রাসিত এককালীন
কুহু কুহু কলরব করিতেছে।"

1. A city. 2. Noon day. 3. Morning. 4. Night. 5. A cloudy day. 6. Woman's beauty. 7. The sage Nārāda. 8. Viṣṇu. 9. Rāma 10 Lakṣmana. 11. Çiva. 12. Kālī. 13. Sarasvatī. 14. Lakṣmī. 15. A forest. 16. War. 17. Bhagavatī.

Curiously enough these set passages though written in a highly artistic and poetic style are in prose and they are sung as if they were songs. The effect is not at all marred by the prose-forms in which they are couched. Being set to a chant, they sound highly poetic and do not at all jar on the ear.

A short history of the kathakas.

I shall here attempt at giving a short history of some of the most illustrious *kathakas*.

We have not been able to gather much information on this head. We, however, know that Rāma Dhana Çiromaṅi was one of those princes amongst *kathakas* who could move the audience as they liked, so much so that occasionally enormous amounts of money were paid as gifts to him by rich parties who became spell-bound, as it were, by the power of his brilliant oration. He was an inhabitant of the village Sonāmukhi in the district of Burdwan. He lived about 150 years ago. Gadādhar Çiromaṅi was his worthy contemporary and was an inhabitant of Govardāñgā. Dharaṇī Kathaka, a nephew of Rāma Dhana Çiromaṅi, wielded an extraordinary influence over the masses, and especially over the women-folk of Bengal, half a century ago. It is said that he was so extraordinarily gifted, that from tragic tales which drew forth profuse tears from the audience, he could suddenly pass on to satire and comic

subjects making the whole house burst into peals of laughter before the tears had dried in their eyes. Kriṣṇa Mohana Çiromaṅi of Kodaliā in 24-Pergannas was his great rival. Another *kathaka* of great renown who lived about this time was Çridhara Pāṭhaka who contributed a large number of songs to the literature of *Kathakata*.

To-day Kṣetra Natha Chuḍamaṅi of Bāgbazar, enjoys the esteem and admiration of a large section of the Hindu community of Bengal. As a story-teller there is no *kathaka* now living that can approach him. His songs and highly poetic descriptions call up vivid pictures before the mind. Kriṣṇa-kathaka of Shāmpukur is a person of superior scholarship but as narrator of story he stands below Kṣetra Chuḍamaṅi.

The *kathakas* of the old school were scholars, poets, and finished singers. The effect which their narration produced was wonderful. Born story-tellers as they were, their oration was coupled with power of music, the effect of all which was heightened by their command over language and their great scholarship. All this made them the most popular figures in Bengali-society and it is impossible to describe the hold which they had upon the women of our country. When their day's work was done, they would hasten in the evenings to hear the stories narrated by *kathakas* at the house of some one who was generally a man of means and of religious temperament. The stories inspired the minds of women by instances of the lofty sacrifice that Hindu wives have made for the sake of virtue, chastity and faith. In the case of great and illustrious

Their extraordinary influence.

kathakas noticed above, they paid little heed to the stereotyped passages in their description. They composed songs *extempore* and sang them according to the requirements of their story.

As I have said, it was the Vaiṣṇavas to whom the kathās or stories owe the elegant form in which we at present find them. The Vaiṣṇava *goswamies* or priests have up to the present day the monopoly of this profession. I shall here briefly narrate a story told by the Vaiṣṇava *kathakas* to show the kind of moral and spiritual instruction which it is the aim of the *kathakas* to imprint on the minds of their audience which chiefly consist of the women-folk.

The story of Dharā and Droṇa.

Dharā and Droṇa.

Parikṣīta asked what were the meritorious acts performed by Yaçodā, the mother of Kriṣṇa for which the Lord of the universe condescended to become her son.

Çuka Deva said in answer:—

At one time Çiva and Viṣṇu wanted to test the devotional feeling of their followers on the earth. Durgā, the wife of Çiva, accompanied them.

The gods in disguise.

They came down on the earth in disguise:—Viṣṇu as a young man apparently very poor, Çiva as an old man bending under the burden of four-score years, and Durgā as an old woman stricken with age and disease.

A Çreṣṭhi.

They came to a village where a certain Çreṣṭhi (merchant) was known for his great faith in the Çaiva religion. He was a money-lender and had amassed immense wealth by this avocation. It was

noonday when no Hindu, however poor, would turn a guest away from his door if he wanted food. Viṣṅu entered the house when the money-lender was negotiating with a customer as to the percentage of interest on a certain loan. The god applied to him for help saying that his father and mother both old and decrepit, were stricken with hunger, and wanted shelter and food at his house for the day. The Çreṣṭhi looked at him, and, without replying, went on talking on his business, till it was high time for dinner and he rose to leave. Viṣṅu now again asked him if he could give three persons food and shelter for the day. The Çreṣṭhi did not deign to give any reply even to this, but as he passed into the inner appartments, dismissing all his men, he replied briefly saying that it was now high time to worship Çiva, before which he never tasted any food,—so it was a sin on his part to detain him by requests of a secular nature. Viṣṅu came back to Çiva and related the story to him and to Durgā, and they were both greatly mortified at this conduct of one whom they had believed to be a pious man and their devout follower.

Through a dense wood.

Viṣṅu now led them to the western extremity of that village; it was afternoon, a dense wood lay before them, the trees of which glistened with the light of the western horizen; the *champaka* and *ataci* flowers peeped through small vistas, lying hidden in the shade of large *acvatha* and *cimula* trees which abounded there. There they espied a small hut, a straw-roofed mud-hovel, very neat and pleasant to look upon, lying in a sort of woody covert,—unwilling as it were from shyness to show itself to men.

Viṣṇu led them on to the hut,—through a jungly path wreathed with flowering plants that could not all have grown there naturally; some tender hand must have tended them as appeared from the wet ground underneath proving the care with which they were watered. As they came to the door of the hut they saw a damsel of sixteen eyeing them with a look of curiosity. She was poorly dressed in a single sāḍi not long enough to cover her decently. Her profuse black hair fell in luxuriant curls down her back; she was beautiful as a goddess, with timid eyes and a countenance the purity of which was like that one finds in a jessamine flower when it first opes its petals. She had a vermillion-mark on her forehead and a piece of thread was tied round her left wrist, both indicative of the sacred vows of wifehood. She came and though of a shy and quiet nature she was free from that excess of coyness which generally marks the Hindu wife. She asked in a soft murmuring tone as to what the young man wanted. Viṣṇu said what he had said to the Çreṣṭhi; he wanted food and shelter for three persons for the day. The woman replied "My husband has gone out to beg alms and will return presently; in the meantime kindly wait here," "But where can we stop? You have a single hut and no seats, no articles even of every-day use. What have you to offer for our comfort, fatigued and worn out as we all are, specially my old parents?" She showed a great anxiety to please and said, "O sirs, if at this late hour of the day, you go away from my doors without tasting any food, all my virtue will be lost. I am poor, but I crave your indulgence; pray wait here, my husband will be back quickly".

A damsel of sixteen.

She had no metal plate or any other article of every-day use. The leaves of *cala* trees gathered from the wood served as plate for the poor husband and wife, and they also made cups of those leaves for drinking water. Viṣṅu and the other two deities sat down in the hut and the old people looked exhausted and fatigued, unable to speak as if their last hour had come. Viṣṅu said "Look madam! my parents will shortly die as appear from thier condition. You are a very poor woman; if death occurs in this hut, it will put you to great inconvenience and trouble; allow us to depart, I will carry them on my shoulders and seek another place." The damsel softly said "Dear sirs, stay here, it would be a greater sin to send away dying men from my house. What may befall me I don't care; but my present duty I cannot avoid; the rest is in the hands of one who owns this house." Asked Viṣṅu in wonder: "You said it was your husband who lived with you here; what other owner of the house is there?" She replied "My husband has told me that Viṣṅu, the Lord of the universe, is the owner of this house, as indeed he is of everything we see. We are here to carry out the wishes of the master and have no idea of our own happiness or misery." Viṣṅu said 'Have you not up till now taken any food? It is a late hour.' She replied: 'My husband has gone to beg for alms, he will bring what Providence may grant. I shall cook the food and offer it to Viṣṅu first; then we shall reserve a portion for any guest that may visit our house, and what remains my husband will partake of and I shall eat what may be left in his plate." "So late an hour in the day and no

"My parents will shortly die."

Viṣṅu—the master of the house.

food ! Don't you feel hungry ?" She only smiled sweetly at the query without saying anything. It was nearly evening and the husband had not yet returned. Viṣṅu seemed to grow impatient and said that by detaining them in the place she was practically starving his dying parents to death. At these words the eyes of the damsel grew tearful ; with the leaves of *cala* trees formed into a sort of cup she brought a little water for them and poured it on their parched lips and looked at them with such an affectionate tenderness as seemed to soothe their very hearts and would have had a healing effect on them if they had really been what they seemed to be. Viṣṅu said " It is evening now, I can stay no longer. I must go away with my parents." She fell at the feet of Viṣṅu and said " Brāhmin, my vow of serving guests is going to be broken ; if you would kindly help me to be true to it, wait a moment ; not far off is the shop of the grain-seller ; I will go to it though I never did so before, and will come presently back with articles of food. I am sure the grocer knows my husband and will give me credit.' She went to the shop through mazy paths, through briers and flowers, like a silvan goddess. Her curling hair fell down to her waist ; she wore no ornaments save a rosary round her arms, but her youthful charms did not want any artificial help; they fascinated the eyes that looked upon her ; she was innocent and full of piety and did not know the wicked ways of the world. When she arrived at the shop, the grocer was struck with her beauty, all the people assembled there felt the charm of her presence, and the man asked her what it was that she wanted.

To the grocer's shop.

She said "My name is Dharā; my husband is the ascetic Brāhmin who comes to your shop to purchase food every day." "You mean to say that you are the wife of Droṅa that poor pious Brāhmin. I never saw you before, nor knew that you were so beautiful.' Dharā said "I have guests at my house. If you kindly help me by giving me grain on credit, with ghee and fuel, my husband will pay the bill. I have no money." 'O yes, you have much with you to pay me. I hope you will not deprive me of what you have,'—said the grocer in a low tone. Dharā—a sincere soul—who knew no sin wonderingly said, "What have I got to repay you with?" "Promise that you will pay me what you have," added the man in a soft tone. In her eagerness to serve her guests, the innocent and pure-hearted Dharā gave the promise. The shopkeeper dismissed his other customers and gave a sufficient quantity of food-grains, ghee and fuel for the three guests and put them into a basket. He said, "Now is your time to pay before you leave." Dharā rejoined that she did not know what she had to pay and wonderingly asked him to tell it. The wicked man said, "I want only a touch of your rising breasts." Dharā stood silent for a moment, thinking of the promise she had given, which was inviolable. All of a sudden she seized a sharp knife that lay in a corner and with that cut her breasts off and bleeding profusely presented them to the shopkeeper, who swooned at the sight. She now lifted the basket of food on her head bleeding all the way and came to her hut. Viṣṇu came out and was horror-struck at the sight. The disguised deities all hastened to the door, and

The promise inviolable.

asked what had occurred to cause that heart-rending sight. She said, "Revered guests, prepare your food and help a poor woman to be true to her vows. I have prayed to Viṣṅu night and day that my vows of purity and unswerving truth to God and man might be preserved all through my life, and I am glad that even at the cost of life I am able to be true to them" Viṣṅu knew what the matter was, and Durgā suddenly assumed her heavenly form wielding the celestial trident, her head resplendant with a halo of light, and was about to proceed to kill the wicked man, but Çiva stopped her. Viṣṅu said, "You are bleeding to death for the sake of your guests. Take my blessings. In your next life you will be called Yaçodā and I shall incarnate myself as Kriṣṅa and suck the breasts which you did not really present to that wicked man, but to God as offering for the sake of truth." Çiva, who had by this time assumed his divine form, looking like a mount of silver—with his matted locks through which the stream of the Ganges flowed, said, "And I shall protect the Vrindā groves when Kriṣṅa will be incarnated there." Said Durga "I shall be Yogamāyā, the presiding deity of Gakula where Kriṣṅa will play the shepherd-boy and preserve the milkmen and their cattle." And they all said, "Blessed be thou, for thou hast lived a pure life and known how to die for truth and for services of men."

The great sacrifice and the boon.

—o—

Such are some of the stories related by *kathakas* which, with their songs and interpretation of Sanskrit texts produce a wonderful effect on the masses.

The story takes 5 hours.

As I have said before, a story like that of Dharā and Droṅa ordinarily takes five hours in narrating ; I have given only the gist of it. It is impossible for me to give any idea of the effect produced by working it up into detail as the *kathakas* do.

The *kathakas* invariably begin with a preliminary invocation of Kriṣṅa. The text from the Bhāgavata on which they base this is poetical. They begin thus :—'Where Kriṣṅa's name is uttered the place becomes sacred. All the shrines of the world,—the Naimisāranya, Prayāga, Benares, and Gayā meet at that place ; the sacred streams of the Ganges, the Kāveri, the Kriṣṅā, the Tāpti, and the Godāvari flow at that place where Kriṣṅa's name is recited.' This is a poetical way of expressing the idea of the Vaiṣṅavas that a simple prayer is more efficacious than visiting all shrines, and that if God is worshipped in the soul, the sacredness of all earthly shrines attends it in the act.

The preliminary portion.

The influence of Vaiṣṅavism materially helped the spread of education amongst the masses. We often find people of the lower ranks of society reputed for scholarship. Çyāmānanda belonged to the Satgopa or farming caste. But he was a great scholar in Sanskrit Grammar. The social life depicted in the old Bengali poems of this period shows that learning was no longer confined to the Brāhmins. Mukundarām's account of the merchant Çripati who is said to have taken a delight in Sanskrit poetry and drama and his description of the education given to his son Çrimanta who in his early years read Bhāravi, Māgha, Kumār Sambhava and other masterpieces of Sanskrit poetry show that Sanskrit learning was no longer the monopoly

The mass-education.

of the Brāhmins. In the *tols* established by Vaiṣṇavas, pupils from all ranks of society had free access. In an account of the education given to Dhanapati in his boyhood we find that though he belonged to the Baniā caste, he had already learned to talk in Sanskrit and was well acquainted with the Devanāgri characters. In the descriptions given by Mukundarāma who vividly pourtrays every detail of social life in Bengal in the 16th century, we find the women of the lower castes receiving a fair education, not to speak of those who belonged to the higher castes. Khullanā read the forged letter produced by Lahanā and expressed her disbelief in its genuineness as it was not in the handwriting of her husband.

The rustic people preserved Bengali Mss.

Bengali in the 16th century, outside the pale of the Vaiṣṇava community, was mainly read by the people of the lower ranks of society. A large portion of old Bengali manuscripts written in the 16th, 17th and 18th centuries were recovered by me from the houses of the people of the lowest castes. The *bhadraloks* or the gentlemanly classes were generally interested in Sanskrit manuscripts. But I have found old Bengali manuscripts, preserved with almost religious care by the illiterate rustic people,—handed down to them by their ancestors. This proves that their ancestors could read and write Bengali though owing to the decadence of Vaiṣṇava influence, one of the aims of which was to enlighten the masses, these people had sunk into ignorance once again. Many of the Mss. brought to light by me were written by people of lower castes. Some of the writers seem to have

been expert in the art of caligraphy. I name below some of the writers of this class who wrote particularly elegant hands.

1. Harivaṁsa copied by Bhāgyavanta Dhubi (washerman) in 1783 A. D.

2. Naisadā copied by Cri Mājhee Kait (a low *sudra*) in 1749 A. D.

3. Devajani Upākhyāna by Gaṇgā Dās Sen copied by Rāma Nārāyaṅ Gope (a milkman) in 1747 A. D.

4. Kriyā Yoga Sāra copied by Kāli Charan Gope (a milkman) in 1740 A. D.

5. Dandi Parva by Rājā Nārāyaṅ Datta copied by Çrirāma Prāsada Dei (a low sudra) in 1785 A. D.

In the houses of Vaiṣṅava scholars, however, we find such Bengali works as the Chaitanya Charitāmṛita, Chaitanya Bhāgavata, and Padakalpataru carefully preserved side by side with classical Sanskrit works. In their eyes Bengali works dealing with Vaiṣṅavism were not, as I have said, a whit less important than the most sacred theological books in Sanskrit.

The influence of Hindi.

Bengali in the Vaiṣṅava period was subject to the influence of Hindi and this I have already mentioned on page 387. Many of the great masters of the Vaiṣṅava faith lived in Vṛindāvana and there was a constant exchange of ideas between the people of that place and those of Bengal. This circumstance explains why we find such a large number of Hindi words imported into the Bengali writings of the Vaiṣṅavas. The Padakartās held Vidyāpati's songs in great admiration and as a result many

of them imitated the Maithil forms in their *padas* and the Brajabuli of the Vaiṣṇava-songs is a result of this imitation. Thirdly in their attempts to propagate the creed of Vaiṣṇavism all over India, the Vaiṣṇavas came in contact with the different races of India speaking different languages. Hindi had already grown to be the *langua franca* of all India united under the suzerain power of the Moslem Emperor of Delhi. Those who had the propaganda of their faith to carry to all Indians could not help taking recourse to the most convenient vehicle already available for approaching them. The Vaiṣṇavas imported a large number of Hindi words into their works to make them intelligible to the people of all parts of India.

Owing to these causes the works written by a large number of Vaiṣṇavas are more or less influenced by Hindi, and instances of যৈছে, কৈছে, কবহুঁ, তবহুঁ, দুহুঁ, হইলুঁ, কাঁহা, তাঁহা, অবক, বিছুরিল etc., are numerous in all Vaiṣṇava writings, not to speak of Brajabuli which is a thoroughly Hindi-ized form of Bengali.

Case-endings.

The signs of the case-endings that we meet with in the works mentioned in this chapter, show varied forms and are very much like what we have dealt with in foregoing chapters. The growing tendency to use the suffix আদি in the place of গণ, সব, সকল and other words, formerly used to denote the plural number, often coupled with a pleonastic ক, as in চণ্ডালাদিক, পাককর্ত্তাদিক etc.,—found in Narottomavilās and other works—indicates the development of the form দিগ which now makes the case-ending in Bengali that denotes the plural number.

The metres.

The metres used by the Vaiṣṇava-masters, though rich in their forms, do not conform to the stereotyped ways of early metrical styles called Payāra and Tripadī *chhandas* which were carried to perfection by writers with a rigid classical taste. In the Mānik Chandra Rājār *gan* and other writings of the Buddhistic period, we find the Pyājāra *chhanda* to be far from being restricted to 14 letters as it latterly became; the latitude taken by the earliest writers in sometimes dragging the lines to a tiresome length, and not unoften shortening them to abrupt and halting rhymes, were the result of ignorance and uncultured taste. In the Vaiṣṇava writings, however, we find a freedom from the rigidness of classical models—not to be mistaken for the inartistic and unrestrained excesses of the vulgar, but which is prompted by a superior poetic faculty, conscious of its art, making light of restrictions, though keenly alive to the natural rhythm of metre and expression. In the following lines the poet overrides Payāra *chhanda* sportively and shows that by freeing himself from the trammels of a stereotyped metre, he makes the lines more rhythmical and artistic.

"জয় জয় দেব-কবি নৃপতি-শিরোমণি বিদ্যাপতি রসধাম।
জয় জয় চণ্ডিদাস রসশেখর অখিল ভুবনে অনুপাম॥"

"Praise be to Jaya Deva, the brightest jewel of the princes of poetry; praise be to Vidyāpati, a store-house of elegant sentiments, and praise be to Chandidās, the highest pinnacle of delicate feeling, —who is peerless in the world."

The poetic licence.

The poet who wrote these lines was well-versed in the Sanskrit classics, as the very expressions he

uses, prove; yet he uses অনুপাম which is not the right word,—it should have been অনুপম. The poet knew this quite well, but took the poetic licence of using it, for the purpose of making this word rhyme more elegantly with ধাম of the previous line. Here lies the difference between Vaiṣṇava writers and those who are the exponents of the Paurāṇic Renaissance in Bengali. These insisted on the Sanskritic rules without compromise, whereas the Vaiṣṇava poets, often the better Sanskrit scholars of the two, would follow their own keen perception of happy expression and brook no rules laid down by scholars and purists. As in the Payāra *chhanda* so also in our familiar *Tripadi*, they introduced innovations, yielding to the perception of elegance so natural with them. In the latter *chhanda* the first half of a line generally rhymes with the other half and the second line rhymes with the fourth; but here are some verses in the *Tripadi* by a Vaiṣṇava poet, in which one half of the first line does not rhyme with the other, and yet the elegance of the metre does not at all suffer.

"আমার অঙ্গের, বরণ লাগিয়া, পীতবাস পরে শ্যাম।
প্রাণের অধিক, করের মুরলী, লইতে আমার নাম॥
আমার অঙ্গের, বরণ-সৌরভ, যখন যে দিকে পায়।
বাহু পাসরিয়া, বাউল হইয়া, তখন সেদিকে ধায়॥"

(He wears cloths of a yellow tint because they are like me in colour, and as the flute that he carries in his hand, sings my name, he holds it dearer than his life. Whenever he comes across a colour or a scent that remind him of me, he moves forward like a mad man with his arms outstretched.)

Various metres were invented by the Vaiṣṇavas which please the ear, though they do not conform to the style already adopted in Bengali composition. Here is an example of long and short lines rhyming with each other and producing a singularly happy effect by their deviation from ordinary metre :—

"ধনি রঙ্গিণী রাই।
বিলসহি হরি সঞে রস অবগাহই॥
হরি সুন্দর মুখে।
তাম্বুল দেই চুম্বই নিজ সুখে॥
ধনি রঙ্গিণী ভোর।
ভুলল গৌরবে কানু করি কোর॥
দুহুঁ দুহুঁ গুণ গায়।
একই মুরলীরন্ধ্রে দুজনে বাজায়॥
কেহ কেহ কহে মৃদু ভাষ।
নারীপরশে অবশ পীতবাস॥
কেহ কাড়ি লয় বেণু।
রাসে রসে আজ ভুলল কাণু॥"

(The lovely Rādhā, steeped in sweet emotions, sports with Kriṣṇa. She puts sweet betels into his mouth and kisses him. She puts her arms about him in the delight of her heart. They praise each other with sweetest words and play together on the same flute. Some of the maidens whisper softly "how charmed is Kriṣṇa by his lady's touch!" Others snatch away his flute by force. Kriṣṇa is lost in the pleasure wrought by the company of the milk-maids.)

A list of obsolete words and their meaning.

I give below a list of obsolete words, with their meaning from the works dealt with in this chapter.

দৃঢ়—to prove : to cure.
ঠাকুরাল—authority and power.
ছিণ্ডে—to tear.

সমুচ্চয়—number.

বহি—without.

বিরক্ত—one who has an ascetic temper of mind.

উপস্থান—presence.

পরিহার—humble solicitations.

উপস্কার—to clean.

সম্ভার—materials.

আর্য্য—highly honoured: of an angry temperament.

উপপন্ন—to originate from.

পরতেক—visible.

বাহ্য—consciousness of the outer world.

জুয়ায়—to be fit.

নিহ্নি—to wipe away: that which is thrown away as of no value.

চেষ্টা—a fervour of devotional feelings.

কদর্থেন—to cut jokes.

ভিতে—to a particular direction.

ভাবক—emotional.

ব্যবসায়—conduct.

প্রাকৃত—ordinary.

বিমরিষ—sorry.

উদার—anxious.

প্রচণ্ড—great (as প্রচণ্ড অনুগ্রহ).

সম্পত্তি—flourishing condition.

লঙ্ঘন—to bite.

চালেন—to provoke.

কতি—where.

আত্মসাৎ—to accept as a disciple: to admit as a kindred.

আখুরিয়া—one expert in caligraphy; One who interprets the *padas* by simple words of his own, while singing *kirtana* songs.

হাতসানি—to sign by hand.

লঘু—small (as লঘু পদ চিহ্ন).
পাতনা—chaff.
ওলাহন—to rebuke.
ভদ্রকর—to have oneself shaved.
রাতা—red.
বাউল—mad.
পিছলিতে—to turn away.
বুলে—to wander about.
প্রেমা—love.
সিলেহ—affection.
উচাট—anxious.
তোকানি মোকানি—rumour.
উমতি—mad.
সানাসানি—to make signs.
নিবড়িল—completed.
বহুয়াড়ি—wife.
সায়—finish.
বেদিনী—a female sympathiser.
আর্ত্তি—solicitude.
আউটিয়া—to move with a rod.
তাড়াকুর—an ear-ornament.
দাদুর—a frog.
টোটা—a garden.
সম্বাহন—to shampoo: to serve.
ওট—lips.
মংস্ক—(from মৃগাঙ্ক) the dark spot on the moon.

The pretenders

During the Vaiṣṇava-period two persons, envious of the great esteem in which Chaitanya was held, declared themselves to be incarnations of Viṣṇu and tried to practise deception on credulous rustics. Both of them lived 400 years ago, and we find them mentioned in the Chaitanya Bhāgavata and other works with great contempt. One was a

Brāhmin,—a native of Eastern Bengal; his name was Mādhaba and Kavīndra was his title; Kavīndra literally means a prince of poets, but the Vaiṣṅavas called him Kapīndra or a prince of monkies. The other one who was also a Brāhmin belonged to Western Bengal (রাঢ় দেশ); his name is not given, but his family title was Mallik. This man called himself an incarnation of Viṣṇu and the Vaiṣṅavas gave him the title of Fox. Both in Bhakti Ratnākara and in Chaitanya Bhāgavata we find many contemptuous epithets bestowed on these two men. We have besides seen a number of Sanskrit verses in which some details are given about them.

The decadence of the nobler elements.

The Vaiṣṅava community gradually grew larger. Lay men recruited from the lowest castes formed the largest portion of this community. Fallen women and Pariahs swelled its ranks and the result was that the allegory of Rādhā and Kriṣṅa was made an excuse for the practice of many immoralities. Chaitanya Deva did not himself organise this community, as I have said; those, who did so, kept up its purity during their life-time; but it gradually sank into ignorance and corruption. Not only Chaitanya Deva but all his companions also were deified and the catholicity of views that had characterised them became a thing of the past. People came forward to prove that Haridās (a Mahomedan) was realy a Brāhmin as if none but a Brāhmin could be accepted as a leader even in Vaiṣṅava society. The Vaidya and Kāyastha leaders of that society who once counted Brāhmin disciples by hundreds gradually lost much of the esteem in which they had been held, because of their having belonged to castes lower than that of the Brāhmins,

and at the present day there is no Kāyastha *goswami* or priest in the Vaiṣṇava community, who can claim a Brāhmin disciple. The only caste next to the Brāhmins that still claims Brāhmin disciples, is the Vaidya, and the descendents of Narahari Sarkar of Çrikhanda have a considerable following of Brāhmin disciples up till now, though their number has greatly fallen off. Thus do we find Hindu society to be almost proof against any attempt to break down the Brāhminical caste-system. Hindu society has often been seen to yield for a time to the inspired efforts of a great genius to level all ranks, but, as often, it has been found to reassert itself when the new order, after its brief hey-day of glory, gradually succumbs to the power of older institutions. Buddhism, Vaiṣṇavism and even Brāhmaism, all of which began with an ideal of all-embracing love seem each in turn to have lost its hold upon the masses gradually. There is an inherent power in the social organisation of Hinduism,—the power to draw from all faiths and nourish itself on the best elements of other creeds. Each religion, that comes in contact with it, prevails so long as a genius acts in its support, but when such inspired help is gone, it finds that its strongest points have all passed over to the other-side leaving it incapable of coping with the resources of the older institution. But though much of the influence of Vaiṣṇavism has been lost in course of time yet it retains a considerable hold upon the masses. Widow-marriage and a disregard of the hard and fast rules laid down in the Hindu çāstras characterise the lay Vaiṣṇava community, and the Vaiṣṇavas still preach the doctrines of

The Hindu society asserts itself.

The Vaiṣṇava influence.

their faith with great earnestness in backward villages. The whole atmosphere of Bengal resounds at the present day with songs, recitations and the tales told by the *kathakas* and the *kirtanwallas* who belong to that community. These influences also invigorate Hindu society as a whole, by awakening its spiritual consciousness and it is no longer at war with the daughter-creed.

Material prosperity.

From the incidental descriptions found in various old Bengali works we find that during the Hindu period not only the merchant-class, but even rustic folk, enjoyed great material prosperity. In Mānik Chandra Rājār *gan* we find that even the children of villagers used to play with golden balls (সোনার ভাটা) and that even a maid-servant would not touch a cotton sāri, but wore silk. An ordinary merchant's dinner was not complete without fifty different dishes with the rice, besides a number of preparations of sweets. The tradition of fifty different dishes is still familiar in every respectable Hindu household and old ladies may even now be found who know the art of preparing them. The Vaiṣṇavas, as I have said, never touched meat or fish, but in the preparation of vegetables and sweets they were past masters. Lists of the delicious dishes prepared by them are to be found in Chaitanya Charitāmrita (Madhya khanda, 3rd and 15th chapters,) in 2498th *pada* of the Padakalpataru, and in Jayānanda's Chaitanya Maṅgala and other works. Details of the preparation of meat and vegetable curries with fish, are to be found in Dāker Vachana, Kavikaṅkaṇa Chandī, and in nearly all works of Dharmamaṅgala.

We have also descriptions of gold plate being profusely used by rich men. They used to sleep on couches made of pure gold, and when they would sit on these they would rest their feet on silver foot-stools. In the old stories and folk-lore we find references to such fine cloth that when exposed to the dew on the grass, it could scarcely be seen. The Meghadumbura *sadi*, made of an exceedingly fine stuff, was a passion with women of the upper classes.

The cheap living and poverty.

This is only one side of the picture. In Mahomedan times the condition of the lower classes seems to have been deplorable. No description of distress and want can be more pathetic than the account which Phullarā gives of herself. For want of a cup, liquid food had to be stored up in a hole dug in the earth, and often a day and a night were passed without any food. The poor were not infrequently subjected to capricious treatment from the rich. Many of the large tanks which were dug in Bengal at the time, seem to have been the work of forced labour. The custom of employing men by force without wages, which was called বেগার খাটান, was very prevalent. Living was remarkably cheap and wants were few. Now-a-days no rustic in Bengal, however poor he may be, can help spending less than Rs. 100 for a marriage ceremony. There is a list of the expenditure incurred on that account by a poor man, 300 years ago.

Marriage expense.

Two dhaḍās or cloths for the bridegroom	...	Price 3 pies
Betels ...	...	1 cowri (less than a pie)
Catechu ...	...	1 " "

Lime ...	...	½ Cowri (less than a pie)
Khuṅā (a cotton sāḍi for the bride)	...	4½ cowries (a little more than 2 pies
Total	...	13 cowries (a little more than half an anna).

This list we find in Chandikāvya by Mādhavāchāryya, written in 1579 A.D. Of course the value of articles in our present day has greatly increased, but yet the items mentioned in this list would not cost more than Rs. 5 even now, and comparing this with the lavish expenditure now-a-days incurred even by rustic-folk in marriage, we must admit that the economical Hindu of yore has imbibed extravagant ideas about living, with which they were once perfectly unfamiliar, and, from the standpoint of the Hindus, expensive living is no indication of civilisation. At the marriage of Chaitanya a second time, Buddhimanta Khān, who managed the ceremony, said* "Brothers, hear me, in this affair there will be none of that stinginess which characterises most of the ceremonies of the Brāhmins. We shall do things in such a manner that people may say it is the marriage of a prince." Yet the matter was one of the simplest kind. Sandal perfumes and betels, with garlands of flowers, were freely distributed. There was no dinner; no

* "বুদ্ধিমন্ত খান্ বলে শুন সর্ব্ব ভাই।
বামুনিয়া মত কিছু এ বিবাহে নাই॥
এ বিবাহ পণ্ডিতের করাইব হেন।
রাজকুমারের মত লোকে বলে যেন॥

Chaitanya Bhāgavata.

nautch ; no illumination ; no dowry. It is related in the Chaitanya Bhāgavata that this distribution of sandal-perfume, betels, etc., cost an amount of money out of which five ordinary marriages could have been celebrated ! Yet the expenses calculated by the present value of money could hardly have exceeded Rs. 50. Compared with the present expenditure on marriages this was insignificant. For now-a-days no gentleman in Bengal can manage a marriage for less than Rs. 500 and a marriage of a pompous description must cost fifty times this amount. But I doubt if the present state of things mean any improvement in the material condition of the people ; it should rather be taken as the result of extravagant ideas about style of living and display which are threatening to prove disastrous to us.

The merchants.

The merchant-classes, occupying an inferior position in society inspite of their great wealth in Bengal, were lavish in expenditure on the occasion of marriage and other festivals in those days. The description of the marriage of Lakṣmīndra with Vehulā in Manasār Bhāsān discloses a pomp and grandeur which far exceed anything of the kind found in the modern festivities of our rich people. The profuse display of jewellery, of gold and silver plate, the noble procession of elephants and horses all glittering with gold-saddles and ensigns, and the rich dowries carried by thousands of men, valuable diadems sparkling from the turbans of the gay companions of the bridegroom, and rich illumination—all indicate the vast resources that were at the command of the merchants of that period. But this idea of pomp and extravagance in living was

not the highest ideal of Hindu society. The merchants, as has been already said, ranked low in the social scale inspite of their great riches, and the poor pious Brāhmins were the true leaders of society. The people wanted to follow the Brāhmins in their utter disregard of all materialistic considerations and in their devotion to God.

The Mahotsava

Vaiṣṇavas were generally frugal in their living. The *Mahotsava* of the Vaiṣṇavas was the only ceremony in which they would sometimes spend all the money they had accumulated, by their life-long labour. It is a noble ceremony the like of which is not found outside the pale of India and which had its origin probably in the Buddhistic idea of all-embracing charity. As in other institutions of the Vaiṣṇavas, so also in this they probably imitated the Buddhists. Sometimes for a whole month a man of ordinary means kept his gates open to the poor and hundreds of them came from all parts of the country,—poor, famished, half-starved people who had their fill sitting there in long rows without any distinction of caste or creed. It is never a rich dinner, the fare being always exceedingly simple. But it is not for a limited number of invited people;—it is for all—all who are driven to it by hunger. It may be called a feast for the uninvited,—for those whom no one calls and all would turn away who have no status in society and who in their torn rags are generally unwelcome visitors; the owner of the house who holds the Mahotsava ceremony himself serves as far as practicable the beggars, who flock daily to his house in thousands. No invitation is issued, but the tidings of the *Mahotsava* ceremony spreads far and wide, and countless men

and women resort to the place and receive a warm and cordial treatment at the hands of the host who figures on this occasion as a friend of the friendless, sometimes offering all that he has to the destitute and the needy.

CHAPTER VI.

THE POST-CHAITANYA LITERATURE.

I. (a) The Court of Rājā Krisṅa Chandra of Nadiā.—Vitiated classical taste and word-painting.

(b) Alāol—The Mahāmedan poet who heralded the new age. His life and a review of his works.

(c) The Story of Vidyā-Sundara.

(d) Early poets of the Vidyā-Sundara-poems.

(e) Bhārata Chandra Rāi Guṅākara—the great poet of the 18th century. Prāṅarāma Chakravarti.

II (a) The Court of Rājā Rājavallabha of Rāja Nagara in Dacca. Its poets. Jaya Nārāyaṅa Sen—Ānanda Mayī Devī.

(b) The poets of the school of Bhārata Chandra.

III. Poetry of rural Bengal.

(a) The Kaviwalās and their songs—Raghu, the Cobbler—Haru Thākur—Rāma Vasu and others. The Portugese Kaviwallā Mr. Antony.

(b) Religious Songs.

(c) Rāma Prasāda Sen and poets of his school.

IV. The Jātrās or popular theatres.

V. The three great poets with whom the age closed—Dāsarathi—Rāmanidhi Gupta—Içwara Chandra Gupta.

VI. The folk-literature of Bengal.

I. (a) The Court of Rājā Krisṅa Chandra of Nadiā.—Vitiated Classical taste and word-painting.

A new era was dawning in our literature. Society after a great movement sinks into callousness. A great idea passes away: and in the age

that follows the spasmodic efforts of common men to reach the high ideal expressed in some great historic character slowly spend themselves. Lesser men arise who pose as leaders of society, scoffing at all that constitutes greatness; and custom and convention—two hoary-headed monsters—once more clasp the people in their iron grip. This is an age when craft and ingenuity find favour instead of open-hearted sincerity; when moral courage, character, manliness and strength of conviction fall into disfavour and worldly manœuvres of all sorts pass for high qualities and are praised as indicating wisdom.

The Reaction and its effects.

In the literature of such an age, we miss that genial flow of noble ideas—that freedom of thought and freshness of natural instincts which characterise great epochs in a nation's life, and in their place we find the poets struggling to furnish long and wearisome details about a small point till it is worn thread-bare by its very ingenuity; a small idea is over-coloured and followed in frivolous niceties on the lines of a vitiated classical taste till it becomes almost grotesque or absurd.

Such an age came upon the society of Bengal and its influence is stamped on the literature of the 18th century. This was an age when Mahāmedan power had just decayed. Robbers and bandits overran the country; and knavery of all sorts was practised in the courts of the Rājās. The school set up by Aurangeb in politics became the model for his chiefs to follow in their own courts. Conspiracies, plots and counterplots amongst brothers and relations who wanted to elbow down and kill one

The political atmosphere.

another to gain the *gadi*, were events of every-day-occurrence in the courts of Indian noblemen. Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra of Navadwip by a stratagem which was highly praised, deprived his own uncle of his rightful ownership of the *gadi* of Kriṣṇagar. Kriṣṇa Chandra's son Çambhu Chandra played a similar dodge and tried to usurp the possessions of his father, by spreading a false report of his death. The Rājā was thus going to be paid in his own coin. His agent at Agradwip in Burdwan by an equally unscrupulous action ousted the rightful owner out of the possession of that place and gained it for his own master. In the Courts of Serajuddulāh, the Nabab, plots of a far more important character were being formed fraught with consequences which were to change the history of the whole of India. It was not an age conspicuous for its appreciation of high ideas or of noble sentiments. "Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra was hostile to the followers of Chaitanya."* He frustrated the efforts of Rājā Rājavallava who had tried to obtain sanction of the Pundits of Bengal to the remarriage of Hindu widows of tender ages. Yet Kriṣṇa Chandra was the most important man of the period in the Hindu Society of Bengal. His Court had gathered round it some of the greatest Sanskrit scholars of the country. He appreciated merit, patronised literature, and encouraged art. The far-famed clay-models of Kriṣṇagar and the fine cotton-industry of Çāntipur owe their perfection to the patronage of the Rājā. The Rājā was friendly to the English and it was he who first put the idea of overthrowing Serājuddulāh by the help

Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra.

* Khitiça Vaṁçābali Charita P. 29.

of the English into the head of Mirzāfar and other influential men engaged in conspiracy against the Nowāb. Kriṣṅa Chandra was himself a scholar of no mean order. He could discuss knotty problems of logic with Hari Rāma Tarka Sidhānta and in theology he was a match for the far-famed Rāmānanda Vāchaṣpati. He was well-versed in the doctrines of the six schools of Hindu philosophy, and made endowment of lands to the great exponents of that learning of the period—Çiva Rāma Vāchaṣpati and Vīreçwara Nyāya Panchānana. He could compose extempore verses in Sanskrit and competed personally in public with Vāneçwara Vidyālankāra—the famous Sanskrit poet of his court.

The great patron of Bengali.

Besides all these Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra was the great patron of Bengali literature of the 18th century.

Poetry under such patronage became the creation of schoolmen and courtiers. It no longer aimed at offering its tribute to God but tried to please the fancy of a Rājā; the poets found the gates of the palace open to receive them and cared not if the doors of heaven were shut. For models of Bengali court-poetry, we shall quote here a passage translated from the Naiṣādha Charita—a Sanskrit poem held in great admiration by the scholars of the period.

The ove drawn similes of Sanskrit and Persian models.

"How shall I describe, O, King, the profuse hair on Damayanti's head! They compare it to the hair of a *chamari* (a species of deer). But it is foolish to compare Damayanti's hair to what that animal hides behind him as a mark of shame. They say her eyes are as beautiful as those of the

gazelle. But it is as a sign of his disappointment and defeat that the gazelle kicks the ground with his hoofs. God took the quintessence of the moon and made Damayanti's face. So a hole was made on the moon's surface and they call it a spot. The lotuses have all fled into the watery forts being struck by the beauty of Damayanti's face. Before God had created Damayanti, he exercised himself in the art of creating feminine beauty by his creation of all other women, so that he might give perfection to that single form of Damayanti; and when the ideal was reached in her, the subsequent forms were created only to establish the superiority of Damayanti over the rest."

Not only the Naiṣādha Charita, but Daçakumāra Charita, Harṣa Charita and other Sanskrit works admired in this period, abound with passages like the above, and these served as models to the Bengali writers who were under the immediate influence of the courts, and they themselves began to regale on niceties which now seem so absurd to us. The Persian poems which were favoured in this age, also contain long drawn-out similes verging on the ridiculous, and the noblemen and scholars, who prided themselves on a vain-glorious pedantry, encouraged our poets to introduce similar artificial compositions into Bengali. Here are a few short passages translated from a favourite Persian work of the period.

"Her black hair was like a net to catch the wise." "The lustre of her nails kept the hearts of all men fixed on them. They were like so many rising moons". "Her waist was slender as a single hair or rather half of it."—Zelekhā.

Slenderness of the waist was held to be a point of feminine beauty, hence absurdities passed for niceties and were admired as poetic skill!

The literature that sprang up under the patronage of courts was thus vitiated by their influence. Not only in the style of writing but in its subject-matter also, it showed the control of those evil stars that held sway over the literary horizon of Bengal at this time. The romantic conceptions of Persian tales are often singularly unpleasing to the Bengali mind; especially does this remark apply to those *kutnis* or serving women, who acted as agents in matters of illicit passion. Yet these women figure prominently in the literature of this period. Here is an extract, translated from Zelekhā, a Persian poem, in which a *kutni* is vaunting her powers before the heroine of the tale. The Bengali poets were trying their level best to import such characters into their poems.

The Kutnīs.

"Who is it that has tampered with your heart? Tell me why it is that your face beautiful as a flower has grown pale and yellowish. Why are you waning day by day like the moon? I am afraid you have fallen in love. Tell me who is that person. If he be the very moon whose abode is in the sky, I will make him come down to the earth as a slave to your wishes. If he be a spirit of the mountains, I know such charms that he would be put into a phial and brought to you. If he be merely a man, take my word, I shall make him a bond-slave to you. He will be made to minister to your wishes in every matter and you need not care to please him by offering him your services."

The maid-servants of the Hindu classics not to be confounded with Kutnis.

These *kutnis* are numerous in Persian tales. They are not of the class of Durvalā, the maid-servant described in the Chandi Kāvyas dealt with by us in a previous chapter. The latter are knaves who repay the kindness shown to them by creating disunion amongst the members of a family to serve their own selfish ends and by robbing their masters as much as they can, when entrusted with marketing. Durvalā bears a family-likeness to Mantharā of the Rāmāyaṅa, though placed in different situations, and these women should not be confounded with the *kutnis* of the Māhomedan stories; they are not accessories to immoral purposes. The *dutis* perform a quite different function in the Vaiṣṅava poems where love is spiritualised.

Indeed the Hindu poets had hitherto taken particular care to keep scenes of illicit love out of their poems. But the *kutni* now became a very common thing in our literature, especially in the poems of Vidyā-Sundara. A very striking instance of such women as figuring in the poetry of the age is found in the character of Hirā mālinī in Bhārata Chandra's Annadā Maṇgala—the most popular Bengali poem of the day.

The depraved taste in style and in spirit.

Thus in the style of poetry as well as in its spirit, the court literature of Bengal presents a striking difference to the earlier Bengali works. The style and the spirit both became depraved—the former by a vain-glorious pedantry which made descriptions grotesque by their over-drawn niceties, the serious often passing into the burlesque—and the latter by scurrilous obscenities grosser than anything in Sterne, Smollett or Wycherley and by the introduction of characters like those of Hirā mālinī

and Vidu Brāhmini—accessories to illicit love of the most revolting type. The descriptions of men and women are often marred by overcolouring like those of the beards of Hudibras described by Butler in a well known lengthy passage.

The merits of the literary epoch.

But a literary epoch cannot be wholly without its redeeming features. There must be some really meritorious points by which it can attract and make people its votaries, reconciling them even to its vices. In this age, a rigid classical taste gave a unique finish to the Bengali style and enriched it with the variety of Sanskrit metres that so powerfully appeal to the ear. Bhārata Chandra Rāy, the court poet of Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra, stands alone in the field of our old literature as a word-painter. No poet before him contributed so much to our wealth of expression or had such success in importing elegance to our Sanskritic metres. The poet here, like a true Indian artizan, applied himself patiently to the sphere of decorative art. He hunted for and found choicest expressions and strung them into the most elegant metres and carried the whole school of Bengali poets after him maddened by the zeal to imitate his style. The heart had been feasted to satiety on the emotions contained in the Vaiṣṇava literature, the ear now wanted to be pleased. High sentiments expressed in rich poetry had abounded in the literature of the Vaiṣṇavas; enough of such. The scholars would have a brief day of their own. They would show feats of clever expression, pedantry and wealth of words strung together with masterly skill. The people were drawn by this novelty. After the strain of a high-strung idealistic spirituality, they were glad to revel

The great poet Bhārata Chandra.

in grossly sensual ideas. They descended from heaven to have a little taste of the mundane pleasures. The Sanskrit vocabulary and Sanskrit works of rhetoric became the chief sources of poetic inspiration; yet the period, by a strange irony of fate, was ushered in by one who was not a Hindu, as it would be natural to expect, but a Māhomedan. A Māhomedan writer arose with a mastery of the Sanskrit tongue, the like of which we rarely find among Hindu poets in the Bengali literature. He was Syed Ālāol, translator of Padmāvata a Hindi poem written by Mir Māhammad in 1521 A.D.

Syed Ālāol.

(b) Ālāol—the Māhammedan poet who heralded the new age—His life and a review of his works.

Ālāol was the son of a minister of Samser Kutub, the Nawab of Jālālpur (in the district of Faridpur). When a youngman, he undertook a sea-voyage in the company of his father. The crew were attacked by Portuguese pirates, known in the country as *Hermadas* (from *Armada*). We have a line in the Chandi Kāvya by Mukunda Rāma describing the great fear in which sailors held these *Hermadas*. "Night and day the merchant plied his oars in fear of being overtaken by the *Hermadas*."* The father of Alaol was killed in a hand-to-hand fight with the marauders and our poet narrowly escaped a similar fate, and fled to Arācān where Māgana Thakur, the Moslem Prime minister of the ruling Chief of the place, received him hospi-

His father is killed.

* "রাত্রি দিন বয়ে যায় হার্ম্মাদের ভরে।"

Kavi Kaṅkana Chandi.

tably, being pleased with the great scholarship of the youngman. He resided at this place for many years and when he was verging on forty, he was ordered by Māgana Thakur to translate the Hindi poem Padmāvat into Bengali and he did so to please his patron and master. Some years passed in this high and agreeable company, and our poet seems to have tasted during this time the sweets of life after the woes that had befallen him in the early part of his career. He was again ordered by Māgana Thākur to translate a Persian work named Saiful Mulluk and Badiujjamāl into Bengali. But he had now declined 'in the vale of years' and when a few chapters of this book were written, Māgana Thākur, the poet's friend and patron, met with an unexpected death, and Alāol in great disappointment left the half-finished poem and retired into a life of rest. But it was yet reserved for him to be subjected to further vicissitudes in life; and greater sorrows than those hitherto experienced were still in store for him. Sujā, brother of Aurangzeb, had come to Arācān about this period and a fight ensued between the unfortunate prince and the Arācān Chief,—the former being completely defeated. A wicked man named Mirzā gave evidence against Ālāol, to satisfy a private grudge implicating him as a party to Sujā's action against the Chief of Arācān. Alāol was thrown into prison, where he spent a few years, subjected to all sorts of cruel treatment. He was, however, released and spent 9 years of his life in close retirement. Syed Musā, a rich nobleman of Ārācān, took some interest in the poet during these evil days and at his request he completed his translation of Saifulmulluk and

Enjoys the patronage of Māgana Thakura.

Māgana Thakura dies.

Ālāol thrown into prison

His poetry halts.

Badiujjamāl. Alāol had grown old by this time and had lost his wonted spirit—the spring of all his noble poetry. In the last part of this translation we miss his characteristic genial flow and sweetness of expression. Besides the above two works he wrote sequels to the stories of Lora Chandrāni and Sati Mainā—poems written by Doulat Kāzi in Bengali. The latter works were undertaken by our poet at the command of Solamān, another minister of the Arācān Chief. At the request of an influential man of the court named Syed Mahamed Khan, Alāol translated the Persian poem Hastapaikār by Nizāmi Gaznavi. Besides these, Alāol wrote several poems on Rādhā and Kriṣṇa, some of which display exquisite poetic touches. Alāol was born about the year 1618; was thrown into prison in 1658; and being released lived to a good old age, till the close of the 17th century.

A list of his works.

It will be seen that Alāol the poet worked manly in the field of translation, and the chief work of his Muse on which his fame rests—the Padmāvati—is only, as we have said, the Bengali translation of a Hindi poem. But Alāol's translation is not only free but is also marked by great originality, and though conforming in the main to the tale of the Hindi bard, is an improvement upon it in many respects.

An improvement on the original.

The Padmāvati is written in a high flown Sanskritic Bengali. Alāol is the first of the poets who aimed at word-painting and at that finished Sanskritic expression which is the *forte* of the Bengali literature of the 18th century. In fact Alāol, though, generally speaking, inferior to Bhārata Chandra, because he lacks the "elegant genius"

of the latter, eclipses nearly all the other poets of Bengal in his profuse use of Sanskritic terms. For a Moslem writer to have the credit of importing the largest number of Sanskritic words into a Bengali poem and thus heralding an age of classical revival, is no small achievement, and we are bound to admit that none of the Hindu poets of the age in which he lived, was in this respect, a match for him.

The Sanskritic style and the Hindu spirit.

Alāol has given descriptions of the religious ceremonies of the Hindus, their customs and manners with an accuracy and minuteness which strike us as wonderful, coming as they do from the pen of a Mahomedan writer. He has given a classification of feminine emotions in all their subtlest forms as found in the Sanskrit books of rhetoric, in the portraiture of such characters as Vāsakasajjā, Khanditā, Kalahantaritā, and Vipralavdhā. He has represented the ten different stages of separation from a lover (বিরহের দশ দশা), closely following the rules laid down in Sāhityadarpaṇa and in Pingala's works on rhetoric. He has discoursed on medicine in a manner which would do credit to a physician versed in the Aurvedic lore. He has, besides, shown a knowledge of the movements of the planets and their influence on human fortune worthy of an expert astrologer. In his accounts of the little rituals connected with the religious ceremonies of the Hindus such as the Praçastha Vandanā, he displays a mastery of detail which could only have been expected from an experienced priest. He has, besides, described the rules of long and short vowels, the principles যগণ, রগণ etc. by which the various Sanskrit metres are governed, and quoted Sanskrit

couplets like a Pandit, to serve as texts for the theological matter introduced in his book. The Moslem poet is profuse in his eulogies of Çiva the Hindu God, and all through the work writes in the spirit and strain of a devout Hindu. Curiously enough his work has been preserved in Chittagong by Mahomedan readers. The manuscripts of Padmāvati hitherto obtained, all belong to the border-lands of Ārācān in the back-woods of Chittagong, copied in Persian characters and preserved by the rural Mahomedan folk of those localities. No Hindu has ever yet cared to read them. This goes to prove how far the taste of the Mahomedans was imbued with Hindu culture. This book, that we should have thought, could be interesting only to Hindu readers, on account of its lengthy disquisitions on theology and Sanskrit rhetoric, has been strangely preserved, ever since Aurungjeb's time, by Moslems, for whom it could apparently have no attraction, nay to whom it might even seem positively repellent. From the time of Māgana Thākura the Mahomedan minister, till the time of Shaik Hāmidullā of Chittagong who published it in 1893—covering a period of nearly 250 years, this book was copied, read, and admired by the Mahomedans of Chittagong exclusively. What surprises us most is the interest taken by the rustic folk in its high-flown Sanskritic Bengali. The Province of Chittagong must have been once a nucleus of Sanskrit-learning to have disseminated so deep a liking for the classic tongue of the Hindus among the lowest strata of society, and specially amongst Mahomedans who might have been expected to have the least aptitude for this.

His work read admired and preserved by Mohamedans.

The Sanskritic culture of Chittagong people.

The poem Padmāvati deals with a well-known episode in Indian history. The Emperor Alāuddin of Delhi had heard of the wonderful beauty of Padmāvati, queen of the Rājā of Chitore, and demanded her for his harem. Bhim Sen, the Rājā, who is called Ratnasen in the Bengali poem, treated this request with the contempt which it deserved, and the result was that for twelve years the Emperor laid siege to Chitore. Bhima Sen was eventually defeated, and his queen sought death on the funeral pyre,—true to the traditions of Rajput women. This story had formed the subject of a poem by Mir Mahomed in Hindi which contains about 10,000 lines. The Bengali Padmāvati by Alāol has about 10,500 lines.

The subject of the poem.

I have said that the classic taste, which made the Bengali poets of the 18th century revel in exaggerated and high flown imageries, was indicated in the work of this Mahomedan poet, to such a considerable extent, that he may be said to have heralded the new epoch. Alāol rang the bell of the new age and the sound was caught by a host of other poets amongst whom Bhārata Chandra was the most prominent. I shall here quote some passages from Alāol's Padmāvati to show how his description owns kinship with those found in the Sanskrit and Persian poems already referred to by us, as also with the high sounding flourishes of style which characterise the Bengali poems that followed the age of Alāol.

The new age.

*"The light that beams in the face of Padmāvati puts to shame the light reflected from a golden mirror.

*কনক মুকুর জিনি মুখজ্যোতি সাজে—
দেখহ অপূর্ব্ব রীত বদন উপরে।

Far-fetched similes.

One curious fact with regard to the face is that two lotuses are confined in the disc of the moon (her face.) The sun who finds his friends so confined by his enemy, came to the rescue, in the shape of the vermilion mark on the forehead. The god of love, in aid of the sun, held the bow of her eyebrows, and aimed his shafts, which were the glances of her eyes. The only regret is that these friends though so near were not allowed to see each other."

The lotuses are her two eyes. The sun according to the poetic tradition of Sanskrit rhetoric (কবি-প্রসিদ্ধি) is a lover of the lotus. The moon is unfriendly towards the lotus according to a similar tradition. The lotus blooms in the daytime and fades in the evening—a circumstance which caused the acceptance of this idea by the poets.

For pages and pages one may follow descriptions on this line. The ingenuity of such compositions, greatly favoured, as they were, by the scholars of a particular epoch, show the artificial taste of the age—the absurdities that passed for intellectual feats and the grotesque and the uncouth that were accepted as beautiful.

পদ্মযুগ বন্দী হয় চন্দ্রের মাঝারে ॥
শত্রুমাঝে মিত্রবন্দী দেখি দিবাকর।
ধরিয়া সিন্দুর রূপ অ ইল নিয়ড় ॥
ভুরুযুগ ধনুক ধরিয়া পঞ্চবাণ।
তিলে তিলে হানে বাণ কটাক্ষ সন্ধান ॥
কমল নয়নী মাত্র মনে এই দুখ।
নিকটে থাকিয়া মিল না দেখায় মুখ ॥

Alāol's Padmāvati

But Alaol's poems often reach a high degree of excellence from the wealth of their Sanskritic expressions. It is to be regretted that the excellence of their style, and the effect produced by the jingle of classic words and associations suggested by them, are not such as can be conveyed in translation. The author frequently imitates the style of the great song-masters of Bengal with a happy effect. The following passage reminds us of some well-known lines from the Sanskrit Gita-Govinda by Jayadeva.

The untranslatable beauty of style.

*" In the spring season the bridegroom revels in the joyous company of his bride. They are like two moons, shedding, as it were, ambrosia in the lovely smiles on their softly curving lips. The flowers are in full bloom, and from the floral bowers the cuckoo cooes pleasantly in the company of its mate; the bees hum delightfully; the cool Malaya breeze charged with the scents of flowers, softly touches the bridegroom heightening the charm of the sweet words of his lady-love. The *acvatha* tree, the prince of the forest, displays its wealth of new leaves, the *tamala* stands obliquely and the mango-creepers are rich with fresh foliage and

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*বসন্তে নাগরবর নাগরী বিলাসে
বর বালা দুই ইন্দু, স্রবে যেন সুধা বিন্দু,
মৃদুমন্দ অধরে ললিত মধু হাসে
কুসুম প্রফুল্লিত মধুব্রত ঝঙ্কৃত,
হুঙ্কৃত পরভৃত, কুঞ্জে রত রাসে
মলয় সমীর সুসৌরভ শীতল,
বিলোলিত পতি অতি-রস-ভাসে ॥

tendrils. The hearts of the youthful pair are gladsome. They are decked with the wreaths of the *rangan*, *mallika* and the *malati* flowers."

Alas, the beauty of metre and of choice Sanskrit words that characterise this passage is but ill-conveyed in the above translation.

Indebted to earlier poets.

The line "চলিল কামিনী, গজেন্দ্রগামিনী, খঞ্জন-গমন-শোভিতা" is evidently inspired by Vidyâpati's "গেলি কামিনী, গজহুঁ গামিনী, বিহসি পালটি নেহারি" and the lines beginning with "আজি কেন বিপরীত তোমার বদন" breathe the sentiments of Chandi Das in his well-known passage opened by the line "আজি কেন তোমায় এমন দেখি।"

The description of the seasons is full of delicate sentiments and calls up familiar scenes by suggestive lines. During the rains the lovers sit up at night in merry talk and *" if there be a sound of thunder she is startled, and throws herself into the arms of her lover—an unexpected surprise to him."

প্রফুল্লিত বনস্পতি কুটিল তমাল দ্রুম।
মুকুলিত চূত-লতা কোরক জালে।
যুবজন-হৃদয় আনন্দ-পরিপূরিত।
রঙ্গ-মল্লিকা-মালতি-মালে॥

Alāol's Padmāvati.

*" চমকিলে বিদ্যুৎ চমকি কণ্ঠে লাগে।
বজ্রপাতে কমলিনী ত্রাসিত হইয়া
ধরয়ে পতির গীমে অধিক আটিয়া॥"

Alāol's Padmāvati.

There are many pretty lines in the poem recalling scenes of domestic affection and of the delicate associations of love.

In praise of God.

The preliminary lines in praise of God are full of sincerity and devotion. *" He created life to manifest Himself in love, and death to show that He is also the terrible. Sweet scents of flowers He created to indicate heaven and evil odours to warn men of the filth of hell. As a sign of His high favour, He created sweet things, delicious to the taste, and the bitter and pungent, to indicate His wrath. He secretly hid the honey in the flowers and by creating the bees He brought it to the knowledge of the world. He created all in the twinkling of an eye, and the great firmament created by Him stands without the support of pillars. The sun and the moon He created, and also created the night and the day. The winter and the summer He created, and the heat, the rays of the sun and

*" আপন প্রচার হেতু সৃজিল জীবন।
নিজ ভয় দর্শাইতে সৃজিল মরণ॥
সুগন্ধি সৃজিল প্রভু স্বর্গ বুঝাইতে।
সৃজিলেক দুর্গন্ধ নরক জানাইতে॥
মিষ্ট রস সৃজিলেক কৃপা-অনুরোধ।
তিক্ত কটু কষা সৃজি জানাইল ক্রোধ॥
পুষ্পে জন্মাইল মধু গুপ্ত আকার।
সৃজিয়া মক্ষিকা কৈল তাহার প্রচার॥
এতেক সৃজিতে তিল না হইল বিলম্ব।
অন্তরীক্ষ গঠিয়া রাখিছে বিনিস্তম্ভ॥
সৃজিলেক দিবাকর শশি দিবা রাত্রি।
সৃজিলেক নক্ষত্র নির্ম্মল পাঁতি পাঁতি॥

the clouds which He lined with lightning. He pervades the universe—both revealed and unrevealed. The virtuous and the saintly know Him, but the vicious know Him not."

In this hymn Alāol follows more or less the Hindi original of Mir Mahomed.

The characteristic features of a Mahomedan tale.

But though in the main story Alāol follows a style on the line of the Sanskrit classics and shows a wonderfully close acquaintance with the manners, customs and religious life of the Hindus, yet reading between the lines one may discover the vein of a Mahomedan poet by the non-Hindu elements to be found in his work, though couched beneath a highly Sanskritised form of Bengali. A certain extravagance of imagination reminds us, at every stage, of the excesses of fancy which characterise Arabic and Persian tales. Raja Ratna Sen heard of the beauty of Padmāvati, and even before he saw her, fell into a fit of violent love; renounced the world as an ascetic, and wandered through the forests. And "with him 1600 princes turned ascetic."* The

সৃজিলেক সুশীতল গ্রীষ্ম রৌদ্র আর।
করিল মেঘের মাঝে বিদ্যুৎ সঞ্চার॥
প্রকট গুপ্ত রহে সবাকারে ব্যাপি।
ধার্ম্মিক চিহ্নয়ে তারে না চিহ্নয়ে পাপী॥

Alāol's Padmāvati.

*নৃপতি গমন শুনি হইয়া বিরাগী।
ষোল শত রাজার কুমার হইল যোগী॥

Alāol's Padmāvati.

princess was sad, and the message of her sorrow was carried by the bird *cuka*. The poet describes the mission of the bird and the effect which his flight produced on the objects that he came in contact with.

*"The message of her sorrow was carried by the bird through the sky, and the clouds became dark, in an excess of grief. A spark of this sorrow touched the disc of the moon and created a spot on its surface. The wings of the bird drooped under his burden of sorrow and they looked like lightning. The bird passed over the sea and its waters, in their deep woe, became saline."

These excesses of fancy, which should not be confounded with the play of poetic imagination, make the passages such gibberish as children may be heard amusing themselves with in their folk-lore.

Ratna Sen's wrestling-feats.

Ratnasen's wrestling-feats and skill in riding, which have been graphically described in the poem, have many points which remind us of the feats exhibited by modern circus troupes. They give us

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* দুঃখের সংবাদ লয়ে বিহঙ্গ উড়িল।
সেই দুঃখে জলদ শ্যামল বর্ণ ভেল॥
স্ফুলিঙ্গ পড়িল উড়ি চাঁদের উপর।
অন্তরে শ্যামল তহি ভেল শশধর॥
উড়িতে নারিল পাখা শূন্যের উপর।
উল্কাপাত হয় হেন বলে তারে নর॥
সমুদ্র উপর দিয়া করিল গমন।
জলনিধি হইল তহি পুণিত লবণ॥

Ālāol's Padmāvati.

a complete idea of the manly sports and pastimes that found favour during the Māhomedan period, though the description is not altogether free from exaggeration.

The story is a failure.

Ālāol's Padmāvati has little interest as a story. The characters are not delineated with skill, and the conception of the plot does not show any great mastery of the poet over his incidents. Its main charm rests on those stray glimpses of poetic elegances and high classical refinement, with which the book abounds, and no less on the great erudition of the poet, indicated in many noble passages. We appreciate the truth of what Ālāol says of himself in the preliminary chapter of Badiujjamāl.

Poet's great scholarship.

*"At the order (of Māgana Thākur) I wrote Padmāvati; therein I showed the utmost powers that my intelligence possessed."

Another poem by Ālāol.

Though greatly inferior to Padmāvati in poetic merit, the Saifulmulluk and Badiujjamāl of this poet contains occasional passages of much beauty. The preliminary hymn to God is quite a match for that which we found in Padmāvati. †"Where would be the glory of light, if it were not

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*"আজ্ঞা পাইয়া রচিলাম গ্রন্থ পদ্মাবতী।
যতেক আছিল মোর বুদ্ধির শকতি॥
Ālāol's Padmāvati.

†"উজ্জল মহিমা নাহি অন্ধকার বিনে।
অধম না হলে বল উত্তম কেবা চিনে॥
লবণ কারণে চিনে মিষ্ট জল সীমা।
কৃপণ না হত কোথা দাতার মহিমা॥

placed side by side with darkness! If the wicked were not in the world, who would know the value of a saintly life! The salt water of the sea makes us appreciate more the boon of sweet fresh water. If there were no misers, we could not give our tribute of praise to liberal minds. The true and the false represent but two sides of a picture. Don't you Ālāol, care to listen to the praise or blame of this world. The little stock that you have in your own heart, give freely to the world, without feeling ashamed of it."

In the preliminary account of Padmāvati Ālāol says that Māgana Thākur, the prime minister of the Chief of Ārācān, had employed him to translate the Hindi poem into Bengali,—high-flown Sanskritic Bengali,—because the people of Ārācān did not understand Hindi but understood Bengali. This leads us to the conclusion that the popular literature not only of Āssām but also of the borderlands of Ārācān used to be written in Bengali, a circumstance confirmed by the other fact to which we have already drawn attention, *viz.* that it was the low class Māhomedan population of these places who have preserved these poems for about 250 years.

The faults and merits of Padmāvati are characteristic of the literary works of the period that

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সত্য যে অসত্য দুই মতে হল যত।
ভাল মন্দ যে বলে না ক'রো কর্ণগত॥
যেই পুঁজি আছে মাত্র হৃদয় ভাণ্ডার।
লাজ ছাড়ি আলায়োল ব্যক্ত কর তার॥

Ālāol's Padmāvati.

The style and the taste.

follows. The Sanskritic style used by Ālāol was greatly improved by Bhārat Chandra. The descriptions of the school that follows abound with niceties which mystify the reader, as in the case of Padmāvati. In Bhārat Chandra, the great master of the age, we only find these niceties somewhat curtailed, and absurdities often reclaimed, by a sweet jingle of words, which please the ear, like the warblings of birds—without conveying to us any clear sense or meaning.

The moral tone became more and more vitiated; and Bhārat Chandra, had he lived in this age, when poets are not allowed to revel in the unrestrained language of sensualism and the grosser passions, could not have given us his masterpiece the *Vidya-Sundara*. The literature of Bengal in the 18th century was pitched in the key of a high-strung classic taste; yet it bore no mark of any master hand, that could shape circumstances and give them life. The works of the period are nevertheless full of sparkling passages and delicate sentiment, and they display above all a unique treasure of choice expressions which has greatly enriched our literature.

The poets had betaken themselves to the painter's art. They did not aim at inspiring life; they wanted to give finish to the form. They busied themselves with colouring, till some of the pictures they drew became blurred by their very efforts to embellish them. For it was not the natural that engaged their poetic powers, but the artificial and exaggerated, which pandered to the vitiated taste of mere scholars. From the time of Ālāol the tone gradually degenerated;—the good sense, the sound principles, and the domestic instincts that aimed at

purity were lost. There was a violent return to the senses. Sensualism of the grossest kind—unrestrained and vulgar sensualism, redeemed only by fine literary touches and embellished by choice metaphors—pervades a considerable portion of the literature of this age. The poets in their strenuous attempts to depict vulgar scenes cared only to produce effects by their rhythmical pomp; and when one reads such passages he thinks more of the metre and of the niceties of expression than of the wicked and immoral spirit that they breathe. Hence the lawless tone loses much of its force and the scenes themselves appear as harmless as painted devils. Poetry sank to the level of mere painting, as I have said, and to that of a merely decorative type,—painting in which skilled and ornate designs are worked up with inexhaustible patience by gifted hands like those we find in the caves of Elephanta.

——:o:——

The Story of Vidyā Sundara.

Annadā Maṇgal.

The story of Vidyāsundara finds a prominent place in the works which are called Annadā Maṅgala or Kālikā Maṅgala. Annadā, Kāli and Chandi are all names of the same goddess though their forms are different. These poems therefore are written in honour of a deity. The religious element however, is introduced by way of apology. It was not the custom of the old Bengali poets who rose with the revival of Hinduism to write on a subject which had no touch with religion; and the religious garb of the story is thus accounted for. Grossest matter however is introduced into these works, though bearing a holy name. Those who have

seen the sculptural figures in bās relief on the walls of the Puri and Kanāraka temples will not be astonished to find a religious work associated with these scenes of vulgar sensualism which are to be found in Vidyāsundara—a poem forming part of the religious work Annadā Maṅgala.

Sundara hears a report of Vidyā's beauty.

Sundara, son of Rājā Guna Sindhu of Kānchi (Kanjivaram) hears a report of the remarkable beauty of the Princess Vidyā, daughter of Rājā Vira Simha of Burdwan. Vidyā was not only a peerless beauty, but her scholarship was so great that she had sent a challenge all over India offering her hand to the person who would defeat her in scholarship. The challenge was accepted by many distinguished princes who flocked to the Burdwan palace, but they were all defeated by the princess whose scholarly discourses in various branches of learning completely out-witted them.

Comes to Burdwan and meets Hirā.

Sundara, without taking permission of his royal father, went alone *incognito* and riding a noble horse reached the capital of Rājā Vira Simha. A large Bakula grove spread its shadow in the precincts of the city and the fragrance of its flower was carried on all sides by the pleasant evening breeze, when Sundara alighted from his horse, and sat in the grove, not knowing where to seek shelter for the night. At that moment a rather elderly woman whose charms were not altogether lost by years,—a courtezan and a coquette, happened to come there to gather flowers,—for Hirā was a flower-woman whose duty it was to make wreaths and garlands for the ladies of the Rājā's house at early dawn every day. She was charmed with the hand-

some appearance of the Prince and offered to lodge him for the night and as long as he might wish to do so, if he wanted to put up at her place. He called her aunt, and though she was not pleased with the prince for calling her so, as in her heart of hearts she entertained the hope of being flattered with a little attention from him, yet she showed him every hospitality at her house; but when she asked him who he was and what his mission was at Burdwan she could elicit no satisfactory reply. The Prince said he was a youngman who had taken a fancy to travel in various lands for the sake of pleasure.

The evening passed in pleasant conversation, and in the night the flower-woman began to wreathe her floral store into garlands; and placed them in a beautiful basket, and Sundar asked her what she would do with them. She said that the garland would be presented to Princess Vidyā at early dawn, a task which it was her duty to perform every morning by appointment from the queen. The Prince was very much delighted to find in Hirā a woman who had access to the Princess. He asked her many questions about the beauty of Vidyā and Hirā following the close lines of classical metaphor and a highly ornate style, as dictated by the Sanskrit rules of rhetoric, drew an over-coloured sketch of the Princess which had the effect of greatly heightening the desire of the Prince for an interview with the far-famed beauty. He made a request to Hirā to allow him to weave a garland of flowers for Vidyā to be presented to her next morning; of course he did not mean that it was to be offered in his name; as usual she would give it to the Princess;—the garland was to be woven by him—this was all that

Offers to present a garland.

he wanted. Hirā did not see any harm in this and Sundar, who was an expert in the art of preparing floral wreaths applied his whole heart to the work and prepared a garland with remarkable skill;—the petals of the flowers were so arranged as to form characters by which he conveyed his love to the lady in a beautiful Sanskrit sloka.

Love's message and its effects.

Hirā had to sit up till a late hour of the night, as much time was taken by Sundar in artistically preparing the garland; so she was late in arriving at the palace the next morning, and Vidyā reproved her for her delay threatening that she would bring her conduct to the notice of the King. Hirā said that it had taken her a long time to weave one special garland for her, and that the Princess should pardon her for this first fault. "Where is the beautiful garland of which you speak?" She said; and as Hirā handed the thing to her she felt the dawn of love in her heart as she read the name of the Prince, and the message conveyed to her by the exquisitely artistic arrangement of the flowers. It was as though reading an elegant poem; the garland rich in design, perfect in execution and containing the sweet message of love, charmed her heart and she importuned Hirā, asking her to tell her who it was that had made it. Hirā at first tried to maintain her position by declaring that she herself had done so; but the Princess laughed at all attempts on her part to establish this point by oaths and long speeches, and she was afterwards obliged to confess the whole truth to Vidyā who, on hearing it, could not disguise her feeling from the flower-woman and wanted to have a sight of the gifted youngman.

A sight of each other.

The inner apartments of a Rājā's house are eternally shut against all out-siders; but through the shutters of her window, Vidyā saw Sundara, who was brought by Hīrā to a convenient place that they might have a sight of each other. It should be stated here that Vidyā's learned discussion with those who courted her hand were always, following the custom of Hindus in such cases, managed behind the screen with the help of interpreters and in no case was a prince allowed to have even a peep at her.

They saw each other and fell in love. How could an interview be effected? It was impossible to attempt anything like it on the face of the guards—those eunuchs who kept a strict and vigilant watch at the palace gate. Sundara disguised himself as a Sannyasin, wore matted locks and a false beard and covered his face with ashes and saw Rājā Vīra Sinha. To the surprise of the Rājā and his courtiers he declared his desire to enter into a scholarly discussion with Vidyā, and, if he succeeded in winning the game, to take her for his wife. A strange story from the lips of an ascetic! Such a challenge would only be entitled to credence and approval if a prince were the suitor. But as Vidyā had promised that any man was welcome to accept the challenge irrespective of age and social status, the false Sādhu insisted on being ushered behind the screen to have a discourse with her in various branches of learning and win her for his bride. The maids of Vidyā humourously asked her to match her powers with his and if she should prove the weaker of the two, to court the lot of an ascetic's wife and wonder with him bare-footed,

Sundara as a sannyasin.

Vidyā puts off the date.

visiting shrines like Benares, Gayā and Prayāg! But Vidyā whose mind was full of the handsome prince would not allow the Sannyāsin to approach her, and put off the date for doing so to an indefinite time on some pretext or other.

Both the prince and the princess were longing for an interview. Hīrā was taken into their confidence, but she was afraid of the guards who would tear her to pieces if they had a scent of her having a share in the business.

Prince Sundara felt that life was unbearable without an interview with Vidyā. He fasted and worshipped Kāli with true devotion, who granted him a charmed rod wherewith the prince worked out a subterranean passage from the room in which he lodged, leading through a mazy tunnel to Vidyā's room in the palace.

Equipped with a charmed rod.

The maids of Vidyā were taken into her confidence and they all promised secrecy. One night when the starry sky, with its grey linings of clouds looked beautiful, causing sweet emotions to grow in young hearts.—Vidyā felt a great longing to meet the prince. The maids attending on her suddenly saw that a deep cavity had been made inside the room, through which a turban sparkling with diamonds rose before their bewildered gaze, and shortly after there appeared a human form, the handsomest that had ever met their eyes—Sundara was smiling in triumph and looking to Vidyā assured her that it was all through the grace of Kāli that he had at last succeeded in making an underground passage leading to her apartments. The maids felt reassured at this words; but Vidyā

The meeting.

said to them that though she could excuse the thief and the intruder, it was not possible to break her promise; unless and until he could defeat her in scholarship there was absolutely no hope for him. Sundara readily accepted the challenge and there followed a discussion in Kāvya, Nyāya, Dharmaçāstra, Philosophy and all other subjects of human knowledge. At every turn Vidyā was brought to bay by the intellectual acumen and profound scholarship of the prince and when so vanquished, she had a smile for him, which, coupled with the glances that they stole at each others face, invested her defeat on the field with a sense of conquest over the heart of her antagonist and lover. Vidyā now acknowledged that she was defeated and that she saw no objection to her being united to him in marriage, true to her promise. Among the various systems of marriage of the Hindus there is the *Gandharva vibaha* or marriage in secret which makes the vows sacred and legal by mutual election of the bridegroom and the bride. No priest or third party is required to minister to the ceremony,—the only condition required to bring this marriage to a consummation is to exchange garlands of flowers worn by each other. Vidyā in great delight took off the floral garland from her neck and offered it to Sundara and Sundara did the same to her. So the marriage was completed. The poets say that Kāmdeva or the God of love, unseen by others, discharged the priestly function in this ceremony. The marriage parties consisted of six seasons headed by the spring and tinkling sounds of the ornaments,—the *napura*, the bracelets, the *kankana*

The defeat and marriage in secret.

worn by maids, sounded the musical notes to consummate the event.

Thus Vidyā and Sundara met every night. The maids connived, and nothing was known about the marriage by the Rājā or his queen. Even in daytime they met, for Vidyā had a compartment in the palace all reserved for herself, and her parents visited her only occasionally, and when they did so they generally sent previous informations of their visit. Chapter after chapter is devoted by Bhārata Chandra to describing the manœvres of the husband and wife to give pleasure to each other by surprise-visits and by every form of play imaginable in which the young couple indulged to their heart's content. Rājā Vīra Sinha continued now and then to send information to his daughter about the ascetic till waiting as suitor for her hand, but Vidyā would not listen to it. She declared that she would lead the holy life of a nun and had despaired of marriage as no prince could yet defeat her in scholarship. The ascetic, as I have said, was no other than Sundara himself, who passed his days in the city in the garb of an ascetic, with the object of avoiding attention as he was ostensibly without any occupation. The prince and the princess in the meantime both insisted whenever they met Hirā, the flower woman, on her helping them to have an interview with each other, and the poor woman was at her wit's end to devise some plan for their doing so. She was completely ignorant of the affair that was going on *subrosa*.

The maids of Vidyā were alarmed to find that the princess was *enceinte* so that the fact of her marriage could not be longer concealed from

her royal parents. In great dismay they discussed among themselves what was to be done at this crisis. It was settled that the matter should be brought to the notice of the queen; for the disclosure of the circumstances through other sources, which was inevitable, would expose them to the risk of losing their lives, as they would be implicated in a share of the guilt. They would not disclose Sundara's name but would bring the matter itself to the queen's notice—a course to which Vidyā had reluctantly to give her consent, as there was no other alternative.

Concealment no longer safe.

The queen heard of it; she visited the princess, and after vainly attempting to extort the right information from her and rebuking her as best as she could, asked the maids to disclose the name of the person who was so bold as to violate the sanctity of the royal *zenana* ; but they washed their hands clean of all knowledge about any one and maintained a determined silence, in answer to all enquires on this point. In a great rage the queen approached the Rājā, who was taking his afternoon nap at the time ; the maids in attendance were waiting with *chamars* and fans—standing silently like painted figures by his bed-side. The queen in a violent paroxysm of anger flew into the royal apartments and the tinkling sound of her *napura* awoke the king who was surprised to find her in such a condition.

The exasperated queen.

She related the story to the Rājā, declaring him to be quite unfit to hold the sceptre since such a thing could happen in his own palace. The police staff was worthless, if they allowed a thief

to enter the royal *zenana* and perpetrate such a heinous crime under the king's nose, what safety was there for the life and property of the poor people living in his dominion ?

The police officer's danger.

The Rājā convened his court immediately. The chief officer of police came trembling before the enraged chief, and Vira Sinha after relating the story said, "You base-born fellow, there will be one grave dug into which you and your children will be thrown if you cannot detect the thief." The officer with folded palms asked for seven days to make an enquiry and find out the thief. The Rājā granted him the time saying, if on the expiry of seven days, the thief should not be brought to his presence, the officer would lose his head and his children would all be killed.

The police officer commenced operations of a thorough inspection of the palace. Vidyā was made to leave her apartment, and the police people flocked to see through what passage a thief might enter the house inspite of such a strong body of guards. It took them no time to discover the hole—the passage made by Sundara. They entered the hole but came back feeling as if the vaults of hell were open,—there was no passage of light or air, the gloom that pervaded it over awed them and choked them. The bravest of them repeated his attempts several times and as many times came back apprehending the approach of a venomous snake or some devil. Dhumaketu, the Inspector, pronounced it to be a hole made by a serpent and Yamaketu, another officer of the staff, said that it must have been

made by some black spirit. Whatever it might be, they were unanimous in their opinion that in all probability that was the passage used by the thief. They all sat round the hole and contemplated the best method of carrying on a sifting investigation as to where it could lead. They thought of excavating the whole ground covered by it, but that course would require such an extensive operation through the hard ground-floor of the palace that seven days might not suffice for finishing the work. Kālaketu, a police officer, said :—" Brethren, let us wait here in the disguise of maids; the thief may come of himself to visit the princess."

This idea was accepted by all. They brought various dresses and ornaments from the Rājā's theatrical stock. One of them who had a charming face put on the dress similar to that of Vidyā and twelve officers disguised themselves as twelve maids decorating themselves with great skill inorder to practise the deception successfully. Thirteen men belonging to the police staff had thus stationed themselves in the apartments of Vidyā. Sonā Rāya and Rup Rāya, the chief officers, sat at the main gates leading to the palace. There were 28 minor gates and as many police Inspectors guarded them with a vigilant watch. One of the old women belonging to the family of a police Inspector, who used to wear a red coloured *sadi* and a garland of *java* flowers round her neck, visited every house on some pretext or other, and employed her maidens on a similar mission, making enquiries of the women-folk of the town to get a clue to trace the thief. A thorough search was made of the incoming and outgoing boats and all

arrivals and departures were subjected to a most careful search.

Vidyā could find no possible way to send information to Sundara, as her apartments were occupied by officers of the detective department. The police were trying to detect a thief, that was all that the people knew; no inkling as to a guilty connection with the royal *zenana* was obtained by any outsider, and Sundara had no thought of all this investigations having been aimed at the detection of his crime.

As usual dressed in his best attire,—scented with *atar* extracted from the rose and jessamine, with his turban and apparel sparkling with diamonds —his head full of love's reveries, Sundara entered the subterranean passage in the evening and appeared at the other end of the hole. The police officers looked at each other and smiled. Sundara could not recognise them in the dim light which the police had purposely kept in the apartments. He sat smiling by the side of one who wore Vidyā's dress and attemped the gay amours with her to which he was accustomed; but the false lady hid her face behind the veil and would not show any sign of reciprocating his warm sentiments,—at which he feared she was angry with him for some unknown cause. The prince looked helplessly around, and asked the maids to intervene in his behalf to make his lady-love as kind to him as she had ever been. The maids responded to his call and all at once seized him—his lady-love also was not slow in joining her maids in according him the reception which a thief deserved at the hands of the police.

In the meantime some of the officers groped in the darkness of the subterranean passage, attempting to discover the residence of the arch-thief whose daring and ingenuity was so great as to have outwitted the whole staff of guards. They were no longer afraid of the devil dwelling in the cell, nor of snakes, since they had seen the thief entering Vidyā's apartments through it with his fine apparel, nothing soiled by the dirt of the cell. They had to go a long way before they saw the region of the sun and the moon, and it so happened that the first light they saw, discovered to their eyes a charming *bunglow* which was familiar to them all, as forming part of the house of Hīrā the flower-woman. The faded beauty, whose face showed a strange combination of wrinkles and loveliness, was dragged out of her room and belaboured for giving shelter to a thief and helping him to dig a passage under the earth. Hīrā swore by all that was holy to her,—by her father's name—by the name of Rājā Vīra Sinha and by the head of Sonā Rāy, the chief officer of the police, that all was a mystery to her and that she knew nothing of such developments in her house and in the palace. Dhumaketu remarked:—"How could the thief have the knowledge of Vidyā's apartments, if you did not draw a map for him, you old hag?" They bound her in chains and drove her like an animal to the palace.

The flower-woman in the trap.

Rājā Vīra Sinha sat on his throne to pronounce his judgment on the daring thief who appeared to him to be a remarkable man, and whose performance sounded like a romance. Sundara was brought before him bound in chains; the courtiers

felt the influence of the charm of his personality. He appeared perfectly indifferent to his fate, and with a stately demeanour approached the throne. He was more handsome than all the princes that had stood as suitors for the hands of the princess. Rājā Vira Sinha felt compunction at the noble sight of the young man who would be welcome as his son-in-law, if only his birth, status in life, and learning, had qualified him for the high honour, and if he had not stooped to the wicked device of a thief for winning the heart of his pretty daughter. The sword of the chief officer of police was unsheathed and it stood ready awaiting only the command of the king to sever the head of the thief from his body before all the assembled court. The Rājā asked the young man to relate his story,—who he was, what was his father's name and why he stooped to such a mean device for gaining the princess. Sundara said in a half-humourous tone, "My name is Vidyāpati (lit. husband of Vidyā), my father's name is father-in-law of Vidyā, my home is in Vidyā-nagar (village of the name of Vidyā) and I belong to the caste of Vidyā." The offended chief was angry beyond measure at the audacity of the man, and the chief officer of the police wanted permission to kill him on the spot, but the chief by a glance cast secretly at the officer forbade him to do so. The more the Rājā tried to bring the thief to a confession of his guilt as also to giving an account of himself, the more did he frustrate him by ingenious replies, and at last recited 50 *slokas* composed by himself, extempore, in which he described his love to Vidyā, but these *slokas* (in

The prevarications of Sundara before the Rājā.

Sanskrit) which are found in the Vidyā Sundara of Bhārata Chandra and are well known as "Chora Panchāçata" could also be interpreted as signifying praises in honour of the Goddess Kāli. They have double meanings. The Rājā was struck by this display of erudition and felt that he was no ordinary person, but as he persisted in his waywardness, at last gave orders to take him away from his sight and lead him to the place of execution.

Order for execution.

The handsomest young man that ever met the eyes of men in Burdwan, being cruelly bound hand and foot, was being carried to the execution-ground, and the citizens that witnessed the scene felt sorrow and sympathy for the prince, especially the women-folk who made all kinds of reflections, some of which were not in good taste, as many of them expressed in an unreserved language their envy at the good fortune of Vidyā in having possessed him. These descriptions do not really represent the Hindu women whose natural shyness would scarcely allow them to overstep the limits of decency in such a gross manner. We have in our literature of to-day feminine characters like Āyeṣā and Kunda-nandinī—imitations of Rebecca and Haidee, who though they do not actually come in gowns and bodices, display the heart of European maids through the thin cover of Indian *sadi*. The feminine characters depicted in Vidyā Sundara and the ideas attributed to them are similarly foreign to us. They unmistakably show the stamp of the influence which the literature of an alien people left on our own.

Sundara being taken to the execution ground, prays to Kāli for succour. The story of Çrimanta

Saved by the Mother.

Sadāgara repeats itself here. Sundara prays to Kāli invoking her by names which begin with each of the 34 letters of the Bengali alphabet. He receives the never failing help of the mother; a great army of ghosts come and bind the king's army with chains.

In the court of the Rājā the bird *cuka* communicated a strange story. It told the Rājā that the thief was no other than the far-famed prince of Kānchi, Sundara, whose learning, handsome appearance and martial acquirements were the pride of Southern India. The Rājā asked *cuka* as to why he did not give an account of who he was, though he was repeatedly asked to do so. The bird said, it was not the custom with a prince to give an account of himself, the royal ambassador introduced him to Rājās of those countries which he might happen to visit. The ambassador Gangābhāta had been sent to Kānchi to proclaim the challenge of Vidyā in that city and he was called in. After making obeisence to the Rājā he said in reply to the query put to him about the prince,—"The prince of Kānchi has the title of Mahākavi or great poet, because he possesses poetical powers in an uncommon degree. I saw him at Kānchi; than him a more handsome prince does not exist in the world; when he heard of the beauty of Vidyā and of the challenge she had offered, he suddenly disappeared from the city and since then nothing is known of him. His royal parents in great distress sent messengers everywhere to make enquiries about his whereabouts. But so long as I was there he did not return. It is not unlikely that he has come to Burdwan."

The story told by Çuka confirmed by Gangā Bhāta.

The Rājā sent the ambassador to the execution-ground to identify the thief if he was really the prince. Gangābhāta came back forthwith and declared that the thief was the prince, to whom he had, while at Kānchi, delivered the letter of challenge.

Sundara identified.

The Rājā himself went to the execution-ground. There he saw his army mysteriously bound with chains and unable to speak, and the prince in an attitude of prayer looking up to heaven. He seemed so completely resigned that he looked like a beautiful statue placed there to dispel the horror of the execution-ground. The Rājā went and embraced him as his son-in-law, and by the grace of Kāli the royal army was released from the chains and was once more set free.

The marriage of Vidyā and Sundara had already taken place according to the Gandharva system,—the ritual of which consisted only in the exchange of flower-garlands between the couple as a sign of their mutual selection of each other, and the public ceremony was now performed with great *eclat*. Sundara after having stayed at Burdwan for some time went to Kānchi with his wife Vidyā and lived many long years in happiness. Nor must we omit to say that during the marriage festivities Hirā the flowerwoman was released and rewarded by Rājā Vīra Sinha.

Marriage and public festivities.

The flower-woman rewarded.

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(d) Early poets of the Vidyā Sundara-poems.

The oldest Vidyā Sundara that we have been able to secure, was written by Govinda Dās in

The story is an old one.

1595 A. D. The poet was born at Deogrām in Chittagong and belonged to the Atriya Gotra, and to the line of Naradās who was probably a Kāyastha. It appears that there had been previous poems on Vidyā Sundara from which our author drew his materials. We find in the Brahma khanda of the Bhavişya Purāṅa* the story of Vidyā Sundara described at some length in racy Sanskrit verses. It is wrong to suppose that Bhārata Chandra was the first to connect the story with the Burdwan Rāj-family and that he did so to satisfy a private grudge. In the Brahma khanda we find mention not only of Burdwan as the place of occurrence of its incidents but also of Rājā Vīra Sinha; and Rāma Prasāda whose Vidyā Sundara is earlier, as well places the scene in Burdwan. Besides these, in the Padmāvati by Ālāol we find a reference to the underground passage dug by Sundara which proves that the tradition of the story had existed in the country for a long time. The mould in which it was subsequently cast by Bhārata Chandra and other poets of his school bears the mark of Māhomedan influence. Govinda Dās's poem was free from those vulgarities which are now associated with the story, owing to the way in which Bhārata Chandra dealt with it. But Govinda Dās wrote in a highly Sanskritised style and in this respect had affinities with subsequent schools of poets. The following passage shows the sort of style which now came gradually into favour and from which it is so hard to translate, owing to the fact that its merits lie wholly in its literary art :—

Govinda Dās 1595 A. D.

* According to Wilson, Brahma Khanda was composed shortly after 1550 A.D. See Indian Antiquary vol. XX P 419 (1891).

A hymn to Çiva.

*"All praise be to the Lord of gods Çiva,—the saviour of the world. Many salutations do I offer to thy lotus feet. The stream of the Ganges adorns thy locks,—the moon is thy crown;—garlands of flowers and snakes coiled into the form of wreaths adorn thy neck and soft curls of hair hang loose and touch thy ears. Thy three eyes though half shut gleam fiercely, and the lustre of thy body is like unto a silver mountain. O Thou, the destroyer of the enemies of the gods and of the god of love,—Thou Prince of ascetics, regaling thyself in the joy of Yoga, thou Lord of Gouri—thy humble votary pays his worship unto thee."

Govinda Dās was of a religious turn of mind and often his reflections are worthy of one versed in Vedānta philosophy. Here are a few lines:—

Vedantic ideas.

†"As one sees the reflection of himself in a mirror, so is Kāli reflected in the universe. All emanate from her and pass into her, just as the waters of the sea rising to the sky fill the streams and rivers with rain and flow back to the sea."

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* জয় দেবনাথ জগত তারণ চরণ সরোরুহে বহু মিনতি।
সুর নদীচন্দ্রিম মুকুট মাল ভূষণ ফণিমাল কুন্তল মোহেশ্রুতি॥
টলমল ত্রিনয়ন জ্বাল আধমিলন রুজত ধরাধর অঙ্গদ্যুতি।
সুররিপু ত্রিপুরহরদাহন অবহেলন সীমবরণ শিবযোগপতি॥
বিলসতি যোগভোগ ভববাসন দীনশরণ জয় গৌরীপতি॥

Kālikā Maṅgala by Govinda Dās.

† প্রতিবিম্ব দেখি যেন দরপণ তারা।
সংসারের যত দেখ সেইত শরীরা॥
সমুদ্রের জল যেন নদ নদী ভরে।
সেই জল পুনরপি মিশায় সাগরে॥

Kālikā Maṅgala by Govinda Dās.

After Govinda Dās the next writer of Vidyā Sundara that we have been able to trace is Kriṣna Rāma. He was a Kāyastha by caste, born at Nimtā a village close to Belghariā, a station on the East Bengal Railway. Kriṣṇa Rāma's Vidyā Sundara was written in the year 1686 A. D.

Kriṣṇa Rāma 1686 A.D.

Kṣemānanda.

Of Kṣemānanda's Vidyā Sundara—the date of composition is quite unknown. It is evidently very old to judge from the hand-writing of the incomplete manuscript that has been obtained.

Madhu Sudana.

Vidyā Sundara by Madhu Sudan Kavīndra—The story is told very briefly in the poem. The date of composition is not known.

Vidyā Sundara by Rāma Prasāda Sen.

Rāma Prāsada.

Rāma Prasāda was that great saint and poet of the 18th century whose name is known and revered throughout Bengal. Whatever was the cause, this saintly poet conceived the whim of writing the indecent story of Vidyā Sundara. His poem was the model which inspired Bhārata Chandra to write in a similar strain. Ram Prasāda was favoured by Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra as appears from the grant of 100 bighās of rent-free land which was conferred on him by the Rājā in 1785 A. D. It may have been under court-influence or due to some juvenile poetic freak that Rāma Prasāda set his hand to the task of writing a poem for which nature had not fitted him. He has been outdone by Bhārata Chandra whose poem of Vidyā Sundara far excels the one he wrote. But Rāma Prasāda in his vulgarities, his pedantry, and other faults of the age was not a whit behind his more successful rival. The details of vulgar and indecent love which are found

in Bhārata Chandra's poem were all anticipated by Rāma Prasāda, and in fact the former seems in such matters to have taken his cue from him. Bhārata Chandra gave a finish to the style by a harmony of expression which Rāma Prasāda had sought for in vain. Though himself a learned scholar and Sanskritist, Rāma Prasāda scarcely shows a musical ear in this work. His efforts to introduce high sounding Sanskritic words are far from happy; they remind us of the attempts of the elephant to please Adam and Eve in the garden of Eden, as described by Milton :—

Failure of Rāma Prasāda in Sanskritic style.

"The unweildy elephant,
To make them mirth, used all his might, and wreathed
His lithe proboscis."

The style of Rāma Prasāda is made cumbrous by Sanskritic expressions, such as :—

* "সহজে কলঙ্কী সে তবাস্য সম নহে"
† "জলস্থলে চান্তরীক্ষে"
"ক্ষেপ করে দশ দিক্ষু লোষ্ট্রবিবর্দ্ধনে"
‡ "পূর্ণচন্দ্র শোভা যেন পিবতি চকোর"
§ "আগত ভানু রজনী চলি যায়।
বারে বারে ডাকে রাণী, জাগৃহি, জাগৃহি
উঠ উঠ প্রাণ গৌরী, এই নিকটে গিরি,
এবমুচিতমধুনা তব নহি নহি।
সুতমাগধ বন্দী কৃতাঞ্জলি কথয়তি
নিদ্রা জহিহি জহিহি।"

* "The moon is spotted and so cannot bear comparison with your face."

† "In water, on land and in the sky."

‡ "As if the beauty of the full moon were drunk by the bird Chakora."

§ "The sun is rising and the night goes away. O my Umā, awaken. There stands your father. You should not behave so. The bards and singers with closed palms are singing 'arise, awake from your sleep'."

As the above is quoted to show how the poet fails to produce an effect by his high sounding words, a translation is hardly called for though I give one in the foot-note. The words 'তবাস্য,' 'দিক্ষু,' 'চান্তরীক্ষে,' 'পিবতি,' 'জাগৃহি,' 'এবমুচিতমধুনা,' 'কথয়তি' and 'জহিহি' are pure Sanskrit forms and though Bengali is now a highly Sanskritised dialect, the above forms could have no chance of being introduced into our written language.

These passages show a curious medley of Sanskrit and Bengali words and remind us of the similar style of Kriṣṇa Dās Kavirāja's Chaitanya Charitāmrita.

Bhārata Chandra and Rāma Prasāda—a contrast.

Bhārata Chandra destroyed the temple of fame which Rāma Prasāda had erected for himself in the poem of Vidyā Sundara, and with those materials raised one to glorify himself. He is so profusely indebted to the preceding poet that there is scarcely a line in Rāma Prasāda's poem, the ring of which is not echoed in Bhārata Chandra's work. Yet the latter produces such a singular effect by harmony of words, that Rāma Prasāda, upon whose work he draws freely for materials, must be satisfied with the wages of a day-labourer while Bhārata would claim the reward of the artist who creates a master-piece. I quote below * extracts from both

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A description of Vidyā's beauty.

* "ডুবিল কুরঙ্গশিশু মৃগেন্দ্রসুধায়
লুপ্তপ্রায় তনুমাত্র নেত্র দেখা যায়॥
নাভিপদ্ম পরিহরি মত্ত মধুপান।
ক্রমে ক্রমে বাড়িল বারণ কুম্ভস্থান॥

"কাড়ি নিল মৃগমদ নয়ন হিল্লোলে,
কাঁদেরে কলঙ্কী চাঁদ মৃগলয়ে
কোলে॥
নাভিপদ্মে যেতে কাম কুচশম্ভু বলে।
ধরিল কুন্তল তার রোমাবলী ছলে।

poems, and place them side by side to show to what extent the one has drawn upon the other. I shall not attempt a translation of the passages into English, as no sense could be imparted without

কিম্বা লোমাবলী ছলে বিধি-	কে বলে শারদ শশী সে মুখের
বিচক্ষণ।	তুলা।
যৌবন কৈশোর দ্বন্দ্ব করিল ভঞ্জন॥	পদনখে পড়ে তার আছে
কোন বা বড়াই কাম পঞ্চ	কতগুলা॥
শরতুণে।	কেবা করে কামশরে কটাক্ষের
কত কোটি খর শর সে নয়ন	সম।
কোণে॥	কটুতায় কোটি কোটি কালকূট সম॥
Rāma Prasāda.	Bhārata Chandra.

Marriage under Gandharba form.

"উত্তম ঘটক সুন্দরের গাঁথা হার	"বিবাহ নহিলে হয় কেমনে
বরকর্ত্তা কন্যাকর্ত্তা চিত্ত	বিহার।
দোঁহাকার॥	গন্ধর্ব্ব বিবাহ হইল মনে আঁখি
পুরোহিত হইলেন আপনি মদন।	ঠার॥
বিদ্যালাপছলে বুঝি পড়াল বচন॥	কন্যাকর্ত্তা হইল কন্যা বরকর্ত্তা
উলুদিছে ঘন ঘন পিক সীমন্তিনী।	বর।
নয়ন চকোর সুখে নাচিছে	পুরোহিত ভট্টাচার্য্য হইল পঞ্চশর॥
নাচনি॥	
বরযাত্র মলয় পবন বিধুবর।	কন্যাযাত্র বরযাত্র ঋতু ছয় জন।
মধুকর নিকর হইল বাদ্যকর॥	বাদ্যকরে বাদ্যকর কিঙ্কিণী কঙ্কণ॥
উভয়তঃ কুটুম্ব রসনা ওষ্ঠাধর।	নৃত্যকরে বেসরে নূপুরে গীতরায়।
পরস্পর ভুঞ্জে সুধা মুখেন্দু উপর॥	আপনি আসিয়া রতি এয়ো হল
নূপুর কিঙ্কিণী জালে নানা শব্দ হয়।	তায়॥
দুই দলে দ্বন্দ্ব যেন চন্দন সময়॥	ধিক ধিক অধিক আছিল সখি তায়।
সস্ত্রীক আইলা কাম দেখিতে	নিশ্বাস আতস বাজি উত্তাপে
কৌতুক।	পলায়॥
দম্পতীরে পঞ্চশর দিলেক	নয়ন অধর কর জঘন চরণ।
যৌতুক॥	দুঁহার কুটুম্ব সুখে করিছে ভোজন॥
Rāma Prasāda.	Bhārata Chandra.

elaborate annotations of such words as 'চন্দনসময়,' 'কুচশম্ভু,' 'মৃগমদ,' 'উলু,' etc., and even by such notes the affinity of the passages in point of language could not be fully conveyed to readers unacquainted with the niceties of our tongue.

Rāma Prasāda.

But Rāma Prasāda was a great poet, greater in many respects than Bhārata Chandra. His other works, to which we shall have to refer hereafter, have made landmarks in the history of our literary and spiritual thought. He was a seer and a saint, and though he was beaten in his juvenile attempts to compose a love poem, he shortly after achieved fame by his songs, which have immortalised him in Bengal and made him dear to the heart of every Bengali. We need not regret that he failed in his attempt to say an artificial thing, for his soul was artless. It is well that he was defeated in his effort to win precedence in a court where scurrility reigned;—the pity is that he soiled his hands by such an attempt to pander to the vitiated taste of the age. He was a scholar, but it is only when he forgets vain-glorious erudition, that he displays himself in his best and most favourable aspects. He was a finished literature and the language he had at his command was rich and varied, though he was not happy in his attempts to mingle Sanskrit and Bengali. It is when he appears as a child and uses the child's language, singing songs that welled up

"রাঙ্গা বলে কাট চোরে মশানে বান্ধাই।	"চাহে কাটিতে কোটাল, চাহে কাটিতে কোটাল।
আঁখি ঠেরে আর বার করে নিবারণ॥"	নয়ন ঠারিয়া মানা করে মহীপাল॥"
Rāma Prasāda.	Bhārata Chandra.

in his heart out of the exuberance of his devotional feeling,—when he sees the Divine mother in nature and forgets every thing else saying—"Enough O mother! Like the bee attracted by a painted flower, have I roved amongst the vain pleasures of the world. Enough have I tasted, I desire no more. Now the evening has come. It is the dusk of the evening, O mother, take this thy child, to thyself."* —that he appeals irresistibly to the heart. Each line of his songs throbs with the deep yearning of the soul. We shall deal with them hereafter. Rāma Prasāda himself said truly in one his songs †"My poems will crumble into dust but I shall live in my songs." Even as a child plays at being a soldier in dress that passes for a soldier's uniform, and, soldier-like, brandishes his little sword, but when he becomes weary, runs to his mother all covered as he is with the dust of the play-ground, and there in his natural aspect looks most lovely, so did Rām Prasāda—sick of the false play of pedantry which had occupied him for a while but had not realy satisfied him—run at the close of the heyday of his worldly career, to seek his Divine mother's grace. He now soothed his heart, vexed with the world's turmoil with songs, which, with their deep-toned melancholy and their resignation to the divine mercy ring out even now in the

His Songs.

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* "বৃথা আশা চিত্রের পদ্মেতে পড়ি ভ্রমর ভুলে র'ল।
যা হবার তা হ'ল এখন সন্ধ্যা হল
কোলের ছেলে মা কোলে নিয়ে চল॥"

† "গ্রন্থ যাবে গড়াগড়ি গানে হব ব্যস্ত।"

Rāma Prasāda.

villages of Bengal. There is no rustic, no old man, and no woman in Bengal who has not drawn a truly inspired consolation from them in hours when the wrongs and sorrows of the world were like to bruise the heart and make it heavy-laden.

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(c) Bhārata Chandra Rāi Guṅakara—the great poet of the Eighteenth Century.

A short time after Rāma Prasāda's Vidyā Sundara was composed, Bhārata Chandra described the same story in his poem, called the Annadā Maṅgala, which at once rose to the highest point of fame and popularity, throwing into the shade all the earlier works on the subject.

His life.

Bhārat Chandra Rāi was born in the year 1722. A. D., at Peroñ Basantapur in the district of Hughly. His father Narendra Nārāyaṅa Rāi was a Zeminder of the place and had obtained the title of Rājā from the Nawab of Mursidabad. There arose a dispute between Narendra Rāi and the Rājā of Burdwan on a boundary-question and the former is said to have given offence to the independent chief by a public mention of Viṣnu Kumari, his queen. Two Rajput soldiers named Ālam Chandra and Kṣema Chandra were sent by the angry Rājā to chastise Narendra Rāi. They were accompanied by a number of armed men who took all the lands belonging to Rājā Narendra Narāyaṅa by force and ousted him from his possessions, allowing him to retain his hold on his homestead only. Narendra Rāi was, as may be understood, reduced to great poverty after this event. His son Bhārata Chandra stayed with his maternal uncles at Noāpārā and prosecuted his studies in a Sanskrit *tol* at Tājpur. When

only fourteen, he married a girl of the Keçarkuni family of Brahmins at Sārada, (a village in Pergana Maṇgalghāta) whose status in society was much inferior to his own—in the face of great opposition from his parents and brothers. They were not prepared to receive him or his bride at their house; so the young fellow came to Devānandapura in the district of Hughly and sought the favour of a wealthy Kāystha named Rāma Chandra Munsi who accorded him a warm reception, being pleased with his talents. He learned Persian at his place and on an occasion of worship of the god Satya Narāyaṅa composed a short poem in honour of the deity, which greatly pleased the audience. This poem was composed in 1737 A. D., when Bhārata Chandra was only fifteen. At this time his parents permitted him to return home though they would not allow his wife to come with him. He came back to his family-residence and was deputed by his father to settle certain questions about their landed property with the Rājā of Burdwan. But for some reason or other Bhārata Chandra was thrown into prison by the Rājā for a few months. On being released he felt a desire to visit the Jagannātha temple of Puri. Arriving at the shrine he met with a warm treatment from some of the Pāndās who were delighted with his learning. He was greatly impressed with Vaiṣnavism at the time and is said to have taken into his head the idea of turning ascetic and leading a holy life in the Vrindā groves. With this object he marched bare-footed, but the village Khānākula lay in his way, where a relation of his wife stopped him and by persuasive arguments, the force of which he took no time in appreciating, brought the

Troubles owing to marriage.

A poem on Satya Nārāyaṅa 1737 A.D.

Thrown into prison.

young aspirant for a holy life to the village Sāradā where his wife lived. The Vrindā groves with the vision of God, that had inspired the poet, melted away like mist from his imagination, and in the village of Sāradā he found a metal more attractive where he spent some time in the company of his young wife.

In the Company of his wife

Our poet next came to Farāsdāngā where a zemindar named Indra Nārāyaṅā Chaudhari took some interest in him and introduced him to Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra of Navadwipa. This Rājā, who, as already said, was a great patron of letters, discovered in the young man poetical talents of an extraordinary order and immediately appointed him as his court-poet on a pay of Rs. 40 a month.* The clouds that had gathered over his fortune, now passed away and he met with sunny days. His Annadā Maṇgala was composed by the command of Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra. The book was completed in 1752 A. D. About this time he built a new home at Mulājore—a village which was shortly after leased by Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra to one Rāma Deva Naga. This man was very exacting and our poet was sore troubled by his growing demands. He wrote 8 couplets in Sanskrit describing the oppression of Rāma Deva Naga, the naive humour of which so greatly pleased the Rājā that he granted to his favourite poet 105 *bighas* of rent-free land at Gusta in Pergana Āmalpur and 16 *bighas* more at Mulājore. Bhārata Chandra died of diabetes in 1760 A. D. three years after the English had won the battle of Plassey. He was decorated

Introduced to Kriṣṅa Chandra.

Annadā Maṇgala in 1752.

105 + 16 bighas of land.

Death in 1760 A.D.

* It was not at all meagre at the time, Warren Hastings' pay as a Member of Council being Rs. 300 a month in 1764.

with the title of Rāi Guṇākarā by Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra.

The popularity of Vidyā-Sundara.

Bhārata Chandra's Annadā Maṇgala was at one time so popular in Bengal, that there was scarcely a young man or young woman with any pretensions to learning who could not reproduce passages from it. The story of Vidyā Sundara was popularised by his work to such an extent that our popular theatres called *yatras* at one time rang with the songs of Vidyā and Sundara. The long poetical descriptions did not suit the *yatras*, so Gopāla Uriyā, a famous Yātrāwālā of later times took the cue from Bhārata Chandra's writings and composed short and light songs based on the text of his poem, which became very popular in the country. In these *yatras* the dance of Hīrā, the flower woman, was a point of great interest. We may quote the following song as a specimen :—

Adopted in yātrās.

*"It is so curious that a handsome man like you is in quest of lodgings. There are many lotuses to receive the bee, why should there not be many hearts to welcome thee ! Hear me, O youngman, when I pluck flowers, the bees fly around me—that is the pleasure that keeps me at Burdwan."

The prince is brought to the house of Hīrā where he constantly harps on Vidyā; the flower-

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* "হায়রে দশা কি তামাসা বাসার জন্য ভাবছ কেনে।
হৃদকমলে দিতে বাসা আশা করে কতই জনে॥
শুন নাগর তোমায় বলি, নিত্য নিত্য কুসুম তুলি,
সঙ্গে সঙ্গে ফিরে অলি, এই সুখে থাকি বর্দ্ধমানে॥"

A song sung in Gopāla Uriyā's *yatra*.

woman again sings* "What a foolish young man! He constantly says 'aunt, give me my Vidyā.' Is she a jewel that a woman can keep tied in the end of her *sadi* and produce on demand!" These songs and hundreds of such, a attributed to Gopāl Uriyā and other Yātrāwālās, were once in every man's mouth. Their inspiration came direct from Bhārata Chandra. In fact in the depraved atmosphere of towns, directly affected by court-influence on the eve of the downfall of the Mahomedan power, Vidyā-Sundara became the craze of the young dilettantes of Bengal who revelled in the literature of sensualism.

The contents of Annadā-Maṇgala.

The Annadā Maṇgala by Bhārata Chandra, of which Vidyā Sundara forms a part, is divided into three parts. The first part is devoted to the sacrifice performed by Dakṣa, the death of Satī, her rebirth as Umā, her marriage with Çiva and subsequent domestic scenes at Kailās. It also describes the futile attempt of the sage Vyāsa to build a second Benares, with the object of thwarting the God Çiva, and gives account of Harihoḍa and Bhabānanda Mazumdār—ancestors of Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra. The second part describes the story of Vidyā-Sundara. The last part is devoted to a description of the wars of Rājā Pratāpāditya of Jessore with Mān Sing, the Governor of Bengal,

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*"কোথাকার হাবা ছেলে হাসি পায় শুনে,
সদা বলে কই মাসি তুই বিদ্যা দিলিনে,
আঁচলে কি বাঁধা আছে দিব তা এনে?"

Sung in Gopāla Uriyā's *yatra*.

the eventual defeat and death of Rājā Pratāpāditya, and further accounts of Bhabānanda Mazumdār, who helped Mān Sing in his fight with the Rājā; it also describes Bhabānanda's visit to Delhi where he is said to have held a heated controversy on religion with Jāhāngir, who in a great rage ordered him to be imprisoned. An account is also given of his release from prison and of the emoluments he received from the Emper

His other works.

Besides Annadā Maṇgala, Bhārata Chandra wrote Rasamanjurī in Bengali, in which he classifies feminine emotions and gives illustrations in imitation of Sanskrit works on Rhetoric. His incomplete drama, called the Chandināṭaka, shows a curious admixture of Sanskrit, Bengali and Persian, proving that he was a finished master of the three languages. There are many short pieces besides the above, which Bhārata Chandra wrote on various subjects.

Onomatopoetic expressions.

One of the elements which we find in profusion in Bhārata Chandra's poetry is a liking for onomatopoetic expressions. A richness of sound is sometimes lent to his lines by a harmonious assemblage of words not to be found in any vocabulary, yet nevertheless conveying sense by the imitation of natural sounds. This is made very effective to the ear by the clever manipulation of the poet. Bhārata Chandra had a store-house of such words; he revelled in them; they were often coined by him; but he is nowhere unmeaning, as he always took his cue from natural sounds. It would be impossible to translate words which do not occur in any vocabulary. I shall quote a passage here, in the translation of which I cannot help introducing the

very sounds which the poet imitates, and the effect of which would be lost in a different language. The piece describes the dance of Çiva at the time of the final dissolution of the universe.

*"Çiva assumes the form of the great destroyer; the sound of his horn is terrible—*va vam bham-va vam bham.* His matted locks shake to and fro—*latapat-latapat*, and the murmuring stream of the Ganges flows—*chalacchal, kalakkal, talattal* through them. The snakes hiss—*phaniphan phaniphan* and the moon on his forehead burns like the sun : fire issues from it—*dhakadhvak-dhakadhvak ;* and from his mouth come the deep sounds *va vam bham-va vam bham.* The naked ghosts and goblins dance—*tadhia-tadhia.*"

A word in explanation of these lines:—Çiva the god of destruction is represented as having the moon on his forehead; the Ganges flows from his locks. The popular belief of the Hindus is that

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* "মহারুদ্র রূপে মহাদেব সাজে।
ভভম্ভম্ ভভম্ভম্ শিঙ্গা ঘোর বাজে॥
লটাপট্ জটাজুট সংঘট গঙ্গা।
ছলচ্ছল্-টলট্টল্-কলকল তরঙ্গা॥
ফণাফণ্ ফণাফণ্ ফণীফন্ন গাজে।
দিনেশ প্রতাপে নিশানাথ সাজে॥
ধকধ্বক্ ধকধ্বক্ জ্বলে বহ্নি ভালে।
ভভম্ভম্ ভভম্ভম্ মহাশব্দ গালে॥
ধিয়া তাধিয়া তাধিয়া ভূত নাচে।
উলঙ্গী উলঙ্গে পিশাচী পিশাচে॥"

Bharata Chandra's Annadā Maṅgala.

the Ganges originates from the feet of the God Viṣṇu and its stream is caught by Brahmā in his *Kamandalu* (water-pot). Thence it flows down to the matted locks of Çiva and thence it comes down to the earth.

The words *chalacchal*, *kalakkal* and *talattal* in the fourth line which refer to the waves of the Ganges are singularly happy. *Chalacchal* in the colloquial dialect seems to signify a flow, *talattal* transparency, and *kalakkal* the sweet murmur of the waves. Three onomatopoetic words not to be found in the Bengali vocabulary have thus been strung together in the same line, to suggest to the ear three qualities of a stream ; a line more happy could not be conceived. The whole of this poem is written in the sublime Sanskrit metre called the Bhujangaprayāta. It is to be read with special care to place the proper accents on the vowels. The lines rhyme in measured sounds with a sweet jingle and the whole is an instance of admirable word-painting in poetry.

The tendency to onomatopœia in poetry which was taken from Bhārata Chandra, is marked in many later poems, and often the effect produced by such combinations of words is singularly happy, as in the passage given below from Jaynārāyan's Harilīlā.* We refrain from giving an English

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* "সভামধ্যে রত্নসিংহাসনে নরপতি।
শিরে শ্বেতছত্র ইন্দুকুন্দ জিনি ভাতি॥
ফক্ ফক্ জ্বলে ভস্ম ত্রিপল্লব ভালে।
মিস্ মিস্ যজ্ঞভস্ম ভ্রূমধ্যে জ্বলে॥

translation of the piece as it is impossible to convey, even in a small degree, any idea of the sonorous music created by its onomatopoetic expressions.

Rhyming perfected by Bhārata Chandra.

The rules of rhyming had not hitherto been strictly followed. As poetry used to be sung, the defects in metrical form were made up for by the tune. But as the domain of poetry gradually separated itself from that of music, the art of poetical composition became gradually more finished, and perfection in rhyme was aimed at by Bhārata Chandra and the poets of his school. Hitherto it was held sufficient if the last letters of a couplet rhymed with one another; but the keener perception of the ear now required not only a fulfilment of the above condition, but also an agreement of the vowels preceding the last letters of a rhyming couplet. According to the last principle rhyming of লোক with অভিষেক, রস with বাস, বনমালা with গেলা, করে with তীরে would be faulty. Among the Vaiṣnava *Pada-karttas* Govinda Dās, whose ear was naturally the most keen to a harmony of sounds, had committed the smallest number of faults in

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টলমল মুকুতা কুণ্ডল কাণে দোলে।
টল্ টল্ গজমতি মালা দোলে গলে॥
কস্ কস্ কসাতা সটুকা কাটিতে।
ঝল্ ঝল্ ঝকমকে স্বর্ণ ঝালরেতে॥
ডগমগ সপ্ত কন্যা চামর লইয়া।
ধীরে ধীরে দোলাইছে রহিয়া রহিয়া॥
ঝন্ ঝন্ লাগে কাণে কঙ্কণের ধ্বনি।
ঝক্‌মক্ চামর দণ্ডেতে জলে মণি॥"

Jaynārāyaṅ's Harilīlā.

this respect. But perusing closely the Annadā Maṇgala by Bhārata Chandra (a poem running over 13000 lines) we scarcely find one instance of disagreement of vowel-sounds in the final syllables of rhyming couplets. One or two examples of this defect are found in his short poem on Satyanārāyaṅa which the poet composed when he was only 15 years old. In the whole range of Bengali literature, no poet has shown a finer sense of harmony of sound or a greater skill in the choice of his words than Bhārata Chandra. In our own day some poets have followed the principle in rhyming stated above; but in an earlier epoch of the history of our literature, it was Bhārata Chandra who held up the torch that lighted the path of subsequent poets, so all credit is due to him. The Sanskrit metres that Bhārata Chandra introduced into his Bengali poems are faultless. As the long and short sounds of vowels are missed in the spoken dialect of Bengal, it required a remarkable power to introduce the measured sounds of noble Sanskrit metres in our tongue, and Bhārata Chandra's poems in the Totaka and Bhujangaprayāta metres not only show perfect adherence to classical rules, but they flow so easily and with such a natural grace, that no one would doubt, after perusing them, that Bengali is a true daughter of Sanskrit, and that a poet who knows the resources of the language can give her a form which would prove her striking affinity in all respects with that of her august parent.

Though it is so difficult to convey to our readers an idea of the beauty of Bhārata Chandra's poems, depending, as this does, on a singularly happy

arrangement of words, we here attempt a translation of one passage of remarkable elegance :—

The advent of the spring.

*"While the cuckoos sang and the bees hummed about the *bakula* flowers, the Goddess Annapurṅā sat in a jewelled shrine. A stream of cool and lotus-scented water over-flowed its banks and the waves danced to the melody of the air. The Spring season had arrayed himself like a prince, and, accompanied by the six modes of music had taken up his abode beneath the *acoka* tree. Here and there the bees were humming about the flowers, and the god of love had strung his bow. Laughing blossoms gemmed the wood-land bowers. Bhārata Chandra was charmed to see the advent of the Spring."

But the original passage subjoined in the foot-note discovers to us that Bengali is one of the sweetest tongues of the world. The words chosen for this piece chiefly consist of the soft letters *l*, *m*, *n*,—the hissing *s* and the harsh *r* are, generally speaking, omitted from these lines. The poem, when recited with proper accentuation, charms the ear and sounds like music unsung. Many passages of Bhārata Chandra afford examples

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*"কল কোকিল, অলিকুল বকুল ফুলে।
বসিলা অন্নপূর্ণা মণি দেউলে॥
কমল পরিমল, লয়ে শীতল জল, পবনে টল টল, উছলে কূলে।
বসন্তরাজা আনি, ছয় রাগিণী রাণী, করিলা রাজধানী, অশোক মূলে॥
কুসুমে পুনঃ পুনঃ, ভ্রমরে গুনগুন, মদন দিল গুণ, ধনুক, হুলে।
যতেক উপবন, কুসুম সুশোভন, মধু-মুদিত-মন ভারত ভুলে॥

Bhārata Chandra's Annadā Maṅgala.

of this decorative art in composition for which Indian genius has a remarkable aptitude.

Spoiled by too much attention.

When Bhārata Chandra makes it a point to describe a beautiful woman, the metaphors gleaned from Sanskrit and Persian works cloud his poetic horizon. Niceties become absurdities and his learning stifles the natural flow of sentiment. When, however, a minor character is introduced, on which the poet does not consider it worth while to lavish classical metaphor preferring to trust to his own powers, his sparkling lines produce a far clearer impression. Vidyā's beauty as described by Bhārata Chandra is culled from all that the poet had read in books, and this again is overcoloured by his own monstrous fancy for the purpose of matching the classic poets in their own field. One can scarcely find his way through the thick array of wild and far-fetched similes, and we wonder at the taste which tolerated the unrestrained exaggerations, the wild excesses, and the puerile funs on words which they disclose. But, reserving all his learning for the description of Vidyā, the poet draws off-hand a picture of Hīrā, the flower woman.

Happier in delineating minor characters.

Hīra, the flower-women.

*"As the sun set and the night approached, there came along a flower woman, of the name of Hīrā

*"সূর্য্য যায় অস্তগিরি আসিল রজনী।
হেন কালে তথা এক আসিলা মালিনী॥
কথায় হীরার ধার হীরা তার নাম।
দাঁত ছোলা মাজা দোলা হাস্য অবিরাম॥
আছিল বিস্তর ঠাট প্রথম বয়সে।
এবে বুড়া তবু কিছু গুঁড়া আছে শেষে॥"
Bhārata Chandra's Vidyā Sundara.

(lit. a diamond) whose words indeed sparkled like the diamond. Her teeth were painted ; she moved with a pleasant gait, and there was always a smile on her lips. She had been very charming in her youth, and though now grown matronly, she possessed some small traces of her better days."

The lines 'আছিল বিস্তর ঠাট প্রথম বয়সে। এবে বুড়া তবু কিছু গুঁড়া আছে শেষে॥' sparkle with humour, especially in the clever use of the words বুড়া and গুঁড়া. In another passage the line 'অস্তগেলা রোষ, উদয় রস' (with the setting of resentment, arose grace) indicates the passing away of one emotion and the rise of another, by a happy suggestion of the setting of the sun, followed by the rise of the moon in the sky. There is much beauty in the pun on the words রোষ and রস. There occur innumerable passages of the nature in which the poet skilfully polishes and sets each word, as a jeweller might polish and set a stone in a piece of gold.

We shall here attempt to translate a passage from the Annadā Mangala, in which the poet describes a flood that destroyed a considerable part of Mān Sing's army.

The flood.

†"The sky was overcast with dark clouds. The winds began to blow with redoubled force,—the thunder roared,—the lightning flashed,—the wind

† 'দশ দিক আঁধার করিল মেঘগণ।
দুন হয়ে বহে উনপঞ্চাশ পবন॥
ঝঞ্ঝনার ঝঞ্ঝনী, বিদ্যুৎ চকমকী।
হড়মড়ী মেঘের, ভেকের মকমকী॥
ঝড়ঝড়ি ঝড়ের, জলের ঝরঝরী।
চারিদিকে তরঙ্গ, জলের তরতরী॥

rustled and the waters splashed. Waves came rushing from all sides; the trees trembled at the sounds of thunder; darkness prevailed, and hails pattered. The outer screens of the Rājā's tents were carried away by the winds; people became terror-struck; the huts raised for the soldiers were swept away by the flood which now overtook the camp; elephants were drowned;—carriages were hopelessly wrecked in mud and the camels perished:—the soldiers threw away their guns, their turbans, their uniforms and swords, and with their shields abreast swam across the foaming stream. Thousands of men were drowned. Urdu-bazar with all its goods lay under water;—the carcasses of sheep, cocks and hens were all huddled together; the fruit-seller with his wife took to swimming. Heaps of grass went floating by, and upon one of them sat the young woman who used to sell it. She was weeping and lamenting her lot saying 'Never O Lord, was such a disaster seen. I am only 15 or 16 years of age; by divorce and death I have changed eleven husbands by this time. This present son of a slave has brought me here to die, but if I die, the matrimonial prospects of how many others will be gone!' The drummer with his drum was carried past by the flood, and the musician

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থরথরী স্থাবর, বজ্রের কড়কড়ী।
ঘুট ঘুট আঁধার, শিলায় তড়তড়ী॥
ঝড়ে উড়ে কানাৎ, দেখিয়া উড়ে প্রাণ।
কুঁড়ে ঠাট ডুবিল, তাম্বুতে এল বাণ॥
সাঁতারিয়া ফিরে ঘোড়া, ডুবে মরে হাতী।
পাঁকে গাড়া গেল গাড়ি উট তার সাথী॥

clasped in his arms the long gourd of his lyre (*vina*) as he floated across the stream. There was panic on all sides. The very soldiers were lamenting saying 'All is lost by this journey to Bengal. All the hard earned money won by risking our lives, is lost. Oh woe to us! Woe to us!'"

The first eight lines bring before us a vivid scene of storm and flood, by means of an array of

ফেলিয়া বন্দুক জামা পাগ তলোয়ার।
ঢাল বুকে দিয়া দিল সিপাই সাঁতার॥
খাবি খেয়ে মরে লোক হাজারে হাজার।
তল গেল মাল মাত্তা উরুহু বাজার॥
বকরী বকরা মরে কুকড়ী কুকড়া।
কুক্কড়ানী কোলে করি ভাসিল কুক্কড়া॥
ঘাসের বোঝায় বসে ঘেসেড়ানী ভাসে।
ঘেসেড়া মরিল ডুবে তাহার হাভাসে॥
কাঁদি কহে ঘেসেড়ানী হায় রে গোসাঁই।
এমন বিপাকে আর কভু ঠেকি নাই॥
বৎসর পনর ষোল বয়স আমার।
ক্রমে ক্রমে বদলানু এগার ভাতার॥
হেদে গোলামের বেটা বিদেশে আনিয়া।
অনেকে অনাথ কৈল মোরে ডুবাইয়া॥
ডুবে মরে মৃদঙ্গী মৃদঙ্গ বুকে করি।
কাপোয়াং ভাসিল বীণার লাউ ধরি॥
বাপ বাপ মরি মরি হায় হায়।
উভরায় কাঁদে লোক প্রাণ যায় যায়॥
কাঙ্গাল হইনু সবে বাঙ্গালায় এসে।
শির বেচে টাকা করি সেও যায় ভেসে॥"

Bhārata Chandra's Annadā Mangala.

onomatapoetic words, each of which has been chosen with singular care, the effect of the whole being such that it cannot be rendered in translation. In the remaining portion of the piece, the poet strives more for an artistic effect of language than for a realistic description of the flood. The whole thing looks like a storm painted on a scene under a mellow light. We miss the actual cries, the wringings of the heart and the death-agonies consequent on the devastating catastrophe. The descriptions of horror grow almost charming, being set, as it were, to a musical air. The lines 'ডুবে মরে মৃদঙ্গী মৃদঙ্গ বুকে করি। কালোয়াত ভাসিল বীণার লাউ ধরি॥ and 'কাঙ্গাল হইনু সবে বাঙ্গলায় এসে' show that the poet's heart did not melt into pity at the sight of a disaster which had killed thousands of men, but that he could enliven its description by a poetic touch, and was even willing to enjoy the scene, maintaining a vein of light humour in his gay couplets.

Niceties of sound.

Poetry was now reduced to an art; it delighted in niceties of sound. Bhārata Chandra's poems are untranslatable. Take away the outer garb, and the picture that he draws loses all its attraction. His delicacy of colouring is perhaps peculiarly oriental. His finest things become poor in translation. The whole may be pronounced 'words, words, words' in the language of Hamlet; but, as a Bengali critic lately said, 'Bhārata Chandra's poetry is the Taj of Agra made in Bengal,—not in marble but in words.'

There are critics who would deprecate this art in literature. In a language like Bengali which

may be so easily wrought into exquisitely melodious strains, the artistic effect produced by a clever manipulation of sweet sounding words, can not be ignored. One who can raise emotions and portray pathos by metrical lines writes noble poetry no doubt, but there is a skilled labour in poetry which creates emotions not wholly definable, as do the unmeaning warblings of birds or the musical notes of a lyre. There is much poetry in mere sound—in its meaningless harmony and we must not deprecate the value of this in our mellifluous Bengali tongue.

Prāṅārāma Chakravarty.

After Bhārata Chandra, Prāṅārāma Chakravarty wrote a Vidyā Sundara in which we come across the following lines :—

* "The first Vidyā Sundara was written by Kriṣṅarāma, a native of the village Nimta ;—next we find one by Rāma Prasāda. After these two poets, Bhārata Chandra came to the field and incidentally described the story of Vidyā Sundara in his poem called the Annadā Mangala." He evidently did not know the names of those earlier poets who had written on the subject before Kriṣṅarāma.

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*" বিদ্যাসুন্দরের এই প্রথম বিকাশ।
বিরচিলা কৃষ্ণরাম নিমতা যার বাস ॥
তাঁহার রচিত পুঁথি আছে ঠাঁই ঠাঁই।
রামপ্রসাদের কৃত পরে দেখা পাই ॥
পরেতে ভারতচন্দ্র অন্নদামঙ্গলে
রচিলেন উপাখ্যান প্রসঙ্গের ছলে ॥"

Vidyā Sundara by Prāṅārāma.

II. (a) The Court of Rājā Rājavallabha in Dacca. Its poets—Jaya Nārāyaṅa Sen—Anandamoyi Devī.

Under court influence poetry became debased; though it is true that a few exquisite poetic touches might enliven scenes of sensualism. But the vocabulary of Bengali was enriched during this period by a treasure of choice expressions imported from Sanskrit. In Western Bengal Bhārata Chandra, as far as the Bengali language was concerned, ruled supreme in the domain of letters. The court of Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra was the nucleus from which flowed fashions and tastes which the aristocracy of Bengal loved to imitate. In Eastern Bengal Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra's great contemporary and rival Rājavallabha tried at his capital of Vikrampur to outdo him in all matters. Rājā Rajvallabha was not as great a scholar as Kriṣṅa Chandra, but was by far the more powerful of the two, having been placed at the helm of the administration of several of the provinces of Bengal. He was besides immensely rich. Kriṣṅa Chandra founded a town called Çivanivāsa, and the temples and edifices he built there show a bold attempt to combine saracenic with Hindu architecture. But the town of Rājanagara in Vikrampur, founded by Rājā Rājavallabha, far outshone the splendour of Çivanivāsa. With the unlimited resources that Rājā Rājavallabha commanded in Bengal, his new city was made a paradise, the like of which was not to be found in the country at that time outside Murshidabād. The famous Ekuça Ratna, with its twenty one spires, which in the distance looked like the crest of a diadem

Rajanagara the capital-town of Rāja-vallabha.

painted on the clouds,—the Navaratna, with nine spires, and the Sapta-ratna with seven spires, displayed great architectural beauty, and the Dolmancha with its mazy staircase and lofty cupola rose to a greater height than the Ochterlony monument of Calcutta. There were besides palaces in which the utmost sculptural skill available at the time in India was employed. All this gave to the town a look of wealth and grandeur which it would have been vain for Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra to attempt to approach in his new town, though Çivanivāsa in its own way was certainly a beautiful place. Rājanagara was unfortunately situated on the dreaded stream of the Kirttināçā—'the destroyer of fame'; this name had been earned by the river, which was a branch of the Padmā, by destroying a rich town founded by Chānd Ray and Kedār Ray —two chiefs of Bengal, in the 16th century. But a second time—in the middle of the 19th century the stream showed again one of its furious moods and by destroying Rājanagara caused a loss to Bengal, which for the Hindus can not be repaired. This beautiful city is now in the bed of the river. It was situated six miles away from the river, when suddenly in the year 1871 A.D. there was a cataclysm. It is said that people suddenly felt the roots of grass and plants snap beneath their feet, and a crack was created, which gaping wide open like the jaws of death made the whole plain, covered by a number of villages and city of Rājanagara, slowly fall down into the river bed with a crash; this catastrophe took a whole year for being complete. The desolation began in august 1871 and was complete about the same time in 1872. The spires

The catastrophe of 1871.

of the monuments, the Ekuçaratna, the Navaratna and the Dolmancha seemed during the cataclysm to struggle for a few moments with the stream of Kirttināça which in its fierce play dashed against the blocks of massive stone and bricks of which the town was built, till the whole scene passed from the sight like a dream, and the waves danced over the town, disclosing not a sign of its former grandeur and pomp. Rājā Rājavallabha's Rājanagara is now reduced to a dream. But the Rājā had not only built a city, far outshining in its glory the town of Çivanivāsa, but in his court there were poets of great power who were not unworthy rivals of Bhārata Chandra. In their elegance of style,—in the sweetness of choice Sanskrit expressions with which their poems are replete, Jayanārāyaṅa and his gifted niece Ānandamayī showed poetical powers of a remarkable order, and it is a pity that the Harilīlā and Chandī by Jayanārāyaṅa in which there occur many noble lines composed by Ānandamayī, could not have the circulation and the far-reaching fame which Bhārata Chandra's poems attained in the more favourable soil of Western Bengal. Jayanārāyaṅa as a poet was certainly a match for Bhārata Chandra, though all points considered, his poems lack the finish of his great rival's works. There are passages in the poem of the East Bengal poet which may rival the sparkling lines of Bhārata Chandra; but in common details Bhārata Chandra's hand moves more freely, and though the poems of both the poets have a family likeness in their ornate classical style, and in the depraved taste of the age, the favourite poet of Kriṣṅa Chandra is a more finished master of his art, as he is also more

The poets of the Court of Rāja-Vallabha.

Jaya-Nārāyaṅa compared with Bhārata.

concise, and commands a greater facility in the use of Sanskrit metres in Bengali.

Family-history of Jaya Nārāyaṅa

Jayanārāyaṅa was a cousin of Rājā Rājavallabha and was a Vaidy by caste. His ancestor Gopi Ramana Sen's name is mentioned by Mr. Beveridge in his history of Backerganj. Gopi Ramana's second son Kriṣṅa Rāma obtained the titles of Dewan and Krori (millionaire) from the Nawab of Murshidabad. From an account given in the 5th of the reports of the East India Company, we see that he was employed in collecting revenue of *Pergannah* Chāndpratāpa and other places. The family residence of Kriṣṅa Rāma was at the village Japsā near Rājanagara. Lālā Rāma Prasāda, his

Rāmagati.

son was famous for his extensive charity. The Lālā had four sons. The eldest Rāma Gati was famous for his high character and learning; he wrote a well known work in Bengali called the Māyātimir Chandrikā to which we shall have occasion to refer hereafter. The youngest Jayanārāyaṅa

Jayanārāyaṅa and his niece.

was one of the best poets in Bengal, and it was he who conjointly with his niece Ānandamayī wrote the poem called Harilīlā which displays a wonderful command over the language and abounds in passages of intrinsic poetic merit. All the members of this gifted family of noble men, the ladies not excepted, were well versed in Sanskrit. Ānandamayī was widely known for her learning. She at one

Ānandamayī.

time surprised the scholarly Brāhmins assembled in the court of Rājā Rājavallabha to perform the Vedic sacrifice called the Agniṣtomayajña, by offering the solution to a knotty point in connection with the sacrificial rite, with ample quotations from

the Vedic texts as authority. The passages in Harilīlā composed by Ānandamayī bear evidence of her erudition; in metre and wealth of words they closely follow classical Sanskrit, and when recited they sound more like Sanskrit than Bengali. Ānandamayī was married in 1761 to Ayodhyā Rāma Sen of Payagrāma in the district of Khulna.

We have had already occasion to quote some passages from Jayanārāyaṅa's poems on pages 360-361. His Harilīlā was composed in honour of the god Satyanārāyaṅa. As usual, in the case of poems of this class, the work which is of a considerable dimension, relates a story, the sequel of which illustrates the grace of the god towards his followers in the shape of gifts of earthly fortune. I quote another passage from Harilīlā below :—

From Harilīlā.

*"The night passed in this way. The eastern horizon was painted with the purple colours of the dawn. The stars gradually disappeared from the sky. The birds left their nests and flew in all directions. The raven was crowing from the tree and did not as yet alight on the ground. Chandrabhāna the hero) held the hands of Sunetrā (the heroine). 'Permit me to go' he said again and again to her. At the dawn of the day which was auspicious for the journey he left her, and her tearful eyes followed the course he took. She

The parting.

*"ঘোরতর রজনী অতীত এই মতে।
পূর্ব্বদিক রক্ত দিনকর-কিরণেতে॥
আকাশে নক্ষত্রগণ ভাঙ্গি যায় মেলা।
পাখিগণ ইতি উতি নিজ বাস ছাড়ে।
বিরলে ডাকিছে কাক ভূমে নাহি পড়ে॥

stood and looked wistfully as far as her eyes could see him. The moon, with false promises, left the beautiful *Kumuda* flower that had been so gay and happy during the night. The flower turned pale at the approach of the sun."

Ānandamayī, as I said, is fond of displaying her erudition. In her compositions she generally adopts Sanskrit metres, the pompous sweep of which she well retains in Bengali. A passage is given below to illustrate her learned style, which thinly veils under grandiloquent language, the immodest taste that characterised her age.

A marriage Scene by Ānanda-mayī.

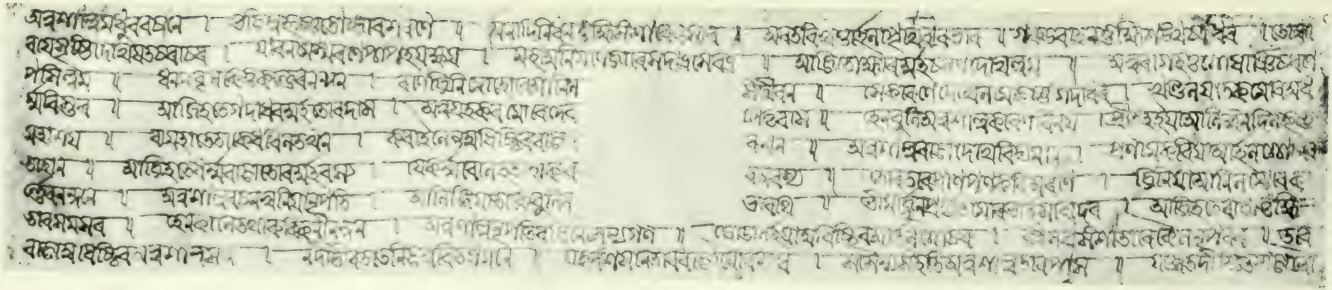
†"Look at the bevy of women assembled in myriads to the front and rear, peeping through the windows and confronting you at every point. The

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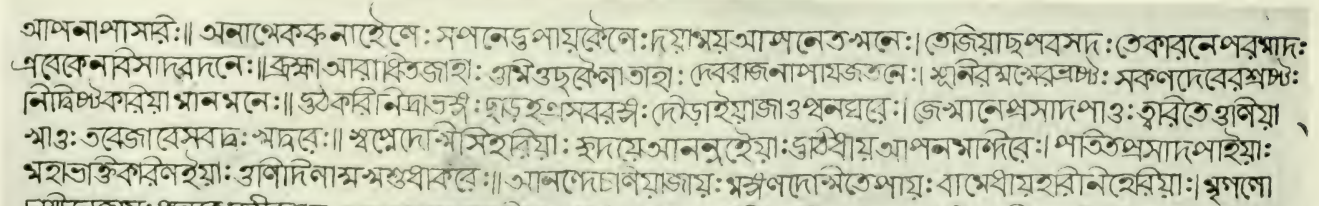
চন্দ্রভাণ করযুগ ধরি সুনেত্রার।
'যাই' বলি বিদায় মাগিছে বার বার॥
উষাকালে যাত্রা করি যায় চন্দ্রভাণ।
সজল নয়নে ধনি পাছেতে পয়ান॥
যতদূর চলে আঁখি চাহে দাঁড়াইয়া।
সুধাকর যায় ইন্দীবর ভাঁড়াইয়া॥
নিশি ভরি কুমুদিনী কৌতুকে আছিল।
রবি অবলোকনে মুখ মলিন হইল॥"

Harilīlā by Jaynārāyaṇa.

†" হের চোদিকে কামিনী লক্ষে লক্ষে।
সমক্ষে, পরক্ষে, গবাক্ষে কটাক্ষে॥
কতি প্রৌঢ়ারূপা ওরূপে মজন্তি।
হসন্তি, স্খলন্তি, দ্রবন্তি, পতন্তি॥



Page of old Bengali M.S. from Chittagang District. Dated 1597 A.D. Note that the script coming from a remote part of Bengal shows characters which are very old, though the actual date is comparatively recent.



Page of Bengali M.S. of Hari Lila from Dacca District. Date late eighteenth century written by a woman, Gangamani Devi.

beauties assembled there were running about at play, fantastically tripping and breaking into charming laughter. Even the sedate matrons of the group were overpowered by the beauty of the bridegroom. Look at the array of sweet and charming faces, of aquiline noses and of flowing tresses; and behold how beautiously bedecked they stand! With what fascination they speak and smile! Behold the slenderness and coquettish manner of the worthy belle. Look at her graceful flirtations, which show how well she is versed in the ways of Cupid, and in the art of captivating her admirers. Looking at Chandrabhāṅa, they found themselves lost in bewilderment and in an all-absorbing delirious excitement. The impassioned matron, the gay spinster, the wedded wife and the coy maiden, all stirred about in excitement and glee. Their dazzling earrings contused the lovely neck of many a merry woman. But they all moved about in gaiety. Some bore on their lips the marks of their lover's kiss. How many a golden beauty was

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কত চারুবক্ত্রা, সুবেশা, সুকেশা।
সুনাসা, সুহাসা, সুবাসা, সুভাষা॥
কত ক্ষীণমধ্যা, সুভঙ্গা, সুযোগ্যা।
রতিজ্ঞা, বশীজ্ঞা, মনোজ্ঞা, মদজ্ঞা॥
দেখি চন্দ্রভাণে কত চিত্তহারা।
নিকারা, বিকারা, বিহারা, বিভোরা॥
করে দৌড়িদোড়া মদমত্তা প্রৌঢ়া।
অনূঢ়া, বিমূঢ়া, নবোঢ়া, নিগুঢ়া॥
কোন কামিনী কুণ্ডলে গণ্ড-ঘৃষ্টা।
প্রহৃষ্টা, সচেষ্টা, কেহ ওষ্ঠদষ্টা॥

secretly pierced to the heart by the flowery arrows of Cupid! Many had come with dishevelled hair; many overcast with pallor; and many faint and slender. The tresses of many were in disorder and many had the *sadi* girt about the waist. The necklaces of others were loose and slipping off. The ornaments on their persons were falling and so was their wearing apparel. Many of them, smitten with the ardour of Cupid, broke into enchanting strains; and some put their arms on the shoulders of their companions and indolently stood addressing sweet and pleasing words to others. Some poured water on Sunetrā and others on Chandrabhāna, but all did so with great care, and they all poured water with their own delicate little hands, and as it fell on their persons, gurgling from the pitchers it kept time with the tingling music of their ornaments. The girl-friends of the bride

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অনঙ্গাস্ত্রভিন্না কত স্বর্ণবর্ণা।
বিকীর্ণা, বিশীর্ণা, বিদীর্ণা, বিবর্ণা॥
কারো ব্যস্ত বেণী নাহি বাস বক্ষে।
কারো হার কুর্পাস বিত্রস্ত কক্ষে॥
গলভূষণা কেহ নাহি বাস অঙ্গে।
গলদ্‌রাগিণী কেউ মাতিয়া অনঙ্গে॥
কারো বাহুবল্লী কারো স্কন্ধ দেশে।
রহিয়া সাধুবাক্য বক্তে প্রকাশে॥
সুনেত্রাকে কহে, কেহ চন্দ্রভাগে।
করে সেক শোয়ে সবে সাবধানে॥
সুহস্তে ঢালিছে সর্ব্ব বারি অঙ্গে।
ঝনং ঝনং গলং গলৎ পড়ে নীর অঙ্গে॥

addressing Chandrabhāña said in jest (alluding to the match) 'A diamond necklace dangles from the neck of a crow.' The bride and the bridegroom heard the jest, and hung down their heads in modesty, and the women burst into loud laughter."

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(b) The poets of the School of Bhārata Chandra.

A host of poets who imitated the style of Bhārata Chandra and who wrote in the latter part of the 18th century contributed works which have been suppressed by the Indian Penal Code. Stray copies of such works that came into our hands 25 years ago, are no longer available. But early in the 19th century, the stories of Chandra Kānta, of Nayantārā, and Kāminī Kumāra enjoyed great popularity with certain sections of our community. The authors of these poems were not great scholars like Bhārata Chandra, Jayanārāyaṇa or Ānandamayī, but they carried the depraved and indecent taste of the new school a step further. The moral atmosphere of young men living in towns was contaminated by their influence. Lord Byron's gallant character, Don Juan, entered the harem of a moslem monarch, disguised as a female servant and so palmed himself off

Chandra Kānta and Kāminī Kumāra; their bad taste.

সখী চন্দ্রভাগে বলে চাতুরীতে।
এ রত্নের মালা কাকের গলাতে॥
শুনি চাতুরী দম্পতী হেট মাথে।
ঢলাঢল্ গলাগল্ সখী সর্ব্ব তাতে॥"

A marriage-scene by Ānandamayī from Harilīla.

upon its occupants. Chandra Kānta, the young merchant, in the poem of the same name is described as having done similar freaks in the inner apartments of a Rājā. The influence of Persian literature is stamped on many of these works; but the Bengali language in these poems, it must be admitted, made further progress towards elegance. High sounding Sanskritic words were gradually dropped in favour of small and sweet colloquial words of classical origin and the metres run in a genial flow in these. I quote the following passage from Kāmini Kumāra by Kāli Kriṣṇa Dās.

The advent of spring.

*"The reign of autumn came to an end, and Spring, the Prince of seasons came to rule with his mighty host. The southern breeze, the royal messenger, proclaimed his approach to the world. The flowers, who constituted the army of the prince, dressed themselves beautifully to give them a reception. The *ketaki* with saw in hand stood proudly smiling. The *champaka* held a spear, and hastened to the spot. The *baka* tree wore the crooked bow of its flowers like the crescent moon.

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*"হিমান্ত হইলে পরে বসন্ত রাজন।
দলবল লইয়া আইল করিতে শাসন॥
প্রথমে সংবাদ দিতে পাঠাইলা দূত।
আজ্ঞামাত্র চলিলেক মলয়া মারুত॥
বায়ু মুখে শুনি বসন্তের আগমন।
সুসজ্জা করিল যত পুষ্প সেনাগণ॥
কেতকী করাত করে করিয়া ধারণ।
দম্ভে দাঁড়াইল হইয়া প্রফুল্ল বদন॥

The rose and the jessamine, two gallant warriors, approached in full bloom to join the fine army. The *gandharaja* wore white apparel and the *java* with red spikes stood ready. The *palaca* held a bow and the *rangana* looked like the arrow of that bow. The lotus floating in the pond looked like the shield of Cupid. When this gay army had made itself ready to receive the prince, the god of love led them as their general. He aimed his five arrows at those who lived in separation from the beloved. He ordered the cuckoo and the zephyr to spy on all who were slow in giving response to this call of love. The royal command was communicated to all. The prince wanted tribute. The cuckoo was ordered to kill the defaulters by his sweet strain. The birds seated on the bough of a tree with their melodious cooings intimated the royal command.''

শূল হস্তে করি শীঘ্র সাজিল চম্পক।
অর্দ্ধচন্দ্র বাণ ধরি ধাইলেক বক॥
গোলাব সেউতি পুষ্প সেনার প্রধান।
প্রফুটিত হইয়া দোঁহে হইল আগুয়ান॥
গন্ধরাজ ধাইলেক পরি শ্বেত বস্ত্র।
ওড় জবা ধাইলেক ধরি তীক্ষ্ণ অস্ত্র॥
মল্লিকা মালতী জাতী কামিনী বকুল।
কুন্দ আদি সাজে তারা যুদ্ধেতে অতুল॥
পলাশ ধনুক হস্তে করিয়া দাঁড়ায়।
রঙ্গন তাহার বাণ হেন অভিপ্রায়॥
সরোরুহ ঢাল হয়ে ভাসিল জীবনে।
এইরূপে সজ্জা কৈল পুষ্প সেনাগণে॥

This idea is followed up till one has almost reached the bottomless pit of indecent realism.

Giridhara's translation of the Gita-Govinda.

That stamp of ornateness for which this age in literature is famous is very marked in the translation of the Gita Govinda by Giridhara who finished the poem in 1736 A. D.,—sixteen years before Bhārat Chandra had completed his Annadāmaṅgala. It is his finished Sanskritic style that marks his affinity with the poets of the school of Bhārata Chandra. This translation threw into the shade the earlier attempt by Rasamaya Dās who had translated the Gita Govinda in the metre called *payar chanda*, so commonly adopted by the early Bengali poets. Giridhara's poem reproduces in Bengali as far as

মলয়ার মুখে শুনি রাজ আগমন।
অগ্রগণ্য সেনাপতি সাজিল মদন॥
শরাসনে সন্ধান করিয়া পঞ্চশর।
বিরহী নাশিতে বীর চলিল সত্বর॥
কোকিল ভ্রমরে ডাকি কহিল মদন।
দেখ রাজ্যে বিরহিণী আছে কোন জন॥
প্রতি ঘরে ঘরে গিয়া দেহ সমাচার।
শীঘ্রগতি কর দিতে বসন্ত রাজার॥
বিশেষ রাজার আজ্ঞা কর অবধান।
যে না দেয় কর, তার বধহ পরাণ॥
আজ্ঞা পেয়ে দুই সেনা করিল গমন।
রমণী মণ্ডলে আসি দিল দরশন॥
প্রথমে কোকিল গিয়া বসি বৃক্ষপরে।
রাজ আজ্ঞা জানাইল নিজ কুহুস্বরে॥

Kamini Kumāra by Kāli Krishna Dās.

possible the spirit of the original in all the gay metres which we find in the Sanskrit poem, nay, he imports with an easy grace the very words of Sanskrit which admirably suit his classical Bengali. I give two passages in the foot-note which retain wonderfully the music and sweep of the stanzas of the great lyrical master of Sanskrit.*

* (1) "এ সখি সুন্দরী যুবতী জনে হরি, নাচত কত প্রকার।
পবনে লবঙ্গলতা, মৃদু বিচলিত, শীতল গন্ধ বহায়,
কুহু কুহু করি, কোকিলকুল কুজিত, কুঞ্জে ভ্রমরীগণ গায়॥
বকুল ফুলে, মধু পিয়ে মধুকরগণ, তাহে লম্বিত তরু ডাল।
পতি দূরে যার, তার প্রতি মনোরথ, মননথনে হয় কাল॥
মৃগমদ গন্ধে, তমাল পল্লব, ব্যাপিত হইল সুবাস।
যুবজন-হৃদয় বিদারিতে, কামের নখ কিবা হইল পলাশ॥
মদন নৃপের ছত্র হেম নির্ম্মিত কি নাগেশ্বর ফুল।
শিলিমুখ সদৃশ বাণ নিরমাওল, পাটলী ফুল অতুল॥
দেখি বিলক্ষণ, জগত ফুল ছল, তরুণ করুণ কিয়ে হাসে।
কেতকী কর সদৃশ করি নিরমিল, বিরহী বিদারণ আশে॥
(2) যমুনাতীরে, মন্দ বহে মারুত, তাহাতে বসিয়া যুবরাজ।
কর অভিসার, করি রতিরস, মদন মনোহর বেশে।
গমনে বিলম্বন, না কর নিতম্বিনী চল চল প্রাণনাথ পাশে॥
তুয়া নিজ নাম, শ্যাম করি সঙ্কেত, বাজায় মুরলী মৃদুভাষে।
তুয়া তনু পরশি, ধূলিরেণু উড়ত, তাহে পুনঃ পুনঃ প্রশংসে॥
উড়াইতে পক্ষী, বৃক্ষদল বিচলিতে, তুয়া আগমন হেন মানে।
দ্রুতগতি শেষ করতঃ, পুনঃ চমকই, নিরখত তুয়া পথ পানে॥
শবদ অধীর, নূপুর কর দূরে, রিপুর সদৃশ রতিরঙ্গে।
অতিতমপুঞ্জ, কুঞ্জবনে সখী চল, নীল ওড়ানি নেহ অঙ্গে॥"

III. Poetry of rural Bengal.

The villages of Bengal.

Let us pass from the city to the village. The villages of Bengal, half a century ago, were the abodes of peace, of love and of devotion. The vices of the towns stamped the literature of the courts degrading it to wicked sensualism: the vain pedantry of scholars introduced into it erudite absurdities of far-fetched imagery; non-Hindu ideas found favour with the citizens, directly under the influence of an alien civilisation. But the quiet Hindu was not in his element in the city. His true home lay in the village; there, under the canopy of the blue sky, on which the gay seasons of our tropical clime present in succession their ever-shifting array of scenes, the Hindu had found leisure for centuries to ponder over the deeper problems of life: undisturbed he devoted himself to interpreting the texts of the çāstras like some Epicurean god sitting over his nectar—careless of mankind. Political squabbles rent the life of cities; kings were dethroned, and new flags were unfurled in ancient capitals; but a change of government did not affect the conditions of life of a Hindu village.

Long distance separates these villages of Bengal from the seething life of political centres. These homes of the people are counted sacred by reason of the noble rivers on whose banks they stand,—the rushing Ganges, the ever-white Dhaleçwari, the foaming Padmā, the furious Dāmodara, the great Brahmaputra, the dark-watered Meghna, and many others that branch themselves into a

hundred streams to flow to the sea, keeping up a never ceasing music by their murmurs. How do these villages adorn themselves with gardens, through whose green foliage peep the scarlet *java*, the white *kunda*, and the crescent-shaped yellow *atasi*,—gardens where the sacred *bel* and *nimba* trees rustle in the breeze the long summer day! There from thick groves of mango and jack, starts suddenly spire-like to view, the tall Bengali *devadaru* rising above the majestic *asvattha*—far beyond the tiara-shaped domes of temples. Here, under the sacred *tulasi* plant, the lamp is lighted at even-fall and the brow marked with vermilion bows down to leave its scarlet traces at the root. Here the sound of the evening conch summons the villagers to the temple; while on the edge of the meadow the cows stand quietly waiting the call of the shepherds to lead them to the shed; and the *madhavi* creepers, rich with the treasure of the spring, diffuse their fragrance as the weary pilgrim approaches his earthly paradise, his straw-roofed mud-hovel. From these same simple Bengali homes sprang the Navya Nyāya —the logical system of modern Bengal—which some of us hold to be the greatest achievement of the pure intellect in modern times. In these villages the poems of Vālmiki and Vyāsa, of Kalidās and Bhababhuti have, for hundreds of years, cast the spell of their beauty upon the people. In them the lofty principles of Vedanta philosophy have been taught by Brahmins who realised that man was one with the universe,—a flute through which might sound the whole music of god's kingdom,—and that his greatest good lay in returning to the consciousness of his oneness with the Supreme Principle. These

Bengali villages are hallowed above all by the wonderful sacrifices of the *satis*, and their heroic death on the funeral pyres of their husbands, when, with a gentle wave of the hand from the midst of flames, they would often indicate a wish to hear the name of god recited at the last moment. Here in Bengal the renunciation of Buddha has been practised by princes from age to age, by Dīpañkara *Sri Jnana* of Eastern Bengal—by Gopi Chānd of the Pāl dynasty, by Narottama of Kheturi, by Raghunātha Dās of Sātgaon, and in our modern times by the saintly Lālā Babu of Pāikpārā, all of whom left their worldly glory, and went forth, beggar's bowl in hand, caring for naught but the highest truth vouchsafed to man. Here the dynasty of the ancient *risies* and seers of the Vedanta Philosophy remains unbroken to the present day in the person of Ram Krisña Paramhañsa, who exemplified self forgetful divine love in the eyes of men now living. These villages of Bengal should not be taken for the homes of men like Mirzāfar, Umichānd and Nanda Kumāra,—political intriguers, trained in courts to heinous vices revolting to the nature of a rural people. Fifty years ago the one great fear of Hindu parents in Bengal was lest their sons should take the vow of the Sannyasin. They would not allow them even to sit on a *kusasana*,—a seat which was generally used by Sadhus. Since the time of Buddha, renunciation in the cause of the highest truth has been no idle dream, no will-o'-the-wisp theory, amongst Hindus. It is a goal towards which the whole Indian civilisation has continued to move, even as Western civilisation moves towards patriotism, and against political serfdom.

Renunciation, the goal of Hindu-life.

The homes of Bengal have even been seed-beds of high thought. The control of the passions, the mastery over self, the training of the mind to concentration and yoga—till it can reach the state of final beatitude—are aims which have engrossed the energy of our people; and Hindus have never been afraid of privation, pain or sacrifice to reach this goal. They have sought a revelation of god within the soul,—the highest aim that can attract a mortal. A certain mystery enshrouds those who scale the greatest heights; but the Yoga Philosophy is a system which enables a man to arrive at a definite realisation, and those who would cry it down must first study the vast literature which has gathered round the subject, and understand what is really meant.

The Songs.

The home life of Bengal has been best expressed in its songs. In these, one may find out all he wants to know about the Bengali people. They are as thoroughly Indian as the *kunda* flowers of the soil; and many of them spring from sincere souls as tributes to god, even as *kunda* flowers are offered by Brahmin to Viṣṇu. From the highest truths of Yoga down to the pettiest concerns of daily life, every point that touches our aims, our ideas and our manner of life is embodied in these songs. Many of them have been composed by saints like Rāma Prasāda and Fikir Chānd, which no one who is not an adept in Yoga, can well understand. Those on Dehatattva, or the spiritual principles governing the human body, are too abstract for laymen. Their language is not difficult, but they offer points of perplexity because they illustrate an experience of which we know too little.

Grouped in four classes.

Bengali songs may be grouped in main four classes :— I. The *kirtana* songs to which we have already aluded. II. The songs of the *kaviwallas*, III. Religious songs, IV. The songs of the *yatras* or the popular drama.

(a)—Kaviwallas and their Songs.

Let us begin with the second of these groups, *viz.*, the songs of the *kaviwallas*. The *kaviwallas* were parties of minstrels who sang songs mainly descriptive of incidents in the life of Kriṣṇa. Their party consisted of men and women who stood and sang in chorus. They were for this reason called Dāñḍa-kavis or the standing minstrels. Their leader generally composed songs relating to the love of Rādhā and Kriṣṇa or to domestic scenes in Kailās—the abode of Çiva and his consort Umā. Latterly a good deal of competition arose amongst different *kaviwallas*. Çambhu Chandra, a son of Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra of Navadwipa, about the time of the battle of Plassey, began to organise professional bands of *kaviwallas*, and a new element was introduced into their songs. The chief singer of one party, as a sequel to his own songs, would begin to compose extempore verses attacking the leader of the opposite party who would next occupy the stage. The latter would not be slow to make a retort at the end of his songs, and the seething satire and gross vulgarity which came to characterise these fights of the *kaviwallas* evoked a most animated interest from city audience. But this corrupting influence was, comparatively speaking, absent from the performances of village *kaviwallas*.

Dāñḍa Kavis.

Attacks on rival parties.

The origin of the kavi songs.

The *kavi* songs had originally constituted parts of old *yatras* or popular plays. The simple episodes in the *yatras*, especially those of the nature of light opera, were in course of time wrought into a separate class of songs, which were sung by these distinct bodies of professional bards called *kaviwalas*, whose domain was thus completely severed from that of the *yatra* parties. The *kaviwalas* used the musical instrument called the *madala* to mark time in their songs. The notes of the *madala* were lighter than those of the grave *khol* which was used by *yatras* and *kirtana*-parties.

Raghu, the cobbler.

The earliest *kaviwala* about whom information has been obtained was Raghu, a cobbler who flourished in the 17th century. The low caste of this singer shows that the institution was based upon the amusement of the rustics. Gradually the higher classes came to take an interest in it. But the chief audiences of the *kaviwalas* have always consisted mainly of illiterate rural people. Alas, these songs are heard no more in Bengal! The death-knell of this institution, once so popular, was sounded by the new Bengali drama influenced by European models; and though the *yatras* still exist, they are only like ghosts of their former selves. We miss the national tone in them. Our *Yatrawalas* now mimic the modern theatres. They can not afford the costs of making a stage or purchasing scenery, hence they generally hold their performances in temporary sheds, raised for the occasion, or oftentimes under the open sky. They have abandoned the ground that once belonged to them, and from which they once wielded so great a moral

The degeneracy of the old yātrā.

and spiritual force, and any one who can recollect the old *yatras* and has the misfortune to attend their modern carricatures, is involuntarily reminded of Hamlet's famous line, "Look here upon this picture, and on that!"

The bashful Hindu wife.

The songs of the *kaviwalas* in former times gave pictures of the domestic life of Bengal with all its gentle lights and shadows. The coy Bengali wife unable to speak out those sentiments of love with which her heart is filled, is beautifully portrayed in them. I quote below a song by Rāma Vasu, a *kaviwala*, who once enjoyed great popularity in the country. The song opens the door to a chamber into which outsiders have no access;—where the coy wife whispers her tale of grief to her maid and *confidante*. It is no free speech of love; we may well imagine the stops, the sighs and tears with which she delivers her tale, in a voice scarcely audible. Unfortunately it is impossible to convey the wailing cadence of the tune of the song. The bashful woman is longing for a sight of her husband, yet she could not speak out at the moment of farewell. Here is a picture of the Hindu wife that we miss in those poems and novels of modern Bengal which have been influenced by English literature.

Rāma Vasu.

* "I could not tell him what I felt. My heart was filled with sorrow. But it was hidden so deep! I tried to speak, when he said good-bye, but shyness

* "মনে রহিল সই মনের বেদনা।
প্রবাসে যখন যায় গো সে, তারে বলি বলি আর বলা হ'ল না।
সরমে মরমের কথা কওয়া গেল না॥

overwhelmed me and I said nothing. You see I am a woman, so how could I beg him not to leave me? Oh! why was I made a woman? May I not be so again!

"In the dawn of my youth and in the bloom of the spring he has left me! When he smiled and said 'I am going' I wept to see him smile,—smile at the hour of parting! My heart yearned after him; I felt a longing to clasp him and detain him, but shyness came upon me, and seemed to say—'But how can you touch?' I saw his face beaming with smiles. I covered my own to hide my flowing tears. How cruel he was—he seemed to feel no pain at saying farewell! Oh! he has left me, left me without a sigh."

A high spiritual tone.

Often a high spiritual tone pervades the *kavi* songs. The love of Rādhā and Kriṣṇa is the theme which has for ages inspired the Bengali imagination with the highest emotions. Rāsu

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যদি নারী হয়ে সাধিতাম তাকে।
নির্লজ্জ রমণী বলে হাসিত লোকে॥
সখি ধিক্ থাক্ আমারে, ধিক্ সে বিধাতারে,
নারী জনম যেন আর করে না॥
একে আমার যৌবন কাল, তাহে কাল বসন্ত এল,
এ সময়ে প্রাণনাথ প্রবাসে গেল॥
যখন হাসি হাসি সে 'আসি' বলে।
সে হাসি দেখে ভাসি নয়ন জলে॥
তারে পারি কি ছেড়ে দিতে, মন চায় ধরিতে,
লজ্জা বলে ছি ছি ছুঁয়ো না।
তার মুখ দেখে, মুখ ঢেকে কাঁদিলাম সজনী,
অনায়াসে প্রবাসে গেল সে গুণমণি॥"

Rāsu Narasiṇha.

Narasiṇha who lived in the middle of the 16th century sang the following and similar other songs. They indicate the high spiritual plane from which the poet gave an interpretation of love.

* "Speak to me, O my friend, of love. I am sick at heart and weary of the world. I yearn for love. O speak of love divine which heals a weary heart and opens the eyes to truth. Where may it be had? O tell me this! I yearn to visit its sacred shrine.

"I have heard from those who know, that you are an adept in the secrets of this love. Be thou sincere and soothe my wounded heart by telling me of it. Weary of life, I have come to you for this.

"Where is the fountain of that great love, for which Prahlāda, the son of Hiranyakaçipu, left the world, and courted hardships in the forest—for which the god Çiva spends day and night in Yoga in holy contemplation? Where is the fountain of that love which made Prince Bhagīratha bring down the stream of the Ganges from the celestial regions for the good of the world? What is that

* "কহ সখি কিছু প্রেমেরই কথা, ঘুচাও আমার মনের ব্যথা।
করিলে শ্রবণ, হয় দিব্যজ্ঞান, হেন প্রেমধন উপজে কোথা॥
আমি এসেছি বিরাগে, মনেরি রাগে, পিরীতি প্রয়াগে মুড়াব মাথা।
আমি রসিকের স্থানে, গেয়েছি সন্ধানে, তুমি নাকি জান প্রেম-বারতা॥
কাপট্য ত্যজিয়া, কহ বিবরিয়া, ইহার লাগিয়া এসেছি হেথা।
হায়, কোন প্রেম লাগি, প্রহ্লাদ বৈরাগী, মহাদেব যোগী কেমন প্রেমে।
কি প্রেম কারণে, ভগীরথ জনে, ভাগীরথী আনে ভারতভূমে॥

love which created the heart-rending woe of the maids of the Vrindā groves when Kriṣṇa left them for Mathurā, and by dint of which the *Madhavi* creepers on the banks of the Jumna had the good fortune to touch his lotus feet?"

Here is another song by Rāsu Narasiṇha which sounds very like a sermon.

* "This earthly love, O maids, is no love. Of her who yields to earthly love, suffering is the destiny.

"Forsaken by friends, slandered by the world, she is subjected to shame. Would you love, O maidens? Love so that both here in this world and in the next you may have nothing but happiness! Love Kriṣṇa the healer of all sore hearts. Why drink ye poison leaving nectar! Why expose yourselves to slander, which is worse than death?

"In the temple of your heart place him from whom flows the fountain of all happiness. Close your eyes and call him dearest and offer your soul unto his feet. Then partings cannot come to cause you woe, nor the slanderous tongue pursue you.

কোন প্রেমে হরি, ব'ধে ব্রজনারী, গেল মধুপুরী করে অনাথা।
কোন প্রেম-ফলে, কালিন্দীর কুলে, কৃষ্ণপদ পেলে
মাধবীলতা॥"

* "সখি এসকল প্রেম প্রেম নয়।
ইহাতে মজিয়ে নাহি সুখের উদয়॥
সুহৃদ ভঞ্জন, লোক গঞ্জন, কলঙ্কভাজন হতে হয়।
এমন পিরিতি করি, যাতে তরি, দুদিকে, ঐহিকে আর পারত্রিকে
শ্রীনন্দ নন্দন, দুঃখ ভঞ্জন, সদা রাখি মন তার পায়॥
অমিয় ত্যজে, গরলে মজে, উপজে কি সুখ।
কলঙ্ক ঘোষণ, জগতে মরণ হ'তে অধিক॥

"Let your mind be the bird *chakora*, and cry for a drop of mercy, even as the bird cries for a drop of water from the clouds. From the divine feet bearing the marks of ধ্বজ (the flag), বজ্র (the thunder), and অঙ্কুশ (the hook) flowed the Ganges, and what is that but the stream of His mercy? Bathe yourself in this, the sacred stream of divine mercy. You will be immortalised in love.

"Take refuge in the feet from which springs all light; they will dispel the darkness of the mind; that light will cause your heart to bloom, even as the sun's rays opens up the lotus. Be deep-drunk like the bee with the honey of his love.

"The creator has placed nectar and poison in the same cup, and given you eyes to discriminate between the two. Why should ye prefer poison to nectar like a blind man? He who acts like a blind man though he has eyes, misuses and loses carelessly the precious gift of love".

হৃদয় মন্দির মাঝে, রসরাজে, বসায়ে দেখিব আঁখি মুদিয়ে।
বিকায়ে সে পদে, বাধি হৃদে, কলঙ্ক বিচ্ছেদে নাহি ভয়ে॥
মনেরে করে চাতক পাখী রাখ্‌ব বিশেষে।
জলং দেহি জলং দেহি ডাকৃব প্রেমের প্রয়াসে॥
ধ্বজ বজ্রাঙ্কুশ যত পদ হইতে, জাহ্নবী হলেন যাহাতে।
সে কৃপাজলে মন ডুবায়ে, করিব কালেরে পরাজয়॥
কমলজজন, সেবিতধন, অরুণচরণে।
মনের তিমির বিনাশ পায় সে কিরণে॥
হৃদে আছে শতদল, সে কমল ফুটিবে, প্রেম পিযুষ ঘটিবে।
মন মধুব্রত হয়ে যেন, রত সেই নামামৃত সুধা খায়।
অমিয় আর গরল দুই রাখিয়ে সাক্ষাতে।
নয়ন দিছেন বিধাতা দেখিয়ে ভক্ষিতে॥
ত্যজিয়ে এ সুধারস, কেন বিষ ভক্ষিবে, কলুষকূপে ডুবিবে।
থাকিতে নয়ন অন্ধ যে জন, পেয়ে প্রেমধন সে হারায়॥

In the songs of Menokā and Yaçodā we find true portraits of the tenderness of Bengali mothers. In those days there was scarcely a Bengali mother who did not pass sleepless nights of longing for some girl-child of eight, sent to a stranger-family to play the housewife under a veil. These little wives were not allowed to move about or talk except in whispers to others of her own age! We all know the silent agonies of the mother's soul for her little widowed daughter living on a single meal a day, and observing fasts and vigils! This throbbing motherhood with its anxious eyes and fervent faith is called up to the mind's eyes as we hear these old songs of the village bards. We find in them the deep spirituality which has always made Bengali women bear the ills of life in a contented spirit; we see, besides, their devotion to their husbands, and notice their skill in the culinary art and their hospitality in these songs. Above all we have a glimpse of their deep piety proving them to be the true daughters of those who showed such marvellous fortitude and faith as *satis* on the funeral pyres of their husbands. These songs represent the feelings of the village people of Bengal, full of tender domestic instincts, who have lived plain lives, but have aspired to scale the loftiest heights in religion.

The motherhood.

We give a list of *kaviwalas* below:—

A list of kaviwalās.

1. Raghu the cobbler was a resident of Sālkiā—a village on the western bank of the Ganges facing Calcutta. He lived in the middle of the 16th century.

* 2. Rāsu Narasiṅha, resident of Gondalpārā, near Chandernagara.
3. Gozlā Gui.
4. Lālu Nandalāla.
5. Haru Thākura (Hare Kriṣṅa Dirghāngi) born in 1738 at Simlā in Calcutta. One of his songs runs thus :—

Songs by Haru Thākur.

† "The dark night is still. Its silence is broken from time to time by thunderous clouds. The bird *chatak* and the peacock are happy to hear the sound. Tell me, O my maids, where is my Kriṣṅa now ? The fragrance of the *kadamva*, the *ketaki*, the *jati*, the *champaka* and the *seuti* flowers fills the air. They remind me of Kriṣṅa, who is not with me. The fire-flies dance and the lightning flashes, and the scene is suddenly lit up as if by day-light. The bird *sadi* sits quietly with her mate and they touch each other with their bills in love. Where is my Kriṣṅa, O my maids, at this hour ?"

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* The three bards whose names are bracketted were contemporaries of Raghu.

† "সুধীর ধীরে বহিছে এই ঘোরতরা রজনী ॥
এ সময়ে প্রাণ সখীরে, কোথায় গুণমণি ; ঘন গরজে ঘন শুনি ॥
ঐ ময়ূর ময়ূরী হরষিত, হেরি চাতক চাতকিনী ॥
ঐ কদম্ব কেতকী চম্পক জাতি সেউতি সেফালিকে ।
প্রাণেতে প্রাণেতে মোহ জন্মায় প্রাণনাথে গৃহে না দেখে ॥
বিদ্যুত খদ্যোত দিবা জ্যোতির্ময় প্রকাশে দিনমণি ।
প্রিয়মুখে মুখ দিয়ে সারীশুক থাকে দিবস রজনী ॥"

In another song he says:—

* "Do not be slow to recite the name of Kriṣṇa, come what may. Would you give up hope, my soul, because suffering has been your lot in this world? Would you sink your boat in the water because there are waves in it?"

Haru Thākur died in 1813. Though he used to compose songs for professional parties, he himself was an amateur, and cared not to earn money by the profession of a *kaviwala*. At one time Rājā Nava Kissen of Grey Street, Calcutta, was so pleased with his songs that he offered a valuable shawl as a present to him, but he indignantly made a gift of it to a low caste drummer of the party.

Rāma Vasu and others.

6. Rāma Vasu, born at Sālkiā in 1786, died in 1828. We have already quoted one of his songs on page 698, describing the pathos of love and especially scenes of parting.
7. Nityānanda Vairāgi, resident of Chandernagar, born in 1751 and died in 1821.
8. Nīlu.
9. Rāma Prasāda.
10. Udaya Dās.
11. Parāṅa Dās.
12. Bhavānī Veniā.
13. Mohana Sarkār.
14. Thākura Siṅha.

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*"হরি নাম লইতে অলস হইও না, রসনা, যা' হবার তা' হবে।
ঐহিকেরই সুখ হল না বলে, কি ঢেউ দেখি তরী ডুবাবে॥"

15. Nīlu Hari Pātni.
16. Kāçī Nātha Pātni.
17. Bholā Mairā.
18. Chintā Mairā.
19. Valarāma Kāpālī.
20. Govinda Ārajavegi.
21. Kriṣṇa Muchi.
22. Uddhava Dās.
23. Parāṇa Siṇha.
24. Rāmrupa Thākur of Dacca.
25. Jajnecwari, a woman.
26. Gorakṣa Nātha.
27. Goura Kavirāja.
28. Sātu Rāy.
29. Gadādhara Mukerjee.
30. Jaynārāyaṇa Mukerjee.
31. Thākura Dās Chakravarty.
32. Navāi Thākur.
33. Kāci Chandra Guha.

Not influenced by English ideas.

The names included in this list from No. 15 onward refer to contemporary *kaviwalas* or to those who were nearly contemporary to one another. They flourished in the earlier half of the 19th century. It should be said here, that though many of the *kaviwalas* lived when English rule had been established in India, their school was not at all influenced by English ideas.

The Portuguese Kaviwalā Mr. Antony.

We have not named in this list one *kaviwala* who enjoyed great popularity in Calcutta and its

suburbs early in the 19th century. This was Mr. Antony of Chandernagar. He and his brother Mr. Kelly were of Portuguese parentage, and had settled in Bengal. They had accumulated immense wealth by successful trade in India. Mr. Antony, when a young man, fell in love with a remarkably handsome Brāhmin widow of Chandernagar. He did not marry her, but the pair lived as husband and wife in his garden house at Gereti near Chandernagar, where the remains of his house may still be seen. Antony did not interfere with the religious views of the Brāhmin woman, nay, he encouraged them as best as he could ; for in his house at Gereti, the religious festivals of the Hindus were performed by her with great *eclat*, and he heartily joined the festal ceremonies. The temple of Kāli known as Firingī Kāli, at 243, Bowbāzār Street, Calcutta, was erected by him at her desire.

Antony acquired Bengali so well that he gained a perfect mastery over its colloquial forms. During the religious festivals of Hindus, his house became a resort of the *kaviwalas* who showed their enthusiasm in reviling their rivals in extempore verses. Antony took so great an interest in these free competitions of the *kaviwalas*, that he himself founded a party of his own, and employed a bard named Gorakṣanātha to compose extempore verses of satire to be levelled against others. He however soon found that he was himself more than a match for many a *kaviwala*, dismissed Gorakṣa nātha, and himself appeared on the stage singing Bengali songs ; and as a sequel to them he attacked the rival parties in doggerels composed extempore by himself,—vilifying, slandering and abusing them

to the height of his power. It was a curious sight to see a European leave his trousers, coat and hat, dress himself like a Bengali with a *chadar* hanging down from his shoulders, and the *kocha* of his *dhooti* neatly flowing in strict Bengali fashion, and singing songs in praise of the goddess Kāli as follows :—

* "I am a Portuguese and don't know how to worship thee. Oh Kāli, be merciful to me."

This he did for the sake of amusement ; for he remained a christian all his life, though by living with his Hindu consort and in the atmosphere of Hindu ideas, he had acquired the liberal views of the Hindus on matters of religion and was quite devoid of crude bigotry. Mr. Antony's party soon acquired the fame of being invincible in their extempore satirical verses. Thākura Sing, the leader of another party of *kaviwalas*, made a charge at him in the following couplet.

† "Tell me, O Antony, for I want to know, why you have, coming to this land of ours, turned a vagabond without a coat ?"

Mr. Antony was in the midst of audience consisting of common folk who would not appreciate any shrewd humour or clever stroke of wit. He was not only required to be coarse in his abuse, but to couch them in Bengali idioms of these rustic folk, and it must be admitted that he was

* "ভজন সাধন জানিনে মা, নিজেত ফিরিঙ্গি।
যদি দয়া করে কৃপা কর হে শিবে মাতঙ্গী॥

† "শুনহে এণ্টনি, আমি একটী কথা জান্‌তে চাই।
এসে এদেশে, এবেশে, তোমার গায়ে কেন কুর্ত্তি নাই"

fully equal to the task. Here is the extempore doggerel with which he made his retort. There is no greater abusive word in Bengali than that of 'Çāla' (wife's brother, and Antony accosted his rival as such, although not in so many words.

*"I am happy in Bengal in the costumes of the natives, and from having been elected as son-in-law to the father of Thākura Siṇha, I have lost my taste for hat and coat."

The town and city—a contrast.

Such abuse, as I have said, stains that portion of the *kavi*-literature which had found favour in cities and large towns. In the cool recesses of the villages, the rustic folk assembled to hear tales of sacrifice, resignation, sufferings for love, and of tender domestic scenes sung by their unassuming bards. Nor do I know if anywhere else than in India the lowest stratum of society, which the *kaviwalas* mainly represented, could show so much spirituality, love, and tender pathos in their literature, chiefly contributed as this was by illiterate men of the lowest classes. The gentler classes, the dilettantes belonging to the aristocracy, favoured the *kaviwalas* in later times only to stamp this folk-lore with their depraved taste; but away from the town, the villages preserved unspoiled, the well of Hindu thought—undefiled, and fit to satisfy the spiritual thirst of those who were humble in spirit, kindly in disposition and who approached God as the Hindu wife approaches her husband,—in deep reverence and love.

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*"এই বাঙ্গলায় বাঙ্গালীর বেশে আনন্দে আছি।
হ'য়ে ঠাকুরে সিংএর বাপের জামাই, কুর্ত্তিটুপি ছেড়েছি॥

(b) Religious Songs.

Twenty-five years ago, in the twilight on the river Khoyai in Sylhet. I saw a boatman rowing a small boat, and as he rowed he sang :

The boatman's song

* "Take back thine oar, O boatman, I can no longer ply it ; all my life I have struggled to bear my boat upstream, but backwards it has gone inspite of me, and now in my old age I find my efforts gone for naught. The prow of the boat is broken, and the planks are falling away. It can no longer be kept from sinking."

This means that he had fought with his passions all his life trying to control them, and bring the mind under discipline ; but he could not. And now when life's ebb-tide was setting in, the despairing boatman could only call upon the Lord to take the charge of the boat of his life for him, conscious as he was of his own incapacity to control it, at the last moment.

This song, which I heard at Habiganj in Sylhet, may be heard sung by the rustic folk at Mymensing and Dacca and even here in Calcutta.

Spirituality in rustic life.

This clear idea of self-control as the supreme good, is not confined in the country to the literate and higher classes. Through long years of the spread of Buddhism and the Vedanta Philosophy, it has filtered down to the lowest stratum of society, and illiterate villagers realise the deepest meaning of this spiritual truth, no less than men of rank and learning.

*"মন মাঝি তোর বৈঠা নেরে, আমি আর বাইতে পারি না।
জনম ভরে বাইলাম তরী রে, তরী ভাইটায় সোয়ায় উজায় না॥
নায়ের গুড়া ভাঙ্গা, ছাপ্পর লড়া রে, আমি আর বাইতে পারি না॥"

There are hundreds of songs describing the transitoriness of life and the vanity of human wishes; and there is hardly a rustic in a Bengal-village who does not sing to himself some favourite tune having for its burden the mutability of fortune, as, after his weary day of labour, he lays down his tools to retire to rest. Here is another song of the same class: —

*"Tell me who are you, carried on a bamboo bier to the funeral ground? Some of your fellows bear you on their shoulders, and while others follow with faggots for the pyre. Your little child is calling for his father. Why so unkind that you have no word for him to-day. Did you not, with the sweat of your brow, earn gold mohurs and rupees, wandering from Delhi to Lahore and thence to Dacca, for the purpose? You strove to heap up wealth. You would not spend for your own comfort a four anna-bit or even a pice. Tell me, brother, how much of this hard-earned money are you carrying with you now?"

These wailing songs are sung by the villagers in chorus. The melody is high-pitched, and the air resounds on all sides with the chant.

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*"বাঁসের দোলাতে উঠে, কেহে বটে, শ্মশান ঘাটে যাচ্ছ চলে,
সঙ্গে সব কাঠের ভরা, লাটবহরা, জাতবেহারার কাঁধে চড়ে
.....ছেলে কাঁদে বাবা বলে
ও তুমি কওনা কথা, নাইক ব্যথা, কিসের জন্য এমন হলে?
ঘুরে যে দিল্লি লাহোর, ঢাকার সহর, টাকা মোহর এনেছিলে,
খেলে না পয়সা সিকি, কওনা দেখি, তার কি কিছু সঙ্গে নিলে"

A popular song by Kāngāl Harināth.

If life is a truth, death is no less so. If one realises this, and turns his back upon the sweets of life, saying that they are not worth caring for, since they are so transitory and because they are held in the same cup with poison, what can a materialistic civilisation offer to such a soul?

The mind turns naturally from the horror of death to God. The soul, that has the power to revel in the permanent delights of god-realisation, becomes the all engrossing matter of attention. Though confined in its temporary shed, it may free itself from its "fleshy vesture of decay" and by the process of Yoga reach a state of permanent bliss. This is realised by the Indian aspirant of a spiritual life, and all the religious songs of Bengal have this burden.

(c) Rāma Prasāda Sen and poets of his school.

Life of Rāma Prasāda Sen.

Amongst those who have composed religious songs, there is no higher name than that of Rāma Prasāda Sen. Born in the quiet village of Kumārahatta, near a station on the East Bengal Railway, in 1718, he was at first influenced by the depraved taste of the court of Rājā Krishṇa Chandra of Navadwipa. It may have been owing to satisfy the Rājā or his own youthful poetic vanity, that he wrote the indecent poem of Vidyā Sundara which was very soon after its composition, outdone by the more brilliant Vidyā Sundara by Bhārata Chandra. Soon after this Rāma Prasāda retired to his native village, where the Panchamundi or seat on which he sat day and night to practise Yoga, is still to be seen.

Rāma Prasāda was the son of Rāma Rāma Sen, a Vaidya by caste. By the machinations of his

relations, the father had been deprived of his inheritance, and the poet passed his early life in poverty. While yet in his teens he was admitted as an apprentice in the revenue office of a Zemindar and was entrusted with the work of keeping the accounts. One day his master was taken by surprise to find some remarkably beautiful songs scribbled over the pages of the account-book, evidently in the hand-writing of the young apprentice. When he came to know that Rāma Prasāda was their author, he was so highly pleased with the poetic talents of the young man, that he conferred a pension of Rs. 30 on him, and allowed him to retire to his village and devote himself to the composition of songs. Rāma Prasāda also obtained a pension from Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra, besides a gift of 100 *bighas* of rent-free land in 1758. After his retirement his fame spread all over Bengal, and his songs composed in the soul-captivating *Ragini* called the *Malacri*, wrought a revolution in the spiritual world.

These songs came spontaneously from the soul. The motherhood of God is a definite realisation in them. Like a child, the poet prattles in them of his griefs and sorrows to the Divine Mother Kālī.

Kalī, the mother.

Rāmā Prasāda was a devout worshipper of Kālī, —Kālī with her fierce destructive look, with a complexion dark as the darkest cloud, and with four hands, one holding the decapitated head of a sinner, another a sword, the third offering benediction and the last assurance to those who would not swerve from virtue's path. When we call God all merciful, kind, and benign, there is one element which we try to white-wash to please our fancy. Surely the

Creator is also the Destroyer. In vain do we discourse sweetly on the tender aspects of the Deity; there is no playing fast and loose, no shilly-shallying with another feature of the Divinity, the awe-inspiring, the dark and the terrible, the fierceness of which confronts us at every step. The Çāktas have proclaimed the worship of Kālī to be only possible in a higher stage of spiritual development. A sweet and complete resignation of one's self to the Divine power knowing it to be terrible, makes the devotee, according to them, grapple better with the problems of life, from a spiritual point of view. Some Çākta-interpreters have explained the dark colour of Kālī as signifying the mystery that enshrouds the primary cause of the universe. The worshippers of Kālī hold her to be at once destructive and protective. Rāma Prāsada especially speaks of her as the mother who beats the child, while the child clings to her only the closer, crying "Mother! Oh Mother!" Here is his song:—

The Çākta interpreters.

"Though the mother beat him, the child cries 'Mother! Oh Mother!' and clings still tighter to her garment. True I cannot see thee, yet am I not a lost child. I still cry 'Mother! Mother!'"*

Through the fierce and the terrible he sees the sweet moonlight of grace that suddenly breaks forth, and Kālī is no more than a symbol to him,—a symbol of divine punishment, of divine grace, and of divine motherhood. She is as much a symbol as the word God. If the symbol of a word is admitted into the vocabulary, why object to the symbol of a figure in the temple? One appeals

The terrible, and the beautiful.

* See Kali the Mother, by Sister Nevedita p. 53.

to the ear, and the other to the eye. Rāma Prāsāda saw the fierce rolling clouds that darkened the whole horizon, and thought he saw in them the dark and flowing tresses of the Mother. The fire of the funeral ground, reducing a corpse to ashes, reminded him of the destructive dance of the Mother. The red glow of the evening sky, with its first stars, wore to his eyes the angry look of the divine Mother. The storm, the hurricane, the flood, death and disease—these are her companions. The cry of jackal is the chorus heard behind her. The funeral ground is her favourite place ; her dark skin, stained with blood, he compares to the black waters of the Jumna upon which floats the full blown lotus. In the agonies that rend the whole world he sees the chastising rod of the Mother, but says that he is not in the heart affrighted, for he has taken refuge in her grace. The image of Kālī works his imagination into lofty poetry, He sang :—

Punishment and grace.

*"See ! she does not bind her flowing tresses, nor does she wear any apparel. A sweet smile breaks out upon her lips !"

Sometimes he says, †" All the miseries that I have suffered and am suffering I know, Oh Mother, to be your mercy alone " for he knew that chastisement opens the blind man's eyes;—a cruel process, but sure in the end to lead to truth and bliss.

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* "ধনী না বাঁধে কবরী, না পরে বাস।
সে বিধুবদনে মধুর হাস॥"

† "বারে বারে যত দুঃখ দিয়েছ, দিতেছ, তারা।
সে কেবল দয়া তব জেনেছি মা দুঃখহরা॥"

A mere symbol.

Sitting at the feet of the image, he often knew it to be no more than a symbol, and he yearned for a revealation of his Mother in his soul. Here is one of his songs

*"O mind, why do you indulge in vain thoughts!

"This pompous worship and rituals are in vain,—they only increase the vanity of the soul.

"Pray to Her secretly, that no one may know of it.

"What is the use of making dolls out of metal, stone and earth?

"Don't you, know, O fool, that the whole universe is the image of the Mother?

"You have brought a handful of gram, O shameless one, as an offering to the Mother—to Her who feeds the whole world with delicious food!

"What use, O foolish mind, in making illuminations with lanterns, candle and lamps?

"Let the mind's light grow, and dispel its own darkness, day and night.

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* "মন তোর এত ভাবনা কেনে?
এক বার কালী বলে বস্‌রে ধ্যানে॥
লোকজমকে করে পূজা, অহঙ্কার হয় মনে।
তুই লুকিয়ে তাঁরে কর্‌বি পূজা, জান্‌বে নারে জগজ্জনে॥
ধাতু, পাষাণ, মাটীর মূর্ত্তি কাজ কিরে তোর সে গঠনে।
তুমি মনোময় প্রতিমা গড়ি, বসাও হৃদি পদ্মাসনে॥
আলোচাল আর পাকা কলা, কাজ কিরে তোর আয়োজনে।
তুমি ভক্তিসুধা খাইয়ে তাঁরে, তৃপ্তি কর আপন মনে॥
ঝাড়, লণ্ঠন, বাতি দিয়ে কাজ কিরে তোর আলো-দানে।
তুমি মনোময় মাণিক্য জ্বেলে, দাওনা জ্বলুক নিশি দিনে।

"You have brought innocent goats for sacrifice.

"Why not say, 'Victory to Kalī!' and sacrifice your passions, which are your real enemies?

"Why these sounds of the drum? Only keep your mind at Her feet and say,—

"Let thy will, O Kalī, be fulfilled, and saying so clap your hands."

In another song he says, "Making pilgrimage, visiting shrines is only a physical labour unto you."

But if Rāma Prasāda condemned empty rituals and the worship of images, it was only at a moment when the mere means were confounded with the end. In fact the image of Kālī was to him a perpetual fountain from which he drew the realisation of the sublime, the terrible and the beautiful in nature; and it inspired in him the most poetic songs that adorn the literature of the Çāktas of Bengal.

The image of Kalī inspires his songs.

The songs of Rāma Prasāda still reign supreme in our villages. In the pastoral meadows, amidst sweet scents of herbs and flowers, with the gentle murmurs of the river flowing by, or in the rice-fields where sounds of the cutting of grass or reaping of harvest lend a charm to the tranquil village-scene, one may often hear the Mālaçri songs of Rāma Prasāda, sung by rustics in the following strain. *"This brief day will pass, sure

The poet of the rural Bengal.

মেষ ছাগল মহিষাদি কাজ কিরে তোর বলিদানে।
তুমি 'জয় কালী' 'জয় কালী' বলে বলি দেও ষড়রিপুগণে॥
প্রসাদ বলে, ঢাক ঢোল কাজ কিরে তোর সে বাজনে।
তুমি 'জয় কালী' বলি দেও করতালি, মন রাখি তাঁর শ্রীচরণে॥

* "নিতান্ত যাবে এদিন, কেবল ঘোষণা রবে গো।
তারা নামে অসংখ্য কলঙ্ক রবে গো॥"

it is, oh Mother Kāli,—and all the world will find fault with you that you could not save a sinner like me"! *" My days are spent in vain pleasure: I have forgotten the only reality in life. When I earned money here and there, my wife, friends, brothers, and sons were all under my control; but now advanced in years, and unable to earn, they treat me unkindly because of my poverty. When death will come and pull me by the hair, they will prepare a bamboo bier for me, and dismiss me from the house with a poor earthern pitcher, stripped of clothing like an ascetic."

A European critic on Rāma Prasāda.

Sister Nivedita says of the works of Rāma Prasāda, " No flattery could touch a nature so unapproachable in its simplicity. For in these writings we have, perhaps alone in literature, the spectacle of a great poet, whose genius is spent in realising the emotions of a child. William Blake in our own poetry strikes the note that is nearest his, and Blake is by no means his peer. Robert Burns, in his splendid indifference to rank and Whitman in his glorification of common things, have points of kinship with him. But to such a radiant white heat of childlikeness, it would be

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*" গেল দিন বৃথা রঙ্গরসে, আমি কাজ হারালাম, কালের বশে
যখন ধন উপার্জ্জন, করেছিলাম দেশ বিদেশে,
তখন ভাই, বন্ধু, দারা, সুত, সবাই ছিল আপন বশে ॥
এখন ধন উপার্জ্জন, হল না আর দশার শেষে।
সেই ভাই, বন্ধু, দারা, সুত, নির্ধন বলে সবায় দোষে ॥
যম এসে শিয়রে বস, ধর্‌বে যখন অগ্রকেশে,
তখন সাজায়ে মাচা, কলসী কাঁচা, বিদায় দিবে দণ্ডীর বেশে ॥"

impossible to find a perfect counterpart. His years do nothing to spoil his quality. They only serve to give him self-confidence and poise. Like a child he is now grave, now gay, sometimes petulant, sometimes despairing. But in the child all this is purposeless. In Rāma Prasāda there is a deep intensity of purpose. Every sentence he has uttered is designed to sing the glory of his Mother."*

The descendants of the poet.

The descendants of the saintly poet still live in the village of Kumarahatta. One of them Babu Kali Pada Sen, a great grandson of Rāma Prasāda Sen, is working as an Engineer in Orissa. Rāma Prasāda died in the year 1775 A. D.

His death.

Two songs.

Before concluding my account of Rāma Prasāda, I quote two more songs of his which are very popular amongst the villages.

(1)

†"No more shall I call you by that sweet name, 'mother'!

"You have given me woes unnumbered and reserved many more for me, I know!

"I once had a home and family, and now you have made me such that I am disowned by all.

"What other ills may yet befall me I cannot tell.

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*Kali the Mother page 48.

† "মা মা বলে আর ডাক্‌বনা।
মা দিয়েছ, দিতেছ কতই যাতনা॥
আমি ছিলেম গৃহবাসী, বানালি সন্ন্যাসী,
আর কি ক্ষমতা রাখ এলোকেশী॥

"Who knows but that I may have to beg my bread from door to door? Indeed, I am expecting it.

"Does not a child live when his mother is dead?

"Rāma Prasāda was a true son of his mother;

—but you, being the mother, have treated your son like an enemy.

"If in the presence of his mother, the son can suffer so much,

what is the use of such a mother to him?"

(2)

*"O mother, for what offence have I been placed for this long term of life in this prison house of the world!

"I rise in the morning to work; O how hard do I work!

"I wander about in all directions to gain filthy lucre,

না হয় দ্বারে দ্বারে যাব, ভিক্ষা মেগে খাব।
মা ম'লে কি তার ছেলে বাঁচেনা॥
রাম প্রসাদ ছিল গো মায়েরই পুত্র।
মা হ'য়ে হলি গো ছেলেরই শত্রু॥
মা বর্ত্তমানে, এ দুঃখ সন্তানে,
মা থেকে তার কি ফল বল না॥"

*তারা কোন্ অপরাধে এ দীর্ঘ মেয়াদে
সংসার গারদে রাখিস্ বল॥
আমি প্রাতঃকালে উঠি, কতই যে মা খাটি,
ছটাছুটি করি ভূমণ্ডল॥
বৃথা অর্থ অভিলাষী, মায়ামদে ভাসি।
তারা এলোকেশী জানি কি কৌশল॥

"O what delusion possesses me !

"And, O mother, how perfect are the enticements by which you bind my soul to this vain world !

" Bringing me down to this world, unnumbered are the troubles you have crowded into my destiny.

" They burn me like fire day and night,

I no longer wish for life, O Mother !"

—— o ——

Other song writers.

After Rāma Prasād, a host of song-writers appeared who imitated his high spiritual strain. Amongst them the following writers attained marked success.

Rāma Kriṣṇa.

1. Maharajā Rāma Kriṣṇa of Nattore, son and successor of the far-famed Rañī Bhavānī of Nattore, and a contemporary of Rāma Prasāda Sen. Maharajā Rāma Kriṣṇa was one of the famous princely saints of India. We have not succeeded in tracing many of his songs, but the few, that have came down to us, show a high spiritual tone. One is quoted here :—

*"If only my mind can reach realisation, you may do with me whatever you will ; no matter if you place me on a bed of sand. Only recite the name of the divine Mother in my ears.

এনে ভূমণ্ডলে, কতই দুঃখ দিলে
আমার নিরবধি জ্বলে দুঃখানল ॥
আমার বাঁচিতে সাধ নাই ।"

*" আমার মন যদিরে ভোলে,
তবে বালির শয্যায়, কালীর নাম, রেখো কর্ণমূলে ।
দেহ আপন বশী নয়, সে রিপুর সঙ্গে চলে ॥
এনে দে ভোলা, জপের মালা, ভাসাই গঙ্গাজলে ॥"

"This body of mine is so difficult to control: it yields to passion.

"O Bhola, my guide, bring me my rosary; I shall throw it into the Ganges, no more formality."

Kamalā-kānta.

2. Kamalā Kānta Bhattācharyya, born in the last part of the 18th century. He was formerly an inhabitant of Ambikānagara in Kālnā, but removed to Kotalhata in Burdwan in the year 1800. He was the religious preceptor of Maharaj Tejaçchandra of Burdwan. I may here give one of his songs :—

* "In whatever station I may be placed, it all becomes blessed, if I forget thee not. O Mother! this life, the bitter cup of life, is a source of bliss, if I can feel thy grace in my heart. Ashes and clods of earth, or precious jewels, lodging beneath a tree for want of a roof, or a seat on the royal throne,—to Kamalā Kānta all these are of equal value, when in his heart thou dwellest."

3. Dewān Raghunātha Ray, born in 1750 A.D. at the village Chupi in Burdwan. His ancestors held the high function of Dewān in the court of the Maharajās of Burdwan, and on the death of his

* যখন যেমন রূপে রাখিবে আমারে।
সকলি সফল যদি না ভুলি তোমারে॥
জনম, করম, দুঃখ, সুখ করি মানি।
যদি নিরখি অন্তরে শ্যামা জলদ-বরণী।
বিভূতি ভূষণ, কি রতণ মণি কাঞ্চন।
তরুতলে বাস, কি রাজ সিংহাসন,
কমলাকান্ত উভয় সম সাধন জননি,
নিবস যদি হৃদয় মন্দিরে গো মা॥"

father Dewān Vraja Kiçore, Raghunātha obtained the appointment in due course. He was a profound scholar in Sanskrit and Persian, and composed a considerable number of religious songs in Bengali. He died in 1836.

Rāma Dulāla.

4. Dewān Rāmdulāla Nandi. He was born at Kalikaccha in Tippera in the year 1785. He acquired a mastery of Sanskrit, Persian and Bengali. He obtained the appointment of Sheristā-dār in the Noakhali Collectorate under Mr. Haliday; and after some time became the Minister in the Court of the Maharajā of Tippera. Rāma Dulāla died in the year 1851. Here is one of his songs.

† "O Mother, I know that you play at magic with our souls.

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† "ওগো জেনেছি, জেনেছি, তারা,
তুমি জান মা ভোজের বাজি।
যে তোমায় যেমনি ভাবে,
তাতে তুমি মা হও রাজি॥
মগে বলে ফরা, তারা, লর্ড বলে ফিরিঙ্গী যারা,
খোদা বলে ডাকে তোমায়,
মোগল, পাঠান, সৈয়দ, কাজী।
শাক্তে তোমায় বলে শক্তি,
শিব তুমি শৈবের উক্তি,
সৌর বলে সূর্য্য তুমি, বৈরাগী কয় রাধিকাজী।
গাণপত্য বলে গণেশ, যক্ষ বলে তুমি ধনেশ।
শিল্পী বলে বিশ্বকর্ম্মা, বদর বলে নায়ের মাঝি॥
শ্রীরাম দুলালে বলে, বাজি নয় এ জেন ফলে,
এক ব্রহ্ম দ্বিধা ভেবে,
মন আমার হয়েছে পাজি॥"

By whatever name one calls you, you seem to be pleased with it.

The Burmese call you Pharā ; the Europeans call you Lord ; the Saiyads, the Pāthanas and the Moguls call you Khodā.

The Çāktas know you as Giver of all strength.

The Çaivas call you Çiva.

The Sauras call you Sun.

The Vaiṣṇavas worship you as Rādhikā.

You are Ganeça to Gānapatyas, Kuvera of the Yakṣas, Viçvakarmā of the artisan class ; and Bador of the boatmen.

Says Ramādulal, this is no miracle ;—

it is quite true that my mind has become debased by thinking the one supreme god to be many."

—— o ——

IV. The yātrās or popular theatres.

Unlike the *kavi*, a *yatra*-party consists of male performers only, the part of women being performed generally by youths. The old *yatras* were a sort of melodrama,* the dialogues being mainly conducted in songs. There was no scenic representation of any kind. On the bare ground, a large carpet was spread, and the actors appeared upon it, all at one time. They usually began their performance by playing on musical instruments only, unaccompanied by any vocal music. The deep voiced *khol* accompanied by the shrill clang of the *kartal* produced a loud musical chord which summoned the people of

* This word is used in its technical, not popular, sense.

surrounding villages to assemble at the place of performance. This loud music would continue for a couple of hours, after which the play would begin in earnest. A green room, so to speak, was reserved for the actors to change their dress. Sometimes one would be observed to throw away his false whiskers, and dress himself as a woman, in full view of the audience; the faces were not very clean shaved, so that while playing the serious part of a princess or a lady of high rank, an actor might often be observed to bear on his chin remnants of the beard or moustache that had adorned his previous masculine part. The performers including those who were dressed as women, would sing in chorus; and the master-singer was always behind them and could sometimes be seen pulling the ear of some erring lad who could not pitch his tone correctly to the high notes of the musical instruments. Another actor, while delivering a speech, might be tempted by the sight of a *hooka*, and in the midst of a pathetic display of feeling, be seen to stop for a moment to snatch a puff of smoke, so that the first line of a song would coincide with the curl of smoke that issued from his mouth. Sometimes we may see the mother of the hero weeping over his dead body; suddenly she springs to her feet, and takes her place in the middle of the chorus, which bursts into a song of grief; at the same moment, the slain hero himself rises, in order to swell the volume of the music! The want of scenic representation was made up for by the simple declaration of the actor that he had now removed to a different place. Thus, Nārada the sage, who happens to be in the heaven of Viṣṇu, declares that he will now visit the

Its defects and incongruities.

Vrindā groves, and, advancing a few steps from where he stood, begins to describe the scenes of *Vrindavana*, as if he had now actually traversed all the distance between heaven and earth. In these *yatras* of the past, the audience comprised people of all ranks, for it was a free entertainment to which all were welcome, held at the cost of the master of the house. Early comers generally occupied the front places, irrespective of their position, and late comers had the disadvantage of back seats; but people did not mind this. They often stood on their feet enjoying the songs for hours together without seeming to feel the inconveniences to which they were subject.

Redeemed by rich poetry.

Though defective in so many ways—and from a superficial point of view the whole performance was marked by incongruity and want of all æsthetic perception,—yet the old *yatras* had the power to captivate the soul and keep men and women transfixed for hours at a time. The songs describing the scenes of Baikuntha, the heaven of Viṣṇu, of Amarāvati, the heaven of Indra, or of the Alakā, the heaven of Kuvera, couched in rich poetic words and set to pleasing modes of music, made up for all want of painted scenes. They suggested romantic situations, and carried the audience to heights of imagination where no painter's brush could have led them. The outward anomalies, the defective and even grotesque elements, were all forgiven and forgotten. These songs, thrilling with pathos, gave life to the performance, and the audience laughed and cried as though they fully believed in the joys and sorrows of the characters of the play. A very familiar personality in the old *yatras* was

Rādhā; she would come with flowing tresses frenzied by Kriṣṅa's desertion, and address the flowers, Mālati and Kunda, as if they were her friends, asking them where her Kriṣṅa was. She would then recollect the great love which Kriṣṅa bore to her; how he would play with her ringlets, saying "blessed am I in the touch of thy tresses"; how he would himself paint her feet with āltā, and bedeck her hair with flowers and garlands, how when looking at her face tears would start into his eyes without any cause, and he would call them tears of joy. He, who could not bear a moment's parting, had now deserted her. The maids were calling him a knave, a hypocrete and faithless lover. But Rādhā could not bear that Kriṣṅa should be reviled by others, though she was dying for love of him.

Rādhā deserted by Kriṣṅa.

The master-singer is generally expert in the theological lore of the Vaiṣṅavas. He comes frequently into the midst of the performers and interprets this love as divine love, making a little commentary aside. Chandrāvali, who was a rival of Rādhā, in Kriṣṅa love, comes to the Vrindā groves and sees that Rādhā is lying in a state of unconsciousness, the maids fanning her with lotus-leaves and weeping at her distress. Chandrā would not at any other time have cared to see her rival, but now the common grief of parting with Kriṣṅa has turned her into a sympathiser and friend. She sees Rādhā, and sings:—

The master-singer.

The laments of Chandrāvali

*"How remarkably handsome is Rādhā! I never saw her so closely before. When she stood by the

*"এতই রূপের রূপসী রাই, আমি নয়ন ভরে দেখি নাই।
যখন বঁধুর বামে দাঁড়াইত, আবার হেসে হেসে কথা কইত,

side of Krishna, and smiled, and talked, how beautiful did she look! Krishna, lying on a bed of flowers, would seem to wear her on his bosom, as one wears a precious necklace. Alas, she, the beloved of Krishna, now lies in the dust! How fine, how peerless are her feet that Krishna was never weary of praising, those feet that he would softly touch to paint with scarlet *alta*. When these tender feet would trip over the thorny paths of the forest to meet with Krishna, one could almost have wished to place her own bare bosom on the road, so that she might have stepped on it."

The interpretation.

When the singers had sung this song, the master-singer would approach and draw the attention of the audience to the description. He would say—"Rādhā's physical charms are not what the poet refers to. In all the points of this description, one may see that it is the love of Krishna that is described by the poet as constituting her beauty. Only when she was smiling and talking with Krishna, would she look charming in Chandrā's eyes, and not at any other time. Chandrā regrets her

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তখন এইনা মুখে—মুখের কতই যেন শোভা হ'ত।
বঁধু থেকে কুসুম শয্যায়, হৃদয়ে রাখ্‌ত যায়,
বঁধুর সে ধন আজ ধূলায় গড়াগড়ি যায়॥
অতুল রাতুল কিবা চরণ দুখানি,
আল্‌তা পরা'ত বঁধু কতই বাখানি,
এ কোমল চরণে যখন চলিত হাঁটিয়ে,
বঁধুর দরশন লাগি গো অনুরাগে,—
হেন বাঞ্ছা হোত যে পাতিয়ে দেই হিয়ে॥"

Rāi Unmādini by Krishna Kamala.

present condition, because she was the object of so much care to Kriṣṅa; she offers her own bosom for the treading of Rādhā's feet, when she may go out to meet *him!* In all this she indicates her love for Kriṣṅa as the only point that contributes to her beauty. Love for God can alone adorn a man—neither wealth, nor physical charms, nor power."

The pathos created by Kriṣṅa's going to Mathurā was the never-ending theme of the old *yatras*, and it was a matter, the lightest touch of which was sure to melt the hearts of all true Bengalis. Yaçodā, the mother of Kriṣṅa, wept, and said to her lord Nanda—

* 'O Prince of Gakula, I dreamt a dream; Kriṣṅa came to me and disappeared.'

and she details the dream by referring to little incidents which are full of tender pathos.

The shepherd boys sing in chorus.

The grief of the play-mates

† "Have you left us, O Kriṣṅa, because we took you for a common play-fellow, and did not pay you the tribute of worship that you deserved at our hands? How often, when playing, we quarrelled and abused you! Did you take these things to heart, and desert us, though we were so deeply devoted to you? We often beat you, or carried

*" শুন ব্রজরাজ, স্বপনেতে আজ, দেখা দিয়ে গোপাল কোথা লুকালে"

Svapnavilāsa by Kriṣṅa Kamala.

†" তাই ভেবে কি ভাইরে সুবল, ছেড়ে গেছে প্রাণের কানাই;
আমরা সামান্য ভেবে, কখন মান্য করি নাই।

you on our shoulders, and rode on yours. Often we ate first, and gave you the remnants, calling you by all familiar names. Have you, for all these, forsaken us, Oh beloved Kriṣṇa?"

Yātrās excelled the theatres.

So the shepherd boys sang; and as they sang they wept, and the audience was moved. All thought themselves in those Vrindā groves, where *Kadamva* trees rose upon the sight fringing the lovely horizon on the banks of the dark-watered Jumna,—those groves that the tears of the milk-maids and the shepherds have hallowed for ever. The *yatras* without any regular stage, without scenery, without the artistic display of costumes, could rouse emotions which now-a-days we scarcely experience, while witnessing semi-European performances given on the stages of the Calcutta theatres.

The subjects of the *yatras* were mainly episodes in the life of Kriṣṇa. There were, however, other subjects also taken up by different parties. The story of Vidyāsundara on the lines of Bhārata Chandra's poem, was adopted by a class of *yatrawalas*, of whom Gopāla Uriyā heads the list. The Vidyāsundara *yatras* had no serious element in them. They were in high favour with the light-brained aristocracy who enjoyed the humour, dances and

The Vidyā Sundara yātrās.

খেলা বেলায় করি দ্বন্দ্ব, কত যে বলেছি মন্দ,
সে মন্দ কি ভেবে মন্দ, ত্যজেছে ব্রজের সম্বন্ধ ॥
কত মেরেছি, ধরেছি, কাঁধে করেছি, চড়েছি
আপনি খেয়ে, খাওয়ায়েছি, তোতকার করেছি সবাই ॥"

Rāi Unmādini by Kriṣṇa Kamala.

witty sayings in the play, and as I have said on a previous page, the songs and dances of Hira, the flower-woman, formed by far the most important and attractive features of the Vidyāsundara *yatras*.

Gopāla Uriyā.

Gopāla Uriyā was born about the year 1819 at Jajpur in Cuttack. When a boy of nineteen he came to Calcutta, and, being very poor, adopted the calling of a hawker,—selling bananas. One evening he was passing along a lane of Bowbazar Street, where Babu Rādhā Mohana Sarkār, a distinguished noble man, was busy with the rehearsal of a Vidyāsundara *yatra* which he had organised. Gopāla was crying 'good bananas sir,' and only for fun he was called in before the party, where question upon question was put to him. To the surprise of the jovial company, they found that the lad was remarkably witty, and had an excellent voice. He was at once admitted into the troupe, and soon after began to compose songs himself. Becoming trained in music by the favour of his patron Babu Rādhā Mohana Sarkār, he organized a party which far outdid the fame of all other Vidyāsundara *yatrawalas*. He died about the year 1859.

Other yātrās.

Besides the Vidyāsundara *yatras*, there were the Chandi *yatras*, the Mansār Bhāsān *yatras*, the Rāma *yatras* and other *yatras* which had for the subject-matter of their songs mythological stories from the Mahābhārata.

There are no authentic records from which we may trace the early history of the *yatrawalas*.

From the time of Chaitanya, *yatras* have flourished in Bengal, and developed their melodramatic character.

A brief history of the yātrā-wālās.

The first great *yatrawala*, of whom we have any information, was Paramānanda Adhikārī, who lived in Bīrbhum more than 200 years ago. The subject of his play was Kāliya Damana. The next *yatrawala*, who earned a reputation in the same subject, was Sudāma Suvala Adhikāri. Lochana Adhikāri, who flourished after Sudāma had left the field, had two favourite subjects, in which he pre-eminently excelled. One was the Akrūra Saṇvada or the advent of Akrūra at Vrindāvana to take away Kriṣṇa and Valarāma, under orders of the King Kaṁsa of Mathura. The other subject was Nimāi Sannyāsa, or Chaitanya's taking the ascetic's vow. It is said that Lochana made so great an impression on Rājā Nava Kissen of Çobhābāzār and Bābu Vanamāli Sarkār of Kumertuli, by his songs, that these noblemen under a sort of spell, made him gifts of immoderate amounts of money Other noblemen of Calcutta, it is said, did not venture to engage the party fearing lest they also might be led, under infatuation, to pay him rewards beyond their means, as the two other noblemen had done. Govinda Adhikāri, an inhabitant of Krisnanagar, (1798 to 1870,) Pitāmvara Adhikāri of Kātwa and Kalāchand Pāl of Vikrampur, Dacca, were the latter-day luminaries in this field. Premchānd Adhikāri, Ānanda Adhikāri and Jaychandra Adhikāri of Patāihāt obtained celebrity in the Rāma *yatra*. Guru Prasāda Vallabha of Farāsdanga and Lāusen Bāḍala of Burdwan

excelled in the Chandi *yatra* and the Manasār Bhāsāna *yatra* respectively.

But we have not yet named the greatest *yatra-wala* that Bengal has ever seen. We have reserved a notice of Kriṣṅa Kamala Gosvāmi for the more elaborate treatment that he deserves at our hands.

The greatest of them,—Kriṣṅa Kamala; his life.

Kriṣṅa Kamala was born in 1810 at Bhājanghāta in the district of Nadia. He belonged to one of those few families of Vaidya Gosvāmies in Bengal who claimed Brāhmin disciples. Kriṣṅa Kamala's great ancestor Sadā Çiva, a friend of Chaitanya Deva, was reputed for his great piety. Kriṣṅa Kamala received his first lessons in Sanskrit grammar at Vrindāvana, where his father Muralidhara had taken him when only six years of age. He was a handsome boy, and by his pleasing manners attracted the notice of a millionaire who desired to adopt him as a son, and make him the heir to his vast fortune. On this, Muralidhara fled from Vrindāvana with his son, who was then only twelve years old.

Returning home, Kriṣṅa Kamala to please his mother Jamunā Devi, wrote a melodrama on Chaitanya which greatly pleased the village people of Bhājanghata, who marked the author as a young prodigy. When in his twenty-fifth year, his father died, and the poet left Bhājanaghāta and came to Dacca with his patron and disciple Rāma Kiçore. He composed his great *yatra* poem, the Svapnavilāsa in 1835. It was at once taken up and played by the amateur parties of Dacca. The success, this work attained, was unique. The songs of Svapnavilāsa

His poems.

were in the mouth of every one in Eastern Bengal, and even now, though about a century has passed since the publication of the poem, there is scarcely any old man or woman amongst the higher classes of that place who has not at least some songs from the book by heart. In a country where a lyrical element predominates, and where devotional feelings are preferred to action, songs are bound to occupy the same place in the popular estimation, as does drama in other countries where work and not sentiment is the motto. We cannot look for a Garrick here. A Kriṣṇa Kamala or a Govinda Adhikāri will better fulfil the natural cravings of the soul that longs to hear of lofty sentiment and of the highest flights of love. In the preface to Vichitravilāsa, a subsequent *yatra* poem by Kriṣṇa Kamala, the author writes about Svapnavilāsa. *"The public probably liked the book; otherwise why should there be a sale of nearly 20,000 copies within so short a space of time?" The sale of 20,000 copies of the book within a few weeks in Eastern Bengal, where a demand for printed books had not yet been created, was quite a phenomenon at that time, and showed the wonderful popularity which the poem had attained.

The best *yatra* by Kriṣṇa Kamala, however, was his Rāi Unmādini which appeared shortly after the Svapnavilāsa. After this poem had seen the light,

*"বোধ হয় ইহাতে সাধারণের প্রীতি সাধিত হইয়াছে, নতুবা প্রায় বিংশতি সহস্র পুস্তক স্বল্প দিনের মধ্যে নিঃশেষিত হওয়ার সম্ভাবনা কি?"

there were produced in succession the Bharata-milana, the Nimāi Sannyāsa, the Goṣtha and other works.

The Bharatamilana describes that episode of the Rāmāyaṅa in which Bharata meets Rāma in the forest with prayers for his return to Ayodhyā and acceptance of the kingdom. The Nimāi Sannyāsa describes Chaitanya's entering into the holy order of ascetics. All other works relate to episodes of the life of Kriṣṅa. His two best works are the Rāi Unmādinī and the Svapnavilāsa, and in both of them he describes in highly poetic language the woes of the inmates of Vrindāvana and especially those of Rādhā caused by parting from Kriṣṅa. And we may observe that in these poems the author, while giving the noblest expression to the tender feelings of a woman's love, takes the real cue from Chaitanya's life. We have read many speeches in the poems attributed to Rādhā which in reality have been borrowed from Chaitanya-Charitāmrita and other works on Chaitanya, only rendered into more refined forms, as the matter passed out of the hands of biographers into those of a poet. The Rādhā described by Kriṣṅa Kamala typifies and represents the frenzied condition of Chaitanya in divine communion and has been portrayed in a very exquisite form. Kriṣṅa never came back to the Vrindā groves, but the Bhāvasammilana or union in spirit is described by all Vaiṣṅava poets. The significance of this is that a material loss, though fraught with pain for the time being, is bound to prove a spiritual gain to the faithful in the long run. Our souls feel a craving for love,

The conception of union in spirit.

and imagine that this desire is satisfied by union with some particular individual. But circumstances are not within our control, and when we encounter sorrow in our love, the mind seeks happiness in its own resources, and under favourable condition of spiritual development, may find the fountain of love within itself,—a perennial stream which never dries up. This is the Bhāvasammilana, and in it the lost are found permanently, and the heart satisfied for ever. Nature offers in all directions what seemed to have been lost in a particular spot, and the blessed soul rises from its external sorrow stronger, freer, and happier, realising union which can never be interrupted. The Vaiṣṇava poets were always averse to tragedy; but as they did not find it mentioned any where in the sacred texts that Kriṣṇa ever returned in the flesh to the Vrinda groves, they created this Bhavasammilana in its place,—the ever-blissful subjective union, in which the mind, freed from the trammels of its material environment, revels in a delight, the fountain of which is within one's self.

We have already on pages 532-536 and 728-730 quoted passages from Kriṣṇa Kamala's works. I give below an extract from his *Sankritan* poems in which the shepherd-boys importune Yoçodā to allow him to go with them to the forest.

The importunities of the playmates of Kriṣṇa.

"Make Kriṣṇa ready, O mother Yoçoda, to go with us to the fields!

"The time is already up—the time for our sport.

* ও মা যশোদা দে মা দে সাজায়ে,
তোর শ্যামচাঁদ লয়ে যাই বনে।

"How long must we delay our woodl-and games?

"Give us your Krishna, mother, for the day. You ask, what care shall we take of him?

"We shall carry his flute and his rod; and we shall place him in our midst.

"He is so merry! He dances as he goes!

"When the rays of the sun are strong, we shall take him to the cool shadow of a tree, and let him rest; and we shall do our best to give him pleasure.

"If the way is thorny, we can carry him on our shoulders.

"And if we see him pale, we shall give him the fruits of the forest to eat.

"If he goes not with us, whom shall we adorn with wild flowers under the cool shadow of the *tamala* tree?

"Whom shall we crown with peacock feathers, and whose fine hair shall we plait with the *bakula* buds?

খেলার বেলা যায় মা বয়ে,
কখন যাবে গোচারণে।
ওমা সুধাও, সুধাও গো, তোর শ্যামসুধাকরে,
কানাইর বেণু বেত্র লয়ে আমরা যাব ব'য়ে,
মাঝে নেচে চলে নীলরতনে;
দিবাকরকর প্রবল হইলে,
লয়ে কালশশী বসি তরুতলে,
কমল বল্লভে ওপ্রাণবল্লভে,
শোয়াইয়া সেবি রাখালগণে।
সাধের কানাই না হলে, কদম্বের মূলে, কারে
সাজাইব বনফুল দিয়ে।

"The sound of whose flute shall charm our ears, and whose embrace shall cool our bodies?

"The peacock, the cuckoo, the bee, the *Sadi* and the *Suka* in the forest-bowers are waiting with heads uplifted to catch the sound of Krishna's flute.

"Help him to dress in his yellow cloth in the manner in which he appears peculiarly charming, O mother, and allow him to come with us.

"In the green pasture under the *kadamva* tree, we shall make him sit, and weave a garland with the *kunda*, the *sephalika*, the *ketaki*, the *mallika*, the *nagakesara*, the *tagara*, the *champaka*, the blue lily and the *kadamva* flower, and put it round his neck.

শিখিপুচ্ছকুলে, বকুলমুকুলে, চূড়া বেঁধে দিব কার
চিকণ চুলে।
কার বংশীরবে শ্রবণ জুড়াবে,
কার আলিঙ্গনে অঙ্গ শীতল হবে।
শিখি-সারি-শুক-মধুকর-পিক
সকলে উৎসুক আছে ঊর্দ্ধমুখে।
ধড়া ক'রে বেঁধে দেগো, পীতাম্বরে, পীতাম্বর।
বনফুলে সাজাইব আমরা নিয়ে বনান্তর॥
গোচারণ স্থলে, কদম্বের মূলে,
বসাইয়া সাধে দিব সাজাইয়ে।
কুন্দ সেফালিকে, কেতকী, মল্লিকে,
নাগকেশর, টগর, চম্পকে,
নীল শতদলে, কদম্ব মুকুলে,
গেঁথে হার গলে দিব পরাইয়ে

"Do not hesitate, O mother, but allow him to go with us!

"Look at the cows; they will neither graze, nor drink, if they see not the sweet face of Kriṣṅa.

"They will not even low, so long as they do not hear Kriṣṅa's flute,—but will remain as mute as statues.

"When the flute of Kriṣṅa is sounded, how quick and great is the response from all quarters.

"The sages see their highest visions, the stone melts and the Jumna stops her course.

"Your son, O mother, has magic arts! If he sounds his flute, the very cows understand and instantly obey his command."

Kriṣṅa Kamala lived the high life worthy of a true Vaiṣṅava. He died in 1888, at the advanced age of 78, but all his best works had been written

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নিঃসন্দেহে দে মা কানাই, ধরি তোর যুগল চরণে,
ওমা ধেনু না দেখিলে কানুর বিধুমুখ,—
অধোমুখে রয় গো, মুখে না লয় তৃণগণে।
যখন শুনে বেণুরব, করে ধেনু রব,
নহিলে নীরব রয় সকলে।
কানাই যখন করে বেণু ধ্বনি, ত্রিভুবনে হয়
জয় জয় ধ্বনি,
মুনিগণ' মন করে আকর্ষণ, পাষাণ গলে, হয়
যমুনা অচল।
তোমার কুমার মাগো, না জানি কি গুণ জানে,
বেণুর সঙ্কেত করে বনে চরায় ধেনুগণে।"

within the first fifties of the 19th century: hence we include him within the range of our treatise. When Krishna Kamala was brought to the Ganges at Chinsura and his last moment arrived, his eldest son Nitya Gopāla Gosvāmi wept like a child, lamenting that after the death of the master of the house, he would be quite unfit to govern it. The dying poet, who had till then retained his senses and power of speech, addressed his weeping son and said*:—"My son, do not weep. I really never knew that I was the master of the house. I knew you all to belong to God and as such it was my duty to offer my humble services to you all my life. Though you were my children, I kept away from my mind the vanity of knowing myself as the master. Guide yourselves in the light of this principle, and you will be ever happy."

The dying poet's words.

Yātrā poems with prose.

We have a few *yatra* poems interspersed with prose by authors who lived in the 17th and 18th centuries. Some of these are mentioned below:—

1. Duti Saṃvāda by Rāma Vallabha.
2. Vidyā Sundara Gāyan. The name of the author is not known.

Here is a song of Hirā, the flower-woman from this work.

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*"বৎস, কাতর হইও না। তোমরা গিরিধারীর: এই জ্ঞানে এতাবৎ আমি তোমাদের সেবা করিয়াছি, পালন করি নাই। প্রতিপালনের কর্ত্তা গিরিধারীকে জানিও। এই ভাব লইয়া সংসার করিও: কষ্ট পাইবে না।"

From the biography of Krishna Kamala, by his son Nitya Gopāla Gosvāmi.

* "I am but one, still to how many do I give pleasure!

"All is incomplete where I am not.

"When I do not go to the good damsels of the neighbourhood, interviews with their lovers can not be arranged, and the pain caused by separation kills them.

"If I do not come to the garden, the flowers and buds are all plucked by unknown hands."

3. Manasā Mañgala Gāyan. This works begins with a conversation between the manager of the *yatra* party, and a constable of the Rājā's palace where the *yatra* is to be held.

† "*Const.* Who are you making an uproar here, at this late hour of the night?

Manager. We are *yatrawalas*, and pray who are you, brother, yourself?

Const. I am the Rājā's constable.

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* "একলা প্রাণে ক'দিক যায়, পড়েছি বিষম দায়।
যে দিকে না চেয়ে দেখি, সে দিকে সব ব'য়ে যায়॥
পাড়াতে না গেলে পরে, বিরহিণী প্রাণে মরে,
মালঞ্চে না গেলে পরে, কুসুম কলি সব লুটে ন্যা'য়॥"

† "জমাদার। তোমরা কোন লোক হে, মাহারাজকা নগরমে এত্‌তা রাতমে ঝুমঝাম্ কিয়া?

যাত্রাওয়ালা। হে, আমরা যাত্রাওয়ালা গাইন হে। আরে ভাই, তোম্ লোক কোন্ হে।

জমাদার। আরে হাম্ মহারাজকা জমাদার হে।

Manager. And, answer me! Where are you going, at this late hour of the night?

Const. I am going to call Kalua, the sweeper of the palace.

[*Enters Kalua, the Sweeper.*]

Song (in Hindi).

"I do not know who it is that calls me.

"For the whole day I have been in attendance at the palace.

"I have swept the roads, and removed all dirt and filth.

"Why I am called again I do not know."

Farcical episodes.

In old *yatras*, farcical episodes were introduced, by way of relief, in intervals of a serious play, and the above indicates the way they were introduced.

A *yatra* performance usually commenced at 4 A.M., and ended at noon, thus lasting for 8 hours or more; of this, as I have said, the first one or two hours were spent in playing a high pitched clamarous music, the intention of which was to advertise the commencement of the performance to the

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যাত্রাওয়ালা। আরে রাতমে কাহা চল্‌তে হো।

জমাদার। আরে হাম্ কালুয়া হাড়ী বোলানেকো আনে চলতা হায়।

কালুয়া হাড়ীর গান।

"মেরা কোন্ বোলা হে চিন্‌তে নারি,
সারা রোজ হুজুরমে দিয়ে হাজিরি।
ঝাড়্‌ভি দিয়া, সাফ্‌ভি কিয়া,
ফের কিস্তরে বোলাতে হে বুঝ্‌তে নারি॥"

villagers. The farcical scenes which were introduced at intervals were generally called সং, and the children who accompanied their mothers to the place of performance, and who could not understand anything of the main play, were greatly interested in সং. In fact they would doze the whole of the time that was occupied in the enactment of the serious portions of the performance, and hailed these farcical scenes with great delight, noting each point with gaping mouths, and sometimes indicating their high gratification by the merry sounds of juvenile laughter.

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V. The three great poets with whom the age closed—Dāçarathi—Rāmanidhi Gupta—Içwara Gupta.

Before we close the narrative of our old literature, and enter upon that which is stamped with English influence, we propose to say something about a few more writers of the old school, and notice the folk tales prevalent in the country from ancient times. Let us first deal with the three poets who lived in the early part of the 19th century. Though by the time they flourished, English rule had become settled in the country, yet their writings bear no traces of European influence. They belonged to the old school and exercised a great influence on contemporary society and literature. These three poets are 1. Dāçarathi Rāi 2. Rāmnidhi Gupta and 3. Içwara Chandra Gupta.

Dāçarathi Rāi.

Dāçarathi Rāi was born at Vandāmura in Burdwan in the year 1804. His father Devī Prasāda Rāi was a man of small means. So the young poet lived with one of his maternal uncles at the village of Pilā where he ultimately settled. He

got a smattering of Bengali and became an apprentice in the office of an indigo-planter at Sākāi on a monthly pay of Rs. 3. Here he fell in love with a low-caste woman of ill fame. Her name was Akṣaya Pātini, and she was commonly called Akā Vāi. This woman had organised a party of *kaviwalas* for whom songs and speeches were now composed by our poet. This made him very unpopular at home, and on one occasion in an open competition of extempore verse-making he was lashed by the taunts of a rival *kaviwala*. The mother and uncle of Dāçarathi insisted on his leaving his mean occupation, associated as it was, with an ignominious passion. Dāçu could not withstand the importunities of his relations, least of all, of his mother; for inspite of the low calling that he had adopted, he was a good Brāhmin and his family enjoyed considerable respectability in the neighbourhood. Dāçu left the party of *kaviwalas*, and became the author and inventor of a peculiar kind of doggerel—called *Panchali*. These *Panchalis* took for their main subject those incidents in Kriṣṇa's life which in the popular belief of Bengal were indispensable to songs. But Dāçu adopted other subjects also favoured by the moderns, and possessing contemporary interest. Such for instance are his poems on Widow marriage, on the Lily and the Bee, and other subjects.

Panchali.

The popularity of these poems, which he made it his profession to recite and sing, was immense throughout the country, and though he had started by charging only Rs. 3 a night, for reciting and singing one of his *Panchalis*, he was able to

increase his fee to Rs. 150 per night, and the number of engagements that he made was so large that he had to refuse many. He grew rich in his old age, made a nice garden-house at Pilā on the bank of the Ganges, and lived comfortably till his death in 1857.

Dāçu Rāi's *Panchali* shows an amazing command over the Bengali language. For one who had had no Sanskrit education and had acquired only an indifferent knowledge of Bengali, his works deserve high praise. Alliteration and punning were his *forte*, and his verses, which flow with remarkable facility, sparkle with humour and wit. The words that he chooses are generally Sanskritic, though not pompous, and the effect produced on the ear by their combination is singularly pleasing. When he is vulgar, we know that he is addressing the mob, to whom the grossest obscenities would be welcome, and he spares no jokes, no hit, however indecent, to pander to their vile tastes. He was essentially a poet of the masses. By his swift doggerels, full of alliterations, by his obscenities, by the display of wit which was often of the coarsest kind, we know that the scum of the society were gathered to hear him, and his aim was to please them at any cost. His poems are full of display—of words, of thoughts, and of wit. They prove that he was trying to create an impression, and was always conscious of his brilliant talent. Take for instance this passage :—

Alliteration, punning and vulgarities.

* "Faith adorns a scholar; lightning adorns the cloud; the husband's love adorns a woman; the sacrificial ashes adorn an ascetic; the crops adorn the earth; its own lustre adorns a jewel; the fruits adorn a tree; water adorns a river; the lily adorns water; and the bee adorns a lily; his sweet hum adorns the bee; the eyes adorn the body; and charity adorns a kind-hearted man, if he gives it with sweet words."

These couplets while scarcely bearing more than any commonplace sense, are, however, remarkable for their jingling alliteration—the rhyming being singularly happy. The poet goes on with his catalogue of what adorns what, for pages, and it appears that unless one forces him to stop, he will never end this strain. Many such verses would be delivered extempore during a single performance, and bear evidence of being carried to the utmost limit of the poet's command over the language, because he was being clapped, cheered, and encouraged to continue. The mob was delighted by the free display of his verbal resources,

Goes on, being clapped and cheered.

* "পণ্ডিতের ভূষণ ধর্ম্মজ্ঞানী, মেঘের ভূষণ সৌদামিণী।
সতীর ভূষণ পতি, রত্নের ভূষণ জ্যোতি।
মৃত্তিকার ভূষণ শস্য, যোগীর ভূষণ ভস্ম,
বৃক্ষের ভূষণ ফল, নদীর ভূষণ জল,
জলের ভূষণ পদ্ম। পদ্মের ভূষণ মধুকর,
মধুকরের ভূষণ গুণ্ গুণ্ স্বর,
উভয়ে উভয় প্রেম বদ্ধ
শরীরের ভূষণ চক্ষু, যাতে জগৎ হয় দৃষ্ট।
দাতার ভূষণ দান করে, বলে বাক্য মিষ্ট॥"

and the poet lost all sense of proportion under the encouragement he received.

He describes many incidents in Kriṣṅa's life. The Prabhāsa scene, for instance, had been worked up to the tenderest pathos by earlier poets. Dāçarathi, then, began by describing how a Brahmin, who was grovelling in abject poverty, went to Kriṣṅa owing to pressure from his wife to beg for alms, and came back dissappointed. The story is told with much artistic effect, and we can understand how the audience would enjoy it. But the serious portion of the Prabhāsa scene must follow, and the thoughtful amongst the audience were sitting waiting for it. The poet however dragged the incidental story of the Brahmin beggar to such an inordinate length, that the whole time was taken up by it, and he began and ended his Prabhāsa with this single incident introduced by way of diversion and originally meant to supplement the main subject. Dāçarathi had no sense of proportion. In the atmosphere of the vulgar he lost all idea of time and place, and if he claims a place in literature, it is only by right of his sparkling and artistic language, which makes his shortcomings and scurrilities half-pardonable in our eyes. The art of writing and appreciating literature was no longer confined to the higher classes. The crowd also began to feel that Bengali literature was theirs. It was the season, as it were, for a flood-tide in our letters, and the evil was inevitably mingled with the pure to cover the whole range of the Bengali language.

Without any sense of proportion.

The suggestive hits of a sharp wit, the majestic sweep of Sanskrit metres, the lofty spirit of self-sacrifice and higher ideals attracted the upper

classes of society; but the coarser elements to suit the taste of the mob were inevitable, and thus the grotesque found place side by side with beauty, indecency with humour and the absurd with the natural. Dāçarathi Rāi was essentially a poet for the masses. In his poem on the Lily and the Bee, the bee, as the lover, being angry with the lily, declares himself an ascetic, and betakes himself to the forest,*—"the lover of the lily, like the sage Çukadeva, went in pensive mood, and gave heed to no one calling him." This poem is an inexhaustible fund of jest and wit, though towards the end it grows extremely vulgar.

The Lily and the Bee.

But I am afraid I have not done justice to Dāçarathi by calling him a poet for the masses only. Curiously enough, he is the author of many songs which breathe lofty religious sentiment and may almost be placed side by side with those of Rāma Prasāda and other saintly poets; with his perverse life, his vulgarities and his conceited style of writing, this element was certainly most inconsistent; yet he was a man capable of pious sentiment and devotional feeling; and whatever may have been his ways and manners, there was an under current of faith in him which comes unmistakably to light in his religious songs. The song beginning with—† "None is accountable, O Mother, for my sins.

His religious songs.

"With my own hands I dug a tank, and in it I have drowned myself."—

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* "চলিলেন পদ্মিনী স্বামী যেন শুকদেব গোস্বামী
ডাকলে কথা ক'ন না কারো সনে।"

† "দোষ কারু নয় গো মা
আমি স্বখাদ সলিলে ডুবে মরি শ্যামা।"

—glistens as it were with the tears of true remorse of a penitent soul. I quote below another song.

† "Find out a means, O divine Mother, for this humble soul, that it may finally rest at thy feet.

"Mayst thou grant me this boon, that at my death, the five elements, that constitute this mortal frame, may join the five places favoured by thee.

"May the etherial portions of my body fill the space of thy holy temple, and the clay of this clay-vessel form a part of thy sacred image as made by the potters.

"May my breath mix with the air of the fans with which the priests fan thy image.

"May my fire be mingled with the sacrificial fire kindled for thee, and the watery portion of my body be joined to the water with which the feet of thine image are washed.

"By thus being resolved and thus dedicated, O Mother, may I never come back to this world to be born and to die."

† "দুর্গে, কর মা এ দীনের উপায়, যেন পায়ে স্থান পায়।
আমার এ দেহ পঞ্চত্বকালে, তব প্রিয় পঞ্চস্থলে,
আমার পঞ্চভূত যেন মিশায়।
শ্রীমন্দিরে অন্তর আকাশ যেন যায়।
এমৃত্তিকা যায় যেন ত্বৎপ্রতিমায়, মা মোর পবন তব চামর
ব্যজনে যায়, হোমাগ্নিতে মমাগ্নি যেন মিশায়।
আমার জল যেন যায় পাদ্যজলে, যেন ভবে যায়, বিমলে,
দাশরথির জীবন মরণ দায়।"

Another song that he is said to have composed on the eve of his death may be taken as a sort of last will and testament. He addresses his brother Tinakaḍi, familiarly called Tinu, in the song.

*"Go back, all of you, and yourself also, dear brother Tinu.

"I came alone and alone must I go.

"It is not in my power to return home with you, nor have I any wish to do so.

"I bequeath to you all my property—my house, my lands, and garden-house and all the effects that I possess. You are now their sole proprietor.

The last song.

"Use this inheritance with discretion and wisdom: and be pleased, O brother, to look after my poor widow and maintain her.

"You seem to think that I am alone and helpless. But I have no need of pity at this moment. I am serene and happy in the arms of my divine Mother."

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*"তোরা ফিরে যা ভাই তিনু রে.
আমি যাব না, যেতে পারব না.
ভবে এসেছি একা, আমার একা যেতে হবে রে।
আমার যত কিছু টাকা, কড়ি,
ঘর দরজা, বাগান বাড়ী,
সকল ধনের অধিকারী, তিনকড়ি ভাই তুমি রে।
হয়ে বিচক্ষণ, ক'রো রে রক্ষণ,
ঘরে র'ল বিধবা রমণী, তারে অন্ন দিওরে।
তোমরা সবে ভাব একা,
আমি কিন্তু নইরে একা,
বসে আছি আমি মায়ের কোলেরে।"

I give below a list of Dāçarathi's works :—

Daçarathi's works.

1. Janmāṣṭami of Çrī Kriṣṅa.
2. Nandotsava.
3. Çrī Kriṣṅer Gostḥalīlā.
4. Çrī Rādhikār Darpachūrṅa.
5. Vastra-harana.
6. Nava-nārikunjara.
7. Kalanka-bhanjana.
8. Māna-bhanjana.
9. Akrura Samvāda.
10. Māthura.
11. Duti-samvāda.
12. Nanda Vidāya.
13. Uddhava Samvāda.
14. Rukminī Harana.
15. Satyabhāmār Vrata.
16. Satyabhāmār Darpachūrṅa.
17. Sudarçana Chakra and Garuḍer Darpachūrṅa.
18. Draupadir Vastra-harana.
19. Durvāçar Pāraṅa.
20. Çrī Rām Chandrer Vivāha.
21. Rāmer Vana-gamana o Sitā-haran.
22. Sitā Anveṣana.
23. Tarani Sen Vadha.
24. Lakṣṅmaner Çaktiçela.
25. Rāvana-vadha.
26. Rāma Chandrer Deçāgamana.
27. Lava Kuçer Yuddha.
28. Dakṣa Yajña.
29. Bhagavatī ebaṁ Gangār Kondala.
30. Çiva Vivāha.
31. Āgamani.

32. Kāçi Khanda.
33. Bhagīratha kartrik Gangā Ānayana.
34. Mārkander Chandi.
35. Mahisāsurer Yuddha.
36. Kamale-Kāminī.
37. Vāmana Bhikṣā
38. Prahlāda Charitra.
39. Çākta o Vaiṣṇaver Dvandva.
40. Vasante Viraha Varṇana.
41. Viraha.
42. Kali Rajār Upākhyān o Chāri-yiār.
45. Navin Chānd o Sonāmani,
46. Stri Puruṣer Dvandva.
47. Nalinī Bhramarokti.
48. Venger Viraha.
49. Miscellaneous songs.
50. Pañchālir Vyakhyā.

In an exhaustive compilation of Daçarathi's works lately published by the Vangavasi Office, Calcutta, we altogether counted 50,000 lines.

Rāma Nidhi Gupta.

Rama Nidhi Gupta, popularly known as Nidhu Babu, was born at Chāñptā in the year 1738. His father was a physician, and earned a small pittance by his profession. At the birth of the poet, the family had removed from Chāñptā to Kumartuli and settled there. Ram Nidhi received a sound education in Persian and Bengali, and acquired, besides, a smattering of English. His father placed him under the care of a European missionary, but the boy paid only little attention to the English language which his parents wanted him to learn, and devoted his whole time to the

His family history. His life and songs.

cultivation of Indian music. Being possessed of a sweet voice he very soon attained fame as a singer and became musically highly accomplished. When twenty years of age he obtained an appointment in the Collectorate at Chāprā where he worked for few years. Music as a science was cultivated with great zeal in Northern India during the decline of the Moslem power. The Mahomedan Chiefs and Nawābs lost their warlike qualities and became addicted to pleasures of all sorts, and highly favoured music. At Chāprā Rāma Nidhi came in contact with a well-known Moslem singer and under his instruction, coupled with his natural proclivities, soon acquired poficiency in Mussulmān music. He came back to Bengal with a resolve to compose songs in Bengali after Sari Miā whose favourite tune—the *tappa* was very popular at the time in the North Western Provinces.

Nidhu Bābu saw that Bengali songs, the Vidyā Sundara alone excepted, had always hitherto related to religious matters. Our love songs had for their theme amours of Rādhā and Kriṣṅa and formed part of the theological literature of the Vaiṣṅavas. Nidhu Bābu introduced a novelty ; in him the higher emotions of love stood on their own basis, requiring no justification by religious reference. Out of this conviction he sang and his utterances have a directness and sincerity which make him unique amongst our song-writers. His style is not marked by any elaboration. The brief and clear expression of thought is always his object,—never the laboured or fantastic conceits of language.

His *tappas*, as his songs are generally called, after the scale adopted by him, have human love for their subject, and the high spirit of idealism which breathes through them, coupled with the charms of a novel melody, elicited the appreciation of the educated community of Bengal. His verses were never popular in the sense in which those of Rāma Prasāda and Dāçarathi had been so. The latter commanded appreciation amongst all sections of Bengali Society, but Nidhu Bābu's *tappas* were mainly admired by the higher classes, who knew something of music as a science and had the culture to enter into the spirit of his exceedingly refined ideas, expressed as these were with laconic brevity. The masses still had the notion that no song was worth hearing which did not bear some explicit reference to religion in it. In a collection of songs published in 1905 by Bābu Durgā Dās Lāhiḍi the number of Nidhu Bābu's songs inserted is 472, and this does not indicate one-tenth of the number composed by him. They are generally brief,—ordinarily taking not more than eight lines, while there are many that have four lines only. But however short they may be, one is sure to find a complete idea in each of his songs. A lively emotion or a fine thought is put into charming language and they are as suggestive as they are brief. They remind us of the short and sweet love-lyrics of Robert Burns.

Nidhu Bābu never says any thing vulgar. He has always an elevated notion of love and gives us only the highest forms of tender sentiment. I here quote a few examples :—

*"I love you, not that you may love me in return!

"It has become my very nature to love you and you alone.

"I long for a sight of the smile on your lips, and for that I come here every day,

"O, do not mistake me, dear! I come to see you, not that you may see me!"

(2)

†"How shall I tell her how deeply I love her?

"On seeing her I feel a gladness that words can not describe.

"When she is not present, my eyes fill in tears, and when she comes I feel like one who has found a precious jewel, and knows not where to hide it."

(3)

‡"How am I to forget her:—

"Have I not offered my soul to her, knowing her for my own?

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*" ভাল বাসিবে বলে, ভালবাসিনে।
আমার স্বভাব এই, তোমা বই আর জানিনে।
বিধুমুখে মধুর হাসি, দেখ্‌তে বড় ভালবাসি,
তাই দেখে যেতে আসি, দেখা দিতে আসিনে॥"

(২)

†"কত ভালবাসি তারে, সই, কেমনে বুঝাব,
দরশনে পুলকিত মম অঙ্গ সব।
যতক্ষণ নাহি দেখি, রোদন করয়ে আঁখি,
দেখিলে কি নিধি পাই কোথায় রাখিব॥"

(৩)

‡"তারে ভুলিব কেমনে,
প্রাণ সঁপিয়াছি যারে আপন জেনে।

"How can I forget that image which with love's brush I painted on my heart with the utmost care?

"They tell me 'she has forgotten you; why do you not then forget her?'

"I shall forget her only when death destroys my memory."

(4)

*"Even before my death, my heart is set aflame.

"May this anguish, that burns me, leave her untouched.

"In my heart I have built a funeral fire, and my grief supplies the fuel.

"I am being consumed in the fire of my love. But may she rest in peace!"

(5)

†"When she is absent I plan to be angry with her; but when again I look upon her face, I forget myself.

আর কি সে রূপ ভুলি, প্রেমতুলি করে তুলি,
হৃদয়ে রেখেছি লিখে, অতি যতনে,
সবাই বলে আমারে, সে ভুলেছে ভুল তারে,
সেদিন ভুলিব তারে, যে দিন লবে শমনে।"

8

*না হতে পতন তনু, দহন হইল আগে।
আমার এ অনুতাপ তারে যেন নাহি লাগে।
চিতে চিতা সাজাইয়ে, তাহে দুখ তৃণ দিয়ে,
আপনি হতেছি দগ্ধ, আপনারি অনুরাগে॥"

(৫)

†সাধিলে করিব মান কত মনে করি,
দেখিলে তাহার মুখ তখনি পাসরি।

"Those eyes, that had resolved to turn away from her, surrender themselves, so soon as she approaches, losing all self-control."

(6)

*"Oh why is there this yearning in my heart to see him ?

"If I miss him for a moment, tears come to my eyes,

"The tongue of slander pursues me, and I glory in it.

"This evil repute seems to me like an ornament.

"My very life is leaving me for love. But he alas, cares nothing for me ! His conduct is indescribable. Why do I love him ? You ask me. I myself know not why !"

(7

†"How happy I should be, if only my beloved would love me in return !

"The scentless *kinsuka* flower would then become sweet-scented.

অভিমানে কহে আঁখি, আর না হইব সুখী,
দরশনে হয় পুনঃ অধীন তাহারি ।

(৬)

* "তারে দেখিতে এত সাধ কেন
তিলেক না হেরি যদি সজল নয়ন ।
আভরণ করিয়াছি লোকের গঞ্জনা,
তাহার কারণে মরি, সে নহে আপনা ।
তাহার রীতের কথা অকথ্য কথন
তবে যে ভুলেছে মন, জানি না কি গুণে ॥"

(৭)

†"তবে প্রেমে কি সুখ হ'ত
আমি যারে ভালবাসি সে যদি ভালবাসিত

"The thorny *ketaki* would grow without thorns.

"The sandal tree would have flowers, and the sugar-cane would bear fruits."

But how can I convey the impression made on the mind by these *tappas* when they are sung? It appears as if a voice were heard out of the regions of blessedness where self is completely immerged in love.

Nidhu Bābu married a girl wife in the village of Sukhachara when he was only twenty. A son was born to the pair in 1765. The child died, when only three years old, and his mother survived him only a few months. Soon after the death of this wife Nidhu Bābu married again. His new bride was a resident of Jorāsānko in Calcutta. But she also died a few months after her marriage in 1768. Nidhu Bābu was only thirty years old at the time; but he could by no means be persuaded to marry again. Twenty years passed from this time, and in the year 1788 the widower was compelled by friendly intervention to take a third wife from the village Varijahāti in the district of Howra. He became the father of four sons and two daughters by this marriage. He died in 1825 at the age of 87.

Died in 1825.

Içvara Gupta.

Dāçarathi was pre-eminently a poet of the masses. Rāma Nidhi's love songs were appreciated and sung by that section of the community which delighted in higher music and in the literature of refined

কিংশুক শোভিত ঘ্রাণে, কেতকী কণ্টক বিনে,
ফুল হতে চন্দনে, ইক্ষুতে ফল ফলিত॥"

sentiment. Içvar Chandra Gupta was the idol of the educated Bengali Hindus of his period. He was a great figure,—in fact the most remarkable literary personality of his age. It was his encouragement that inspired Bankima Chandra, Rangalāla, Dinavandhu and other young aspirants to literary fame who all served their first apprenticeship in Bengali by writing in the monthly *Prabhákara* edited by Içvar Chandra.

His life.

Curiously enough, this writer was no scholar, though his voice was so authoritative in the Bengali literature of his time. In his early years he neglected his studies, and was given up for a lost child.

Içvara Chandra was born in 1811 at Kāñchrāpārā in the district of Twenty-four Parganas. His father Hari Mohan Gupta was not a man of means; he earned the small pittance of Rs. 8 a month as clerk in an indigo factory at Selidaha; but he had some small landed property in his native village, and the family was mainly dependent upon this.

Içvara Chandra showed courage, so early as five years of age. One night the lad was passing through a place supposed to be haunted by ghosts; it was a dark night, and a tall man, passing by, tumbled over him. The child was not daunted by what others of his age would certainly have taken for a ghost, but he boldly stood up and asked 'Who are you, my man?.' When he was ten years old, his mother died. His father lost no time in taking a second wife. The step-mother was introduced to young Içvara Chandra, who threw a brick at her by way of first greeting, expressing his great indignation at the conduct of his father. His uncle was

so angry at this behaviour that he gave him a sound thrashing with his shoes. Young Içvara sulkily bore the punishment and shutting himself up in a small room, did not come out for the whole day.

Married to an ugly girl.

His father Hari Mohan Gupta not only gave him a step-mother whom he did not like, but married him, when only fifteen, to Durgāmani Devi, an ugly idiotic girl who stammered in her speech. The reason for his father's favouring this girl was that her pedigree was noble,—a point which at one time carried high favour with Hindu fathers.

Içvara Chandra's career in school soon came to a close, and he became notorious for his negligence in his studies and for his rowdisms. All gave him up for lost, and he had no better opinion of himself.

A lost child and soreness of heart

He was unfortunate in life,—in his early years as a motherless child, and in manhood as the husband of a wife who was no companion, but rather a troublesome burden, always keeping afresh a disappointment than which in youth nothing can be greater.

The result is the soreness of heart and spirit of satire which characterise his poems. He became a misanthrope and took revenge upon the world by jeering unsparingly at all classes of people. He found no happiness in the nuptial tie, and Bābu Bankima Chandra Chatterjee, his distinguished biographer writes of him :—

*"He was lacking in that education of soul which the company of women gives to a man; he

*যে শিক্ষা স্ত্রীলোকের নিকট পাইতে হয়, তাহা তাঁহার হয় নাই; যে উন্নতি স্ত্রীলোকের সংসর্গে হয়, স্ত্রীলোকের প্রতি

lacked in the edifying influence which admiration and love for the softer sex causes in youthful minds. Womankind was the subject of his constant abuse."

But we shall deal with the merits of his literary composition in their proper place.

A born poet.

It is said that when only three years old, he composed a couplet, to the great admiration of his relations, describing the sort of life he was leading in Calcutta.

*" Mosquitoes by night and flies by day.

This is Calcutta life, say what you may !"

Though his education was practically *nil*, yet on one occasion as his companions were reading poems in Persian, he sat quietly by and listened with attention to their contents, when explained in Bengali. He retired and soon came back with some sparkling verses in Bengali embodying the spirit of the Persian poems, which highly pleased his companions who took him to be a young prodigy. This poetical trait developed so remarkably in him, that when he was only 11 years old, he could compose songs that were accepted with compliments by professional musicians who put the lad to constant tasks in poetical composition,

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স্নেহ ভক্তি থাকিলে হয়, তাহা তাঁহার হয় নাই। স্ত্রীলোক তাঁহার কাছে কেবল ব্যঙ্গের পাত্র।"

The memories of Içvara Chandra Gupta by Bankima Chandra Chatterjee.

*" রেতে মশা দিনে মাছি
এই নিয়ে, ভাই, কলকেতায় আছি "

which it was the joy and pride of young Içvara Chandra to execute to the best of his ability.

But an illiterate man by sheer dint of inborn genius could not be expected to attain more than a rustic fame and the applause of his personal friends. An opportunity however soon presented itself which paved the path to his receiving some education and bringing his remarkable talents to the notice of the enlightened public. His maternal uncles lived at Jorāsānko, where the Tagore family were at the time, as now, pioneers in education and in all progressive movements in Bengal. Içvara Chandra's singular poetic powers attracted the attention of Babu Jogendra Mohan Tagore, and the poet became a friend and companion of that enlightened nobleman. He received a good education here, and conjointly with his noble friend and patron started the weekly *Sanvad Prabhakara* in March, 1830. This journal soon reached the highest popularity in Bengal, and Içvara Chandra's genius supplied the public, through its columns, with an unceasing fountain of satirical and serio-comic pieces in prose and poetry for many years. It was in this journal that the juvenile writings of some of the greatest writers of Bengal such as Bankima Chandra and Dinabandhu Mitra were accorded a place by him, for he was never slow in appreciating talent in young writers and in giving them the encouragement they deserved. Içvara Chandra's noble friend and patron died in the year 1832. Disheartened by this blow of fortune, the poet stopped *Prabhakara* for some time, but it re-appeared as a bi-weekly in 1836, and in 1839 he

Receives education.

Starts a weekly.

made it a daily paper. Besides the *Prabhakara* he edited the *Samvad Ratnavali* which was started in 1849. He translated the Bhāgavata into Bengali verse and also the *Provodha Chandroday Natak* which he called *Vodhendu Vikasha* in Bengali. He was a voluminous versifier; it is said that he composed more than 50,000 couplets. Içvara Chandra died in February, 1858.

Thus the wayward lad and spoilt child lived to wield great influence in the literary atmosphere of Bengal, immediately before it became charged with European influence. He was pre-eminently a poet of the old school, and with him died the last echoes of the age of Bhārata Chandra and Jaya Nārāyaṅa Sen. Satire was his *forte* and bright wit sparkles in his lines directed against what was false and artificial in society. At home he was a genial friend and his company was sought for by the wealthy and talented alike. He kept no accounts and could have amassed a fortune, had he desired to do so. His income from the *Prabhakara* was great; and besides he was endowed with monthly pensions and honorariums from many rich men in Bengal; he spent money heedless of the morrow, and was always ready to help the needy. No friend was refused a loan when he wanted it and many did not repay, but the poet never asked his money back. In the sketch that Bankima Chandra draws of him we find it mentioned that Içvar Chandra distributed prizes and rewards amongst young men who showed skill in literary composition, and young Bankima Chandra who was destined at a subsequent time to win far greater laurels than

His character.

his patron, was also the recepient of prizes from him.

So lived and died Içvara Chandra,—one of the most remarkable men of his time in Bengal. He was a born satirist and a born poet. He adorned whatever he touched with his brilliant wit. When he would vilify a rival, his style would sink into the grossest and most atrocious obsceneties. This had grown to be the fashion amongst the literary men of this time. Içvara Chandra's scathing attacks on his rival Gauri Çaṇkara Bhattāchāryya, commonly known as Gurgure Bhattāchāryya, in the *Sombad Prabhakara*, and the latter's charges in answer published in his journal the *Rasaraja*, form a literature of the worst type that ever saw light; and Mr. Lang, the popular Christian missionary, whose name is inseparably connected with the indigo disturbances, felt the necessity of moving the authorities to enact a law against obscene writings, owing to these perverse and scurrilous publications.

Vulgar satires.

Yet, in spite of such writings Içvara Chandra often disclosed in his poems a highly religious turn of mind. He was not great enough to introduce innovation in taste and free himself from the vices of the age. In the collection of his poems by Bābu Manindra Chandra Gupta, we find no less than 70 pieces devoted to religious subjects, and all of them bear evidences of their writer's spirituality and faith.

Specimens of his writings.

We give below some specimens of his writing.

(*a*). From the poem "Festivity in the month of Pausa."

*"The young wife has scarcely time to braid her dishevelled hair. If per chance she spoils a curry, the mother-in-law and sister-in-law are furious with her. They say 'What hast thou done? It takes one's breath away to see the extent of your folly. Your mother could not teach you anything better than this? If we went without food for years, still we would not touch this curry. The beautiful face of the young wife, sweet and lovely as a full blown lotus, is drowned in tears; her sorrows she can not express, and she bears those rebukes though her heart is bursting with grief."

The young wife.

This is a true picture of young wife; peculiarly placed as she is in Hindu society, she must suffer all the ills of life patiently without a word, till she grows to be herself the mother of chiidren, and has a chance to maltreat some other young wife placed in her charge, by way of retaliation.

(b). On the widow marriage act, which had been passed, it will be remembered, in the teeth of the opposition of the orthodox community.

[It should be borne in mind that Hindu widows are not allowed to wear shell-bracelets nor allowed to take fish or meat of any kind.]

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*" সাবকাশ নাই মাত্র এলোচুল বাঁধে
ডাল ঝোল মাছ ভাত রাশি রাশি রাঁধে।
কত থাকে তার কাঁচা, কত তার পুড়ে।
সাধে রাঁধে পরমান্ন নলেনের গুড়ে।

বধূর রন্ধনে যদি যায় তাহা এঁকে।
শ্বাশুড়ী ননদ কত কথা বেঁকে॥
হ্যালো বউ কি করিলি দেখে মন চটে।
এই রান্না শিখেছিস মায়ের নিকটে॥

Widow-marriage.

*"All are saying, let not the reformers, determined as they are to save the young widows, take up the case of elderly matrons—our wrinkled-faced greyhaired grandams. Who so bold as to dare approach them with an offer of shell bracelets and fish?"

The first kiss.

(c). The first kiss of love.

†"A fount of the utmost happiness, that a lover's heart can wish for, is in the first kiss of love.

"We hear of the nectar in Indra's heaven for which the very angels are suppliants, a drop of which fills their minds with celestial joy,

"for which the demon Rahu periodically swallows the moon.

"But the nectar—sweet nectar, I do not covet in preference to this first kiss of love."

বধূর মধুর খনি মুখ শতদল।
সলিলে ভাসিয়া যায় চক্ষু ছল ছল॥
আহা তাঁর হাহাকার বুঝিবার নয়।
ফুটিতে না পারে কিছু মনে মনে রয়॥"

*"সকলেই এইরূপ বলাবলি করে।
ছুড়ির কল্যানে যেন বুড়ি নাহি ত'রে॥
শরীর পড়েছে ঝুলে, চুল গুলি পাকা।
কে ধরাবে মাছ তারে, কে পরাবে শাঁখা?"

†"প্রণয় সুখের সার, প্রথম চুম্বন।
অপার আনন্দপ্রদ, প্রেমিকের ধন॥
আছে বটে অমৃত অমরাবতী পুরে।
প্রোমোদিত করে যাহে যত সব সুরে॥
উথলয়ে প্রেমসিন্ধু পানে এক বিন্দু।
যার আশে গ্রাসে রাহু পূর্ণিমার ইন্দু।
সে ক্ষুধার সুধা মাত্র নাহি এক ক্ষণ।
যদি পাই প্রণয়ের প্রথম চুম্বন॥"

"Or look at wine, the favourite drink of the Asuras, even a touch of whose cup fills the mind with pleasure,

"drunk with this, the yādavas fought and died,

"wine that kept Vala Rāma in a never ruffled cheerful mood—now become a familiar article with the civilised world;

"even that drink—wine, sweet wine,—I covet not in preference to this first kiss of love."

‡"Diamonds are found in the mines of Golakanda,—

"On the tops of the mount Sumeru are mines of gold and silver,—

"In the sea near Ceylon the pearls called Gajāmuktā are found in abundance,—

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† অসুরের সুধা প্রিয় পেয় সুরারস মাত্র।
রসনা সরস গাত্র পরশিলে পাত্র॥
যার লাগি হল ধ্বংস যদুবংশগণ।
স্বভাবে অভাব সদা রেবতী রমণ॥
অদ্যাবধি মদ্য মাত্র পানীয় প্রধান।
বিদ্বজ্জন খাদ্য মাঝে সদ্য বিদ্যমান॥
এমন মধুর সুরা নাহি চায় মন।
যদি পাই প্রণয়ের প্রথম চুম্বন॥

‡ গলকুণ্ড দেশে আছে হীরার আকর।
রজত কাঞ্চণময় সুমেরু শেখর॥
নানা রত্ন পরিপূর্ণ রত্নাকর জলে।
গজমুক্তা মূল্যযুক্তা অনেক সিংহলে॥

"If Kuvera, the god of wealth were to come with all these and offer them to me,

"I would cast them all away for this my love's first kiss."

But Içvara Chandra will always be admired for the pains he took to collect biographical accounts of some of our early poets, as Bhārata Chandra, Rāma Prasāda and some of the old *kaviwalas*. He travelled in various places of Bengal to unearth valuable materials, and regularly published in *Samvad Prabhakara*, the accounts which he gleaned by his patient research. Much of the information that has come down to us about the lives of our great literary worthies is based upon these accounts.

Biographical sketches.

Içvara Chandra composed many songs for the Kavi parties. In them we find the same ready wit and the sound realistic pictures of domestic life in Bengal, given with that remarkable fidelity which characterises his other writings.

Kavi songs.

His poems are growing obsolete and the great popularity which they once enjoyed is now a thing of the past. The humour of our elders has lost much of the old flavour owing to the more fastidious taste that prevails now. Some of the witty sayings once admired appear to us puerile and it is to be feared, that 50 years hence, Içvara Chandra's

Growing out of date.

কুবের লইয়া যদি সেই সমুদয়।
আমারে প্রদান করে হইয়া সদয়।
ক্ষেপণ করিব দূরে প্রহারি চরণ।
যদি পাই প্রণয়ের প্রথম চুম্বন॥"

poems will only be read by a few students of Bengali who would desire to trace the history of its progress.

Içvara Chandra's style bears evident traces of Bhārata Chandra's influence ; and the influence of his own is stamped on the works of Hema Chandra who succeeded to his high place in Bengali poetry, a quarter of century after. Most of the social satires of Hema Chandra have a ring of Içvara Chandra's celebrated verses on 'our old Çiva' as Mr. Marshman was humourously called by him.

His influence on Hema Chandra.

Içvara Chandra's prose is far from being happy. It is highly pedantic, and has even an element of grotesqueness in it.

The Folk-literature of Bengal.

Bengal possesses a rich folk-literature, very little of which has yet been put into writing. The grandmothers may be heard to tell these stories to their grandchildren every evening in remote villages, —stories which have come down from a very early age. The Rev. Lāl Behāri Dey published some of these stories in English, but those gleaned by him from the resources available in towns represent only a very small fraction of such literature, and the most beautiful of these were not accessible to him, as, being a Christian, he could not have full command of the resources of the Hindu home. Lately Babu Dakṣiṇā Ranjana Mitra Mazumdār has published two volumes of folk-tales in Bengali. He has attempted to reproduce them in the very language of the rustic women from whom he collected them. In some cases he recorded the

Dakṣiṇa Babu's collections.

stories by a phonograph at the time they were delivered; so that their language remains remarkably faithful to the narration of the villagers.

As specimens of old dialect.

The language owes not the least colouring or refinement to modern literary Bengali. The dialect spoken in the country five hundred years ago, of which specimens are to be found in the written literature of the period, remains unchanged in the colloquial language of our backward villages, not subjected to the influences of the outside world; and Dakṣiṅā Babu's collection has not only preserved the spirit of the old folk-lore unpolished by the touch of the compiler, but has retained even those old and quaint forms with all their mannerisms, which best indicate the genius of our tongue.

There are altogether 16 stories in the two volumes. Some of them are meant simply to amuse the children, which is the primary object of all nursery tales. There are others, like the stories of Mālanchamālā and Kāṅchanamāla, which though sufficiently wild and romantic to amuse the young, have also deeper meanings to interest more thoughtful readers. The characters of the heroines of these stories possess a living interest. The ideals of chastity and devotion to the husband, which they hold up, open vistas, as it were, into the domestic life of the Hindu women of past days, and enable us to see the workings of their souls—the purity of their hearts and the wonderful spirit of sacrifice which actuated them in there every-day conduct.

Mālanchamālā.

The pathos created by Mālanchamālā's sufferings, her sacrifices, and devotion to her husband are matters difficult to be conveyed to those whose idea

of wifehood is different from that which governs Hindu women. The Hindu wife in those days bore all kinds of ills from her husband with untiring patience; she lived with her co-wife, to whom often the husband was devoted and bore her neglect and his contempt in a surprising spirit of resignation; and inspite of all maltreatment cherished only the best feelings for her husband. All this was sometimes done with a grace,—a saintliness and devotion which place her sorrows above our pity. They may be looked upon almost in the light of martyrdom. The supernatural element prevails in the story of Mālanchamālā, with all imaginable excesses of wild fancy, and this constitutes its interest for the young; but as we proceed, the griefs of the heroine becomes the all-absorbing subject of the readers. Her woes claim a tear at every page. She like Behulā restores her husband to life; she saves him from the flames of the funeral pyre; follows him like a shadow; and, all unseen by him, ministers to his every comforts. She was married to him when he was a mere child. The child grows up, but Mālanchamālā does not show herself to him till he becomes a handsome youngman and has married a princess. Many years of fasts, and vigils, heart-rending anguish, and cruel treatment from her royal father-in-law, who does not allow her to live in his palace because she is of an inferior caste, are rewarded with this, that her husband marries the princess and lives in the palace of his new bride's father. And this husband had been the apple of her eye; in the funeral ground, in the deep shades of the wilderness she had saved him from death, undergoing unheard of hardships,

Her great love.

and bringing to him all the ministering care of a guardian angel! The young wife looks through a window in the moonlight and sees her husband and his new bride happy together. Mālanchāmālā —chaste, devoted and faithful to her husband, as fidelity itself, peeps through the lattices of the window, and sees her husband in the arms of the princess; it was like Enoch Arden peeping into the room of Phillip and discovering Anne as his wife; but our Mālanchamāla is no earthly woman; she is heavenly in every sense of the word. She sings:—

"Live in happiness, O Prince; live in happiness, O Princess.

"If I am a chaste woman, my words will not be in vain.

"Let your ancestors in heaven, O Prince, watch the candles that light up this chamber and preserve you from all ill.

"May the children, that are born to your new wife, walk beneath royal umbrellas for fourteen generations to come!

"O Forests, O trees, O land, O waters, keep guard! Let me know when they awake, that I may steal away unseen by either.

"Let the towers of the palace, where my husband reigns, endure for ever.

"Let the sun and the moon be as guards of his city.

"May my royal father-in-law's palace and the throne of my husband be victorious for ever.

"And may the shell-bracelets of the Princess and her vermilion mark, the signs of her wifehood, —endure for ever.

"Grant me this boon, O God. I brought up my husband with great pain, and now what can I covet more than to see him happy with a princess?

"Though I die and am reduced to dust I shall ever rejoice at this sight of the happiness of my husband.

"If I die now and am transformed into a bird or a lower animal, or whatever else may befall me, I care not, as I have seen my beloved happy."

This song is couched in the idioms of at least five centuries back.* The story has been worked into such life-like details, that the woman Mālancha-mālā does not here pose as a great heroine. She does not seem to attempt at reaching any inaccessible height. Her woes give rise to great pathos, but with all these she continues to attract us, as an unassuming lovely village-girl that she is.

Our Bengali folklore shows how peculiarly situated a Hindu wife might be in the midst of environment and influences favourable to the development of a spirit of sacrifice, devotion and fidelity. Her growth was often as natural as that of a flower, and is quite faithfully portrayed in the old literature of the country, and even in this unassuming folklore, where nothing has been put forward for the sake of display. The story of Kānchānamālā also shows the familiar ideal of the Hindu wife. Her husband neglects her, but she persists in her devo-

Kānchana-mālā.

* Thakur Dadar Jhuli by Daksina Mitra p. 195.

tion. For selfish reasons her husband comes reluctantly at a certain crisis to obtain her permission for undertaking a sea voyage, promising her, as a reward, a necklace of pearls, a fine pair of shell-bracelets and vermilion to adorn her forehead. But she answers, "You are my necklace of pearls; you are my shell-bracelets and vermilion mark; I do not want any other. Only take me with you my husband, I shall be at your bidding and be happy." These stories are interspersed with songs in language which is generally very antiquated. Many facts about old Hindu society and about the sea-voyages undertaken by the merchants of Bengal are to be found in these stories; and there are other elements which indicate Bhuddistic influences, such as instances of the wonderful powers of Siddhās, and descriptions of Tāntrick rites. There are some stories on which Mahomedan influence has evidently left its impress, as for instance in the story of Madhumālā, the introduction of fairies is certainly no creation of the Hindu fancy.

Buddhistic and Moslem influences.

The songs with which those stories abound are sung to the favourite village metre known as Bhātiāl *sura*. This rythem and cadence is peculiarly distinctive of Bengal; it has nothing to do with the refined melodies of Sanskrit or Persian music. There are six *Ragas* and thirty six *Raginies*—42 chief scales or musical modes of the Hindus; but the Bhātiāl *sura* is not included in the range of this higher musical system. Bhātiāl is the cadence of the rustics, and its plaintive and appealing notes, so unassuming and simple, go straight to the heart and create their own pathos, without possessing any of those niceties of sound which charac-

terise the *Ragas* and *Raginies*. The power of the Bhāṭiāl to strike the tender cords of the human soul, was found out by the Vaiṣṇavas who refined and enriched it with modulations and made from it that soul-captivating air—the Manohara Sāi. The writers of religious songs adopted it with peculiar modifications to form the *Baul sura* which produces emotions peculiar to an ascetic mood.

Supplementary Notes,

TO

CHAPTER VI.

I. **Miscellaneous Poems.**
II. **Mainly on style, literary tastes, and language.**
III. **Early prose-literature.**

We must remember that during that period when the Bengali language was being most rapidly developed and its literature was growing, the Hindus had already lost their political supremacy. By far the larger section of the Hindus lived in villages, and for them henceforth history lay almost entirely in the story of their social changes. Descriptions of society and its revolutions are found in many works of the Vaiṣṇavas. We have also, however, a small number of works on political history. Some of those written in poetry are noticed below. We reserve our treatment of the historical works written in prose for our account of Bengali prose, upon which we have not yet touched.

I, Miscellaneous Poems.

(a) Historical poems.

1. Rājamālā, a history of the Rājās of Hill Tippera. This work was undertaken at the command of Mahārājā Çri Dharma Mānikya (1407—1439 A.D.) by two Brahmin scholars of his court—Çukreçvara and Vāṇeçvara who were inhabitants of Assam. Durlabha Chandāi a hoary headed old man, a courtier and the leader of the Chandāi community at the time, had much information about the early history of Tippera; and Çukreçvara and Vāṇeçvara

frequently consulted him while compiling the Rājamālā. It also appears that there existed in fragmentary condition, earlier works on the same subject from which much help was received. Those to which reference is made in the Rājamālā are (1). Rājamālikā (an earlier work on the Tippera Rājās), (2). Yogini Mālikā, (3). The Lakṣmaṅa Malika (probably a history of Rājā Lakṣmaṅa Sen of the Sen dynasty of Bengal) and (4). Vārunya Kālirnaya. The Rājamālā was written in simple metrical verse.

We have also seen a small treatise, evidently very old, in which the history of the Tippera Rājās, traced from Duryya, son of Yayāti of the Lunar race, is embodied briefly in verse.

Mahārāṣtra Puraṅa.

2. *Maharastra Purana* by Gangārāma. This is an historical work in Bengali verse, which gives an account of the Maharatta raids in Bengal led by Bhāskara Pandit in 1741 A. D. These raids, commonly known in our country as the *Vargira hangama*, gave rise to a feeling of general unrest and panic, inspiring the well-known nursery song, sung up to the present day by mothers to lull naughty children to sleep. This couplet which, like all nursery songs, does not convey any clear meaning, runs as follows—

*"The child is asleep, the whole village is relieved.

*"ছেলে ঘুমাল, পাড়া জুড়াল, বর্গী এল দেশে।
বুলবুলীতে ধান খেল, খাজনা দিব কিসে?"

"The Maharatta raiders have overun the country.
and the Bulbulis (*Turdus jocosus*) have eaten up the crops.

"How shall we pay the rent?"

Gangārāma wrote his historical poem in 1750 A. D.,—seven years before the battle of Plassey. His account of the raids seems to be a faithful one. The author describes how Ālivardi Khān, the Nawāb was suddenly attacked by Bhāskara Pundit at Burdwan and made a captive there for a short time. This is borne out by a statement in Tarikhi-Yusufi, though in Mutākṣarin, Tarikhi Bāngālā, and in the accounts of Mr. Holwel we do not find this incident mentioned. Gangārāma gives a great many facts about the Maharatta raids which will be found interesting to the readers of the history of Bengal.

3. *Samser Gazir gan.* This poem, which runs through 4,000 couplets, describes the life and achievements of Samser gazi who was originally a robber, and who grew so powerful as to dethrone a king of Tippera and proclaim himself its chief for a time. Samser gazi lived 200 years ago, and the poem commemorating his exploits is sung by the rustic folk of Tippera to this day. It is said that Samser used to carry the vast riches, he obtained by looting, to the depths of the jungle in the Udayapura hills. He would then dismiss the carriers and with the help of a carpenter make deep cavities in the trunks of large Çāl trees, where he stored his hoards, and after carefully closing them up with blocks of timber, and effacing all marks of the work, he would cut off the head of the poor artisan, thus removing all chances of detection.

In this way absolute secrecy was secured. It is said that even now stray wood-cutters, while applying their axe to the trunks of Çāla trees in the deep forest, sometimes unexpectedly find themselves in possession of treasure stored up there by the famous robber. The Samser Gazir gān was composed shortly after his death.

4. *Chaudhuri's Ladai*, a poem describing the fight between the two Zeminders, named Rājanārāyaṅa Chaudhuri and Rājachandra Chaudhuri. The fighting took place at Babupur, seven miles to the north of Noākhāli, about 100 years ago, when British rule was not yet settled in that quarter. Rājanārāyaṅa was the more powerful of the contending rivals. He is said to have founded a town by cutting down a great jungle which had belonged to Sindur Kāzi. The town was called Rājagānja. The author of the poem was a Mahomedan, as appears from his preliminary verses in prāise of Khodā. There is an interesting account in the poem, of Rangamālā, a beautiful damsel who is said to have played an important part in the affairs.

Chaudhuri's Laḍai.

5. *The Raids by Kookis of Hill Tippera on the villages of the plains.* This poem was written about a century ago, and is still reproduced from memory by many old men of the Tippera district.

Raids by Kookis.

6. *Dara Sekh.* This is a poem by Dvija Rāma Chandra. It gives an account of the misfortunes of the Prince Dārā, the eldest son of Jāhāngir.

Dārā Sekh.

7. A poem on *Pratapa Chand* who claimed the the *gadi* of Burdwan, by Anup Chandra Dattā, an inhabitant of Çrikhanda. The peom was written in 1844 A.D.

Pratāpa Chānd.

Short historical treatises.

There are numerous small poetical treatises, written about a century ago, describing the flood of the Dāmodara and its devastating effects on the villages of Birbhum ; and on Bābu Rājkumar Sen of Kirtipaçā who died of poison administered to him by Kiçore Mahālānavis, his Dewan, and on various other subjects of minor importance. The poem on the flood of the Dāmodara was written by Napher Chandra Dās in 1823.

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(6) Metaphysical and other works.

Māyā Timira Chandrikā.

1. *The Maya Timira Chandrika* by Rāmagati Sen, which I have already mentioned on page 682. is a work treating of the processes of Yoga. He begins the poem in the form of an allegory, much on the lines of the well known Sanskrit work *Prabodha Chandrodaya Nataka*. The poem begins as follows :—

*" The mind goes in a fit of anger to the soul—that Prince whose capital town is the body and whose palace is the heart ; false vanity is his

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*" কোপে অতি শীঘ্রগতি মন চলি যায় ।
যথা বসে নানা রসে সদা জীবরায় ॥
তনু যার সুবিস্তার দিব্য রাজধানী ।
হৃদি তারি রমাপুরী তথায় আপনি ॥
অহঙ্কার হয় যার মোহের কিরীটী ।
দম্ভ-পাটে বৈসে ঠাঠে করি পরিপাটী ॥
পুষ্পচাপ উগ্রতাপ লোভ, অনিবার ।
দুই মিত্র সুচরিত্র বান্ধব রাজার ॥